DECLUTTER YOUR HOME, CALM YOUR LIFE

A Room-by-Room Guide to Simple Living, Organized Spaces, and Stress-Free Daily Routines

ALEX LEE

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

PHASE I: THE FOUNDATION & MINDSET

Introduction: The Journey to a Calmer Life 3

Chapter 1: The Decluttering Mindset - The Power of Permission 11

PHASE II: BUILDING THE ACTION PLAN

Chapter 2: Building the Foundation - Systems That Stick 25

PHASE III: ROOM-BY-ROOM TRANSFORMATION

Chapter 3: Entryway - First Impressions of Calm 53

Chapter 4: Living Room - Comfort and Order 63

Chapter 5: Kitchen - Function, Flow, and Calm 79

Chapter 6: Dining Area - Gathering Without Clutter 95

Chapter 7: Home Office - Productive, Focused, and Clear 107

Chapter 8: Bedrooms - Restful and Organized Retreats 117

Chapter 9: Kids' Rooms - Fun, Order, and Independence 131

Chapter 10: Closets and Hidden Storage - Out of Sight, Not Out of Mind 145

Chapter 11: Bathrooms - Clean, Functional, and Stress-Free 159

Chapter 12: Laundry Room - Simplifying Chores 169

Chapter 13: Garage or Basement - The Final Frontier 179

PHASE IV: SUSTAINABLE LIVING AND MINDFUL EXPANSION

Chapter 14: Maintenance Routines - Keeping the Calm Alive 193

Chapter 15: Mindful Living - Beyond the Physical Space.....205

A NOTE FROM ME TO YOU 219

Appendix.....221

Companion Resources 221

About The Author 223

PHASE I

THE FOUNDATION & MINDSET

INTRODUCTION

The Journey to a Calmer Life



Let me start by saying you are not alone, and you're not failing at being an adult.

If you're reading this book, chances are you've had some of the following experiences in your daily routine. You enter your home and, looking around your entryway, you see shoes in disarray around the doorway, children's jackets on the floor, a pile of mail awaiting attention. The garage can't house the car because you have sports equipment, camping gear, and even a baby stroller that belonged to your now five-year-old. Your kitchen counter is full of appliances—an air fryer, a coffee maker, a toaster, a pressure cooker, a kettle—and another stack of mail. In every room in your house, there appears to be just too much of something. (I'll call it "stuff" for now.) You reflect on your friends' homes. Everyone else seems to be more organized and less cluttered. Maybe you tried to get organized in the past. You bought bins, labels, and baskets, but went back to where you started six months later.

Well, this is what you should know: the problem is not you. It has never been about you.

Clutter is not a flaw in your character; you're not lazy or messy. It's the result of busy professionals, parents raising kids, and people trying to do too much with too little time. Beyond that, most

of us live in a culture where we're pushed to want more, and the overwhelm comes from managing endless amounts of stuff.

Most of us have accumulated too much, but the stuff isn't the core problem. Many items at home have a story. They could be tied to guilt, obligation, hope, memory, or identity. Do you feel obliged to keep gifts though you don't need or want them? Is it because someone special gave you that shirt or sweater? Do you have a special set of dinnerware that you might use someday but haven't in the last three years? Do you keep baby clothes for the memories?

This is why you can't just toss the stuff in the trash. You need to tell the stories behind the objects. You need to acknowledge what they represent, what gave rise to them, before you can be ready to part ways. This is what human beings do.

Scientifically, clutter has a measurable effect on your mind and body; the visual chaos of having too much stuff increases your cortisol—a stress hormone. As you walk in through your entryway, look at your garage, or sit in your kitchen, your brain is processing (or trying to process) the visual stimulus. And because there's too much information, too much stimulus, your brain can't fully relax and is in a constant state of low-level alertness.

Over time, this stress builds up and affects your mood, sleep, patience, and ability to focus on your work and health. Primarily, this is more about wellness and having peace of mind and improved quality of life. Secondly, you get the benefits of a prettier home. Decluttering is more than just organizing; it is a pathway to the practice of wellness.

Let me make you a promise. If you take the step to work through the guidance of this book with intention and consistency, there will be meaningful change. You will still be who you are, but you will utilize more effective systems.

A simplified home can provide many benefits:

- **Mental clarity and reduced stress**: An uncluttered environment will support your brain. You'll be able to think more clearly, make decisions, and feel less overwhelmed. If you feel like you've been living in a foggy, scattered state, it may be due to the environment. This will change.
- **Better sleep quality**: When your bedroom becomes a peaceful sanctuary, you'll fall asleep more easily, sleep more deeply, and be more rested. This will only happen when your bedroom becomes a sanctuary, not a storage unit.
- **More time and energy**: Your time will not be spent managing the excess. How many times have you lost your keys or phone at home? Worse, how long did it take to find them, and what was the time spent over the course of the year? There are things that matter, and those deserve your time rather than constantly searching for your keys.
- **You will build stronger relationships**: You'll have energy to be present. Your brain won't be distracted by the clutter during conversations. You can have guests over because you don't need to tidy up before they arrive. There will be no need to stress before entertaining.

Before getting there, you need to change your mindset about what decluttering really is. The truth is, decluttering is not really about stuff. It is understanding our relationship with the stuff.

Most think of this as an organizational problem. Ironically, they think they need to develop a better approach and buy more stuff like storage solutions, a bigger closet, or bins and containers. They watch videos, try different methods, and nothing works because they're treating the symptoms and not addressing the root cause.

So, what is the problem? You don't need to organize better; **you need to own less**. Once you arrive at that conclusion, everything

becomes easier. You don't need an organizational system to organize twelve pans; you need to get rid of seven and keep the five that you use. You don't need an elaborate closet solution; you need to get rid of the clothes you haven't worn in two years. Some don't fit, some are no longer in fashion, and some you don't like. It really is that simple.

This is radically different from what the organizing industry wants to sell to you. They make money when you buy products to organize your stuff. They don't make money when you reduce your stuff to the point that you don't need their products. But I'm not selling you organizing systems. I'm offering you freedom.

Throughout this book, I'm going to give you one question that cuts through all the guilt, all the "what ifs," and all the mental gymnastics we use to justify keeping things. Here it is: *Does this item serve my life as it is right now?* I'm not referring to the life you wish you had or that person you hope to become someday. Your life. Right now. Today. The life you're living with, the person you actually are.

This question will serve as your true North Star. If you pick up an object and you feel a sense of paralysis, then ask yourself the following question: Does this item serve my life right now? A variety of thoughts might permeate your mind: "I might need this," "I spent good money on this," or "Auntie gave me this." These thoughts simply cloud your judgment.

If the answer is no, it doesn't matter what it costs, who gave it to you, or how long you've been keeping it. If it doesn't serve your actual life, it's clutter, and clutter has a cost. It costs you space, energy, time, and peace.

Now, I know what some of you are thinking. It's something like, "I don't want a minimalist house with three articles of clothes and a few pieces of furniture." This is not that; it's not deprivation or perfection. It's creating a home that is functional, that supports

your life and allows you to breathe. For some, that may mean a very minimalist space. For others, it might mean a cozy, lived-in home full of beloved books and meaningful art that just happens to be free of excess. The goal is freedom, not emptiness.

Our process has four phases, and we'll move through these phases in order because the order is important. Currently, we're in **Phase I**, which focuses on our attitudes and beliefs, exploring why we hold on to things and giving ourselves permission to release them. This is a crucial first step. If it's bypassed, the emotional toll of decluttering could cause you to give up and cause the clutter to reaccumulate in a year.

Phase II is about building the decision systems and a workable roadmap. This will help to avoid decision-making fatigue and keep your efforts on track. You're going to learn frameworks that make it easier to make decisions consistently, with a clear order for addressing the cluttered spaces. This is the infrastructure that separates those who will succeed from those who throw up their hands halfway through the process.

Phase III is where we'll go through your home, room by room, and apply our decision systems. This is the part where we really start decluttering. It's the longest and most demanding phase; however, this is where we see the results. We start with easier areas to build quick wins, confidence, and momentum. We'll save the hardest spaces for when you're prepared and capable of the challenge.

Phase IV is about maintaining what was built through the creation of routines to keep the house in order long after the book has finished. We'll look at ways to prevent the return of clutter and broaden these concepts in your life.

Before we dive into any of that, we need to talk about why this matters to you specifically. If you don't connect with why you want this change, you will lose steam or give up when things get hard.

There will be times when you're there holding your grandmother's china that you have never used and will probably never use and feeling like the worst person in the world for even considering donating it. There will be moments when you're exhausted and just want to shove everything in a closet and be done. There will be moments when you question what you're doing and whether it's worth it.

Your "why" is your anchor, and it's what will help you get past those moments.

Maybe your "why" is wanting to stop getting angry with your kids over the mess. You want to change this situation, but the current environment makes this impossible.

Maybe it's the hesitation of hosting because you're embarrassed about how your home looks. You want to be able to be a spontaneous host without going through panic cleaning.

Maybe it's about the endless cycle of cleaning and organizing that never seems to work. You restore order on the weekend, and by mid-week, the chaos has returned.

It could be something different, like retirement, divorce, or becoming an empty nester. A life shift can make it clear that time is too precious to be managing stuff. Whether it's a new home or a new chapter, the impact of the decision not to carry clutter with you can be immense.

Whatever your "why" is, it matters. It's what will help you power through this process. So, pause now to get a clear view of this, not a general reason like "to be more organized" but a specific, tangible reason.

Close your eyes and picture your decluttered home six months from now. What does it look like? More importantly, what does it feel like? How do you feel when you walk through the door? What becomes possible that is not possible now? What changes would there be in your daily life?

Get specific. Paint the picture. Feel the feelings. This vision is your North Star.

This is not about having a perfect home; you're not out to impress but to create a home that works for you and makes your life easier.

This is not to lay blame on yourself or judgment on others. You are not a bad person for having clutter. The people who contributed to it—the gift-givers, family who passed down stuff—are not bad either. We're all doing our best.

This is not about speed. This is not a weekend project. Real, lasting decluttering takes time and will go on for months. But this is okay as long as you are moving towards your true North Star. You're doing this for yourself to create more space for what brings you joy, comfort, and meaning.

This is about reclaiming your home, your time, and your energy. You want to create that space, both physical and mental, for what matters. This is about setting boundaries with the stuff, the commitments, and the pressure to acquire more.

The journey ahead will ask you to be honest about what you use versus what you think you should keep. It will ask you to feel some uncomfortable emotions: grief for money spent, guilt about gifts, disappointment about aspirational items. It will ask you to make many decisions, which is genuinely exhausting.

I promise that in return, at the end, on the other side of this process, you're going to walk into your home and feel peace instead of stress. You're going to find what you need without frantic searching. You're going to have mornings that don't start with chaos and evenings that don't end in exhaustion. You're going to have mental bandwidth for what matters, such as creativity, connection, rest, and joy.

That's worth some temporary discomfort, isn't it?

Take a deep breath. Look around at the space you're in right now. See it for what it is. It is not a judgment on you but simply

the current state of things. Your home is currently cluttered. That's a description, not an indictment. And know that this state is not permanent. You have the power to change it, and here is how we're going to do it.

We're going to do this together by giving you the frameworks, the systems, the strategies, and the permission. You're going to bring your commitment, your honesty, and your willingness to do the work. Together, we're going to transform your home and, in the process, transform your daily life.

Let's begin.

CHAPTER 1

The Decluttering Mindset - The Power of Permission



Have you ever stood at the door of your closet holding a sweater that you haven't worn for as long as you can remember? You're debating whether you should keep it or donate it. I refer to this as "decluttering paralysis." This is the feeling of being in a state of limbo. You know deep inside that you need to let this item go, but somehow you're unwilling or unable to do it emotionally.

Most conclude that this stumbling block is about being indecisive. They might think they are "bad decision makers" or "too sentimental." This is not the case; it's not about your character. Your brain has natural barriers that are stopping you from deciding, and these must be addressed first.

This truth changes everything and allows you to see from a different point of view. Often, clutter is the accumulation of past promises. You believe that these items would help you become a different person. The blender was going to make you consume more vegetables. The running shoes would make you a runner. Buying

the guitar was going to make you musical and appreciate music. Did it happen?

When the intended transformations don't happen, these items are assumed to be evidence of failure. This "stuff" serves as a reminder of what you thought you wanted to be. With that, it becomes even harder to release these items because if you do, it's like admitting failure.

But your identity is not driven by the purchase of an item. Buying something is not the same as *being* something. The items didn't fail you, and you didn't fail either. Our consumer culture is trying to sell us stuff that's supposed to make us happier. If you buy these running shoes, you'll become a runner. If you buy these containers, you'll be organized. Material possessions do not change us; our actions initiate change. Habits and choices change us, but purchasing things does not change us.

Once you see the world of clutter through this perspective, through this lens, then something shifts. These are not items you might use someday. These are anchors that represent unfulfilled expectations. These items can be released because they never had the power to deliver the promise you instilled in them. If you're not a runner, those shoes were not going to make you a runner.

Let's talk through the specific emotional barriers that keep you stuck because once you identify them, you can move on.

The Scarcity Mindset

There's a voice in your head that's saying, "What if I need this someday?" You think letting go means you won't have it when you need it. Later, you might kick yourself for having thrown away or donated it. Perhaps you grew up in a time when money was tight, and you kept everything just in case it was needed someday. In the past, at least for some, there was less stuff and enough space for the

stuff; clutter was not an issue. Some may have learned that resources need to be hoarded to ensure survival. Now, though circumstances may have changed, those habits and practices are ingrained, and the neural pathway has been hardwired for this mindset.

The scarcity mindset shows up as statements like "It still works!" But it is never used. "I might need this." But you never needed it in years. "I paid good money for this." But the money is a sunk cost; it's gone whether you keep it or not. (Of course, some items could be resold for money. That will be discussed later.)

The reality is that, most often, the "someday" never arrives. On the off chance you need an item after it's donated or trashed, you could almost borrow, rent, or even buy it at a lower cost than storing it for years.

Think about storage costs. This extends beyond the dollar value. If it takes up space in the garage, maybe there's no room for your car. Even an unused space is worthwhile because it gives you some breathing room. Also, think about the mental cost. If you keep something you might need someday, it occupies space in your brain. You must remember where you put it on the off chance you might need it. It's not one item you must remember; it's the multitude of items you're keeping. This creates cognitive overload and is exhausting.

The antidote to scarcity is abundance. We're not pretending you have unlimited resources, but we live in a world where things are generally available when you need them. You can borrow a whisk if yours breaks. You can borrow a ladder for the off chance you might need it. You can rent a carpet cleaner if you need it. You can solve problems as they arise.

Here's an experiment. What's the worst thing that would happen if you donated an item you later needed? You could borrow it, maybe buy it again. Maybe you could accomplish the task differently without that item.

When you follow the scarcity mindset to its conclusion, you'll discover you may be occasionally inconvenienced. This inconvenience can be solved and is a small price to pay for a less cluttered home.

Objects as Memory Proxies

This is perhaps the most emotional barrier. You keep your grandmother's chinaware because it was handed down or gifted to you. You don't like it, it's not your style, you would not use it. However, if you donate it, it's like letting go of your grandmother. You keep your children's baby clothes because the onesies are so cute; they represent a precious time that has passed.

These objects feel like they are holding or containing memories. You feel that if you lose the object, you lose the memory. Here's the gentle truth: the memory is inside of you, not contained in those objects.

Your grandmother is not inside the chinaware. The love you have for her, your memories of her, and the impact she had on your life are all contained in you. The memories are in your values and stories and within your DNA. We see this in the phrases you use and the way you cook certain foods. A physical object can trigger a memory, but it's not the memory itself. If the chinaware is stored in the highest cabinet within a box, it will never serve as a memory trigger.

You will still remember your grandmother if you donate the chinaware. The baby years will still be there if you keep five items rather than forty. The past remains within you, while the objects are just objects.

Sometimes, it makes sense to keep half a dozen items you like and want to display. These items can serve as a memory trigger if they are honored, cherished, and visible. If you keep forty items, it's not honoring them; it's storing them.

Let's talk a bit about curating. Did you know museums have vast storage facilities filled with items that most visitors will never see? If they displayed everything, it would overwhelm people. Instead, curators thoughtfully select the most representative and impactful pieces.

You can do the same with your sentimental items: you can be the curator. Choose those that are the most meaningful, most useful, and let the rest go. It's not dishonoring the people or memories; it's the opposite. Now, you'll be giving the more significant items the space and attention they deserve.

Take a bold step with your keepsakes and set a quantifiable limit. This is a personal decision. It could be one storage bin, one box, one shelf. *You* must define it, but make it concrete. This forces curation. You choose the most meaningful rather than keeping everything out of guilt, fear, or indecisiveness.

If you have unlimited space, then everything is "meaningful," and you can sidestep making choices. However, when you must choose, you distinguish between what is precious and what is just old. This is a valuable process as you internalize what truly matters to you.

The "Good Host" Pressure

Do you have extra sheets ready for guests? How often do you really have guests who stay over? Do you have a drawer or box of toiletries in case your guest forgets to bring their toothbrush or toothpaste? Do you have place settings for fifteen people when you normally serve five?

This is sometimes referred to as "good host" pressure. Some people, through their upbringing, have been conditioned to prioritize guest comfort over themselves. Our homes have been transformed into hotels for guests who rarely come.

Here's a bit of a reality check: hospitality is about making guests feel welcome, comfortable, and cared for. Your guests don't need a memory foam mattress topper or four types of breakfast cereals. They would much prefer that you are present, relaxed, and happy to see them rather than exhausted from maintaining a museum of "just in case" items.

Reminisce about the best hosting experience you've had. Why was it special? Do you remember the sheets or an extra toothbrush? Or is it perhaps staying up and talking, laughing, feeling wanted? Good hosting is establishing a presence with your guests; it's not about the stuff.

If a guest needs to sleep on an air mattress, it will be fine. They will survive. They might need an extra sheet, but not four. If they forget their toothbrush, lend them the spare.

Adjust your hospitality items to reflect reality. If you expect guests four times per year, then plan for that. Don't prepare for every contingency or scenario. That just creates anxiety.

The Preparedness Paradox

This barrier says, "I need to keep these items because I might need them in an emergency." The irony is that, in an emergency, you could not possibly find the items you need among the multitude of items you own. Keeping too many items makes us less prepared.

Being prepared is not about quantity; it's about having a reasonable amount of the essential items in logical and accessible places. It's not about having flashlights scattered throughout the house, but having two flashlights in a designated location where anyone can access them as needed. It's not about having forty cans of soup. It's about having a week of nonperishable food you can rotate through.

This paradox shows up in first aid supplies stored in different closets and drawers throughout the house. During an emergency, you find yourself moving from closet to drawer looking for pills, only to find out they've expired. Alternatively, you go to access the batteries and find that they no longer work.

In your preparations, organize the supplies intentionally and with purpose. One well-organized and fully stocked emergency kit is more useful than an eclectic mix of emergency supplies dispersed around the house. Prioritize quality and accessibility over quantity.

The Aspirational Item Framework

Let's shift focus to aspirational items, as this is the category that derails many. Aspirational items are those you keep for the "future you." This could be you, "the chef," the version of yourself who cooks fancy meals with the cookware you acquired but never used. This could be you, "the camper," the version of you who's collected camping gear but never gone camping. This could be you, "the athlete," the version of yourself with all the equipment to play a sport that never quite became part of your routine.

These items do not serve a purpose; they are actively harming you. When you see these items, they remind you of a gap between your current self and your visions of what you want to be. They're whispering, "You're not there yet" or "You're not good enough."

So, here's the framework. Have you taken steps toward these goals or aspirations in the past six months? If the answer is "No," then these items aren't triggers for change. These items are aspirational.

If you want to be a painter, you need to attend class or set aside time to paint. The painting materials you bought are not making you a painter. If you want to be a hiker, you should go on a hike with others or by yourself. The hiking boots do not make you a hiker.

The counterintuitive truth is that when you let go of aspirational items, oftentimes it frees you up to pursue your real passions. You'll no longer be weighed down by guilt or aspiring to be someone you're not. Instead, you can be honest about who you want to be. Sometimes you might arrive at the conclusion that you didn't want that thing at all; you just thought you wanted it.

So, releasing those aspirational items will give you permission to be who you really are. You'll be able to live the life you want to live. The real you deserves a supporting home, not a home cluttered with the debris of your imagined lives.

Before moving forward, notice that we haven't touched a single item yet. The work thus far has been internal work, shifting your mindset and reframing. This work is equally as important as the act of physical decluttering and arguably more so. The reason is that if you try to declutter without addressing emotional barriers, you'll either give up or end up reaccumulating more the following year.

Don't worry—the physical work is coming. We'll use decision frameworks that eliminate decision fatigue. We'll create systems to keep from backsliding. Our approach will have us go through each room systematically.

Your current focus should be to reflect on these ideas. You'll want to notice which emotional barriers resonate with you. Is it the scarcity mindset? The memory proxy trap? Good host pressure? The preparedness paradox? You could have more than one barrier. Observe how you feel about each of these barriers.

Permission to Let Go

Let's move on to the antidote of permission. We live in a society where we're conditioned to acquire, not to release. We're constantly encouraged to buy, collect, and accumulate. When we have too much, we go rent storage space, we upsize to a bigger house, and we

have guilt when we downsize. So, I give you permission to release without reservation.

- **You have permission to let go of gifts you don't want.** You've received gifts to make you happy, whether for birthdays, holidays, or weddings. If you're not happy when you see the gift, that's a problem. The gift has already served its purpose; it was given in love. You don't need the object to remain in the house forever; the love was still real.

  When you receive a gift, it's yours, as the ownership has been transferred. Once you own it, you can decide its fate. If you keep something out of obligation, it doesn't honor the giver; it clutters your home and weighs on your conscience. There is someone out there who would like it and has a use for it. That would honor the spirit of the gift.
- **You have permission to let go of items that represent past stages of your life.** You're free to transform into the version of yourself that you want to be. Do you have the same hobbies now as you did twenty years ago? Do you have new interests now? Why hold on to the old when your style is evolving? The items that served you in the past don't need to serve you now.

  Your scrapbook supplies—are you using them? If not, give them away to someone who is engaged in this passion. How about your formal clothes? Are you now working remotely or semi-retired? Consider paring down the formal wardrobe as a compromise. It's not wasteful but honest. It frees up space for now and makes space for what might be coming.

  You're allowed to change. You're allowed to outgrow hobbies, evolve your style, and move on from old dreams.

- **You have permission to let go of regretful purchases.** The sunk cost fallacy is the belief that if you spent money on something, you must keep it to justify the expense. The money is already spent; it's a sunk cost. Keeping the purchase doesn't give you the money back. It's just a memory of the money you spent on the object.

  When you look at your exercise bike or your treadmill, if you don't use it, you feel bad. It will punish you if the item is not being used. Let it go. Release yourself from the punishment and reclaim your space and peace.

  As you begin to discard, donate, or sell items, patterns will begin to emerge. You'll observe that you've made impulse buys and how you fell victim to marketing gimmicks. With this insight, you can be better prepared for the future.

- **You have permission to let go of things you're keeping out of guilt.** We've accumulated family heirlooms, wedding gifts, items from deceased relatives. Guilt is a common but not good enough reason to sacrifice your living space and peace of mind.

  If you've inherited items from someone who passed on, you should focus on your relationship with that person—your grief, your love. Nothing is taken away by letting go of their belongings you now harbor. Your house is not a museum for their items. You can keep a few keepsakes you genuinely like and want to showcase, but the rest can be donated to those who want them.

Let's recap. You can create a home that serves your purposes right now. This includes letting go of anything that doesn't serve your life now. This is regardless of the cost of the items, who gave you the items, how long you've kept them, or what you thought you'd

become. You have permission and the right to define your own "enough." You can change your mind and disappoint others.

After all, this is your life, and this is your home. You decide what stays and what goes. It is not selfish, wasteful, or disrespectful. It is a liberation. This is the first step of the journey. You're ready to start.

PHASE II

BUILDING THE ACTION PLAN

CHAPTER 2

Building the Foundation - Systems That Stick



We've walked through shifting our mindset and giving ourselves permission to let go of items we don't want. Now, we'll build on the external systems that will carry you through this project. Your success in decluttering usually has nothing to do with your will or your desire and everything to do with preparation. You are here because you want to declutter.

You typically will not fail because you lack motivation or are undisciplined. Failure is more commonly caused by decision fatigue without a clear roadmap. If you start with the hardest space, you'll be overwhelmed because you don't have the system to deal with the items you want to discard. You need a good system, not the brute force of trying harder.

This chapter is about forming a decluttering infrastructure. We're going to create frameworks, gather tools, and design the sequence that will make the actual work easier and as smooth as possible. This phase might not feel like "real work," as you're not moving things into donation boxes or trash, but this is where the magic happens.

This will separate people who finish from those who give up halfway through with boxes of donations and "stuff" sitting in their garage in six months.

This chapter is about slowing down rather than jumping into declutter haphazardly. You might be thinking, "Just tell me what to do, and I'll do it!" or "Let's just get started, right now!" This is all understandable. But if you skip this preparation step, then most likely you will hit the wall, and the process will fail. You'll be standing in the middle of your living room with piles of stuff, paralyzed with decisions and at a loss. After that, all the stuff will find its way into storage boxes, and you'll conclude that decluttering does not work for you.

It's better to build the foundation and get to the end. This is my recommended approach.

Step 1: Know Your Starting Point

Before starting, you need to assess what you're working with. This is a data-driven assessment, not a judgment. You can't celebrate progress if you don't know your starting point. Neither can you implement an effective strategy if you don't understand the scope of the problem.

This is what you need to do in your whole home assessment. You should budget about forty-five minutes of uninterrupted time. You'll want to go old school with a notebook. I recommend an actual notebook because on the phone, tablet, or computer, you might get distracted. If you genuinely prefer an app to take notes, that's up to you. Take a physical walkthrough of each room in your house, including the garage, closets, and the attic.

For each space, you're going to record four pieces of information.

First, what's the current function of this space? This means the *actual* function of space rather than the *intended* function.

The spare bedroom might be intended as a guest room, but it is currently serving the function of a storage unit with a bed buried in boxes. Write this down and be honest. The dining room might be intended for family meals, but it's currently serving as a multi-purpose horizontal filing system for mail, homework, and random shopping bags. Write this down and acknowledge this reality. The garage was intended as a roof over your car, but the car is in the driveway because the garage is too full of stuff to fit a car. Write this down without judgment and be honest. You can't solve a problem if you don't acknowledge it.

Second, what are the specific problem areas? You need to write down the problem areas specifically. Don't use vague terms like "messy." Does the kitchen counter accumulate non-food or non-kitchen-related items? Does your linen closet have towels and linens overflowing so much that you must shove things back to make them fit? Is your bathroom drawer full of half-empty bottles and expired medications? Is the bedroom full of clothes on the floor where you drop things off each day? Be specific; name the problems. Vague problems are not helpful and create anxiety.

Third, how does this space make you feel? This is important, yet it might feel strange to document your feelings about a room. Does the entryway give you stress the moment you walk in? Does your bedroom make you feel more anxious than restful? Does your kitchen overwhelm you before you start cooking? Is your living room an embarrassment when someone stops by unexpectedly? Does your garage make you feel so overwhelmed that you don't want to enter it? Your emotional responses are an important barometer; they indicate which spaces are actively harming you and which are working well enough. This step helps you prioritize the spaces that urgently need attention.

Fourth, what do you wish this space could do for you? What is your dream for this space or that room? Do you want the kitchen

to be a place where cooking feels easy instead of a chore you dread? Perhaps you want your bedroom to be a place that helps you sleep better rather than a place of visual chaos. Maybe you want your entryway to be a place for your keys, coats, and shoes rather than a place of disarray. Maybe you want your garage to fit the car. Write down the vision, the dream, even if it appears impossible now—especially if it appears impossible now.

This is a multipurpose assessment. It provides a baseline to track progress. In three months, you'll be able to reference these notes and see concrete evidence about how far you've come. If you get discouraged in the process when you feel like nothing is changing, you can see proof that it is. This highlights places causing the most stress and might influence the sequence of actions. Some people need to tackle the most stressful place first to gain some relief. Others might focus on a smaller space, building success before moving on. This forces you to articulate what you want. The goal isn't really "I want to declutter." It's "I want to cook a meal without having to clean my kitchen first." It gives us permission to acknowledge that the current state does not work, without getting upset about it.

Post-assessment, you'll have a clear map of your starting point. Keep this. Don't lose it or throw it away. You'll want to reflect in three months and marvel at the transformation. Some have told me they get emotional when they look back because they have forgotten how bad things were at the beginning of their journey. This documentation is powerful.

Step 2: Set Your "Why"

We brought this up in the **Introduction**, but now we're going to get specific and concrete. A wish is not a goal. For example, "I want to be more organized" is a wish, not a goal. It won't sustain you when you're tired and overwhelmed and standing in your garage

surrounded by twenty years of accumulated stuff, trying to decide what to do with your ex-husband's golf clubs that he left behind in 2012.

You need something that's visceral and concrete, something you can lean on to pull you through the moments when the going gets tough. And make no mistake—there will be hard moments. There will be moments when you want to quit. There will be moments when it feels like it's too much. Your "why" is your anchor in those moments.

So, what does a good "why" look like? It's specific, it's tied to your actual daily life, and it has emotional weight. Let me give you some examples.

"Find my keys every morning without searching" is a good "why." It's specific, and you can picture exactly what this means. You can visualize walking through your home searching for those keys while your kids are late for school, you're trying to get to work, and the stress levels are rising. In contrast, you can see yourself quickly picking up your keys and everyone leaving the house in a peaceful manner. There's emotional weight to this vision. It's starting the day in control and feeling capable versus full of stress.

"Cook dinner without clearing clutter first" is another example of a good "why." Instead of spending time moving mail and random items and wiping things down before you can begin the cooking process, you want to be able to walk into a functional kitchen and begin.

"Have friends over without panic-cleaning for two days" is another good why. This is all about connecting and building connections without the state of your home isolating you from these relationships. You don't want to say or think "I'd love to have you over, but can we make it next weekend so I have time to clean?" but rather "Come over tonight! I'd love to see you."

"Get the kids out the door without morning chaos" is a good "why" for those with kids. It's about wanting to start the morning off without conflict. You don't want to be looking for homework, a permission slip, or some other missing item. It's about sidestepping that morning stress.

What do all of these have in common? They're about life, not about the stuff. They're about the moments that matter, the experiences you want to change, and relationships. They're about who you want to be and how you want to feel and not about the appearance of the home.

Your "why" might be different. Maybe you work at home and don't want to be distracted by the mess. Perhaps you're thinking about moving and don't want to transport the clutter. Maybe you want to prove that you can do this. It doesn't matter.

Write down your "why" physically, not just mentally, so that you can see it regularly. You can write a sticky note on your computer monitor or set a reminder on your phone. When you start, this will provide some self-motivation.

In this process, eventually you will hit the wall. You might be looking at sentimental items, paralyzed with decisions. After three hours, the room you chose to declutter looks the same or maybe even worse than when you began. That's the time to review your "why." Reconnecting with where you're coming from will give you the strength to keep going.

Some might try to abbreviate this step by not thinking through the "why," holding it in your head and not writing it down. Writing it down will be your true North Star in this journey.

Step 3: The Momentum Roadmap

One thing people get catastrophically wrong is that they start with the biggest problem first. The belief is that if they take out the biggest

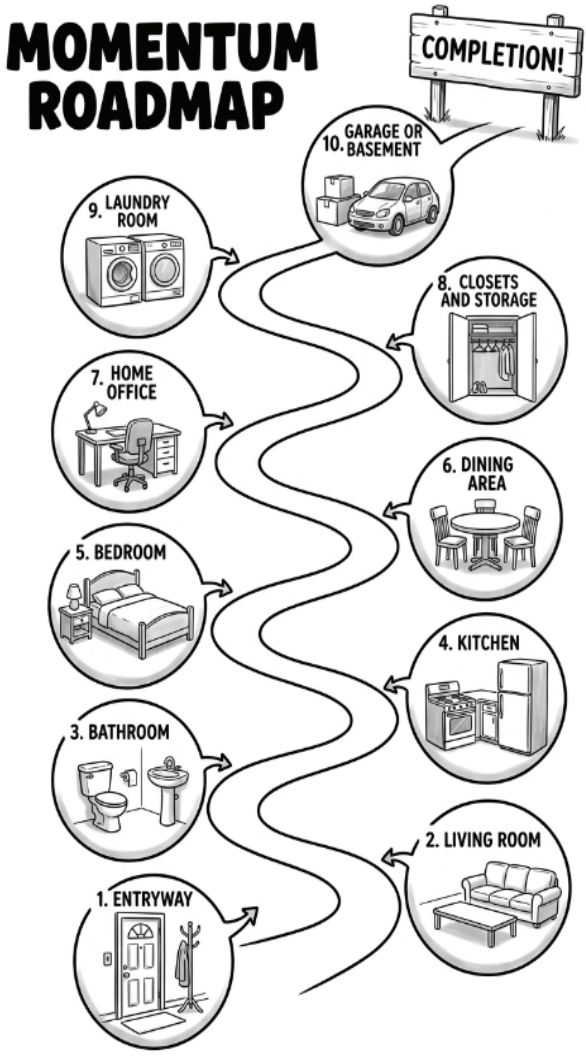
problem, everything else will be easy. Specifically, they dive into the garage, basement, or the spare room and tackle it first. Typically, these are the storage havens; the stuff there has been accumulating for decades. These are the toughest areas. If you start with these, most likely you'll be overwhelmed and quit. Shortly after you get started, you'll conclude that decluttering is too hard and quit. But you're not bad at decluttering. You simply started in the wrong place.

The secret is sequencing. Decluttering is strategic sequencing. It's choosing the order in which you tackle spaces and building momentum as you go, rather than killing it. It's not about avoiding the problem. You need to build up the skills and confidence to tackle the hard stuff when you get there.

An analogy might be going to the gym and working out. You don't go in on day one and start lifting the maximum weight. Similarly, you don't suddenly start running ten miles on the first day. This thinking and approach will be a disaster. First, you build strength; then, you develop proper form and gradually take up bigger challenges. This is the same with decluttering.

Start with spaces that give you quick, visible wins without destroying you. Try to alternate between hard and easy projects to prevent burnout. You want to save the overwhelming spaces for when your confidence and decision-making skills are at their peak.

Below is a recommended sequence. It can be adjusted, but this will generally be a good flow to follow: (note: this is a suggested order of priority, not the order the chapters appear in the book—jump to whichever chapter matches your next room):



Start with the entryway (1–2 hours). This should be a good first project because the space is small. Typically, there aren't sentimental items there, and it's highly visible. Usually, there's high traffic flow through the entryway, so as you and others walk through it, there will be evidence of your progress. The entryway is high impact because it is the transition between the inside and

the outside. A clear entryway will signal that you are home and safe, while a cluttered entryway assaults with chaos.

Next, tackle the living room (3–4 hours). The living room is a medium project. It has more stuff than the entryway—maybe some sentimental items like photos or books—but it's still manageable. This is likely the largest public space, and when done, you'll feel a shift when you walk into the room. It's where you spend a lot of time, so the benefits are compounded. When visitors notice it, this provides external validation and reinforces your motivation.

After a major project like the living room, give yourself a quick win with a bathroom (2–3 hours). The bathroom is a lighter project and can give you a quick win and a mental break. Though bathrooms are small, there's usually a lot of trash, such as expired medications, products bought but never used, or old cosmetics. You can complete this in one session without exhausting yourself. A clean and clear bathroom will make you feel capable.

Now you're ready for the kitchen (8–12 hours, probably split across multiple sessions). This is a major project and probably the single biggest project besides the basement and maybe the garage. You've built some momentum and confidence and know that the decision framework works. You have the mental muscle to make decisions without second-guessing yourself. The kitchen is used multiple times a day, so when it's decluttered, the work will be well worth the reward. A functional kitchen is profound. It affects what you eat, the time you spend preparing food, and the stress you feel around meals and cooking.

From here, move through bedrooms (4–6 hours per bedroom). Your bedroom is critical because it affects your sleep, and sleep affects everyone. Declutter your bedroom first to reap the benefits and then approach the other bedrooms. Kids' rooms might take 3-5 hours each, depending on your kids' age and the level of toy clutter.

The dining area comes next (2–3 hours). This can be a quick win area. The dining area doesn't typically have massive amounts of stuff; it just has the wrong stuff. For example, the dining room table might be a horizontal filing cabinet of mail, homework, and half-done projects. Attacking and reclaiming this space for the intended purpose will be significant, allowing for those family meals.

If you have a dedicated home office or workspace, tackle it next (2–3 hours). This step is optional—not every household has one, and that is perfectly fine. For those who do, this space is often not a massive project but usually has the wrong stuff in the wrong places. The desk has become a horizontal filing cabinet, cables have multiplied, and supplies have accumulated well beyond what any one person needs. Reclaiming this space for focused, productive work pays dividends every single day, especially for those working from home.

Then tackle closets and storage spaces (4–8 hours total, depending on how many you have). By now, you have the decision-making skills to attack the clothes, potentially a lot of clothes! But you're ready and well-equipped.

The laundry room is another relatively quick win (2–3 hours). This is a small space, and putting it into a functional, organized state makes the space work better.

And finally, only after you've built your skills and confidence through all those other spaces, tackle the garage or basement (12–20 hours). Like in *Star Trek*, this is the final frontier, the capstone project. Either the basement or the garage will likely be the biggest project and will take multiple sessions. You've already transformed your home and built up the stamina. The decision-making skills are there. This will mark the end goal of decluttering your home.

Can the sequence be adjusted? Of course. If your bedroom is a mess and affecting your sleep, then maybe move it up to third rather

than fifth. Potentially, your garage is somewhat tame, and the home office is a disaster. Adjust accordingly.

One more thing worth knowing: the chapters in this book aren't laid out in the exact order suggested above—they're organized to build your decision-making skills progressively, room type by room type. So don't worry about reading or working straight through from Chapter 3 to Chapter 13. Feel free to jump to whichever chapter matches your next room, in whatever order makes sense for your home and your energy that week.

The principle is still relevant regardless of the order. Start with moderate challenges, build momentum with visible wins, alternate between easy and hard projects, and save the biggest projects for when you've developed the skills.

A critical piece of sequencing is to finish the space or the room completely before moving on. Don't, for example, start decluttering the living room and advance to the kitchen without finishing the living room. This will result in a house in chaos because you don't know what mess to focus on.

When a room is decluttered, organize it and put systems in place. Then celebrate the win with a photo. Spend a few days enjoying the clear space. Let your brain process the feeling of completion, then move to the next space.

The approach outlined here gives you a series of victories instead of a war. Each space or room is a small battle that, when completed, is a win. Confidence builds with each win, making the next battle easier. By the time you tackle the basement or garage, you'll be a machine and will have made what seemed impossible manageable.

Step 4: Gather Supplies (But Don't Shop Prematurely!)

Here, we give a warning and say something to be emphatic and abundantly clear, as this is a common and costly mistake: DO

NOT BUY ORGANIZATIONAL PRODUCTS BEFORE YOU DECLUTTER.

Don't buy anything until you know exactly what you need. If there's a sale, even if there are nice baskets, don't buy them until you declutter and are ready to organize. This trap is so common. You might think, "I'm going to get organized, so I need storage bins, drawer dividers, closet dividers, baskets, and other things." After this, a few hundred dollars are spent. When the decluttering process finishes, you notice that you have much less stuff. The new organizational products are unused and add to the clutter themselves. This is somewhat ironic.

Very simply put, here is the rule: declutter first, organize second. Logically, you have no idea what storage solution you need until you know which items remain. You don't know what systems you want because you don't know what you're storing. After you've edited down the things that need to be stored, it's time to buy those items that serve your needs.

For the decluttering process itself, you only need the following:

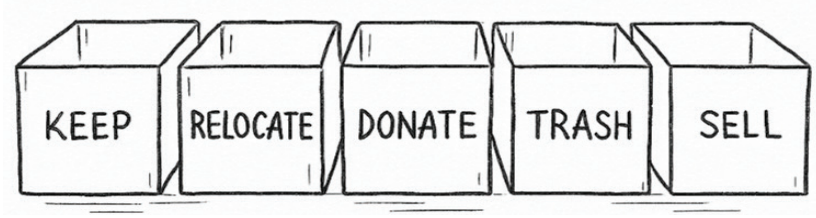
- **Large boxes or bins for sorting.** You can use anything you already have in the home to serve the purpose; these can be temporary items. Both cardboard boxes and laundry baskets work great. If you have four to five containers to set up the sorting station, that's plenty. (More to come below.)
- **Trash bags.** Gather regular and heavy-duty trash bags. You may have a concept of how much trash you'll identify, but you'll fill more bags than you expect. Those heavy trash bags will prevent the embarrassment of having something break open while being hauled to the curb or the trash.
- **Labels and markers.** These are to label the containers into categories, which we'll talk about later. You don't need anything fancy. A permanent marker with masking tape will be fine to create clear functional labels.

- **Cleaning supplies.** As you begin to declutter, you're going to reveal surfaces that have not been cleaned. As you move things off the table, clean it. Have some basic cleaning supplies on hand: all-purpose cleaner, soap and water, a rag or cloth, maybe a vacuum. These should be the normal cleaning supplies you commonly use, nothing special.

This is the list. Take note that there are no organizing bins. Resist buying more. Avoid this marketing trap. When you finish, you'll find you need fewer organizational supplies than you think.

Step 5: Set Up Your Sorting Station

Implementing the Five Container System will keep your current project moving forward without creating more chaos. If you don't use this system, you'll likely end up with piles of stuff everywhere with no clear path to process the items. This might cause you to abandon the decluttering ship as you become overwhelmed.



Here are the five containers that need to be labeled clearly:

- **Container One: Keep.** This container is for items you want to keep that belong in the current space or room being decluttered. These items just need to be organized or put away post-decluttering.

- **Container Two: Relocate.** This container is for items that you want to keep but belong somewhere other than the current space being decluttered, such as that storybook that ended up in the kitchen. They must be relocated.
- **Container Three: Donate.** This container is for items that are donation-worthy. They are gently used, decent, and functional and have some life to give someone else. Most of the decluttered items will end up in this bucket.
- **Container Four: Trash.** This is for trash—broken items, expired items, or things that are unusable. Items that are broken or have missing parts can't be donated. Don't burden others with garbage; just send those items to the trash.
- **Container Five: Monetary Recovery.** This is for high-value items that you want to sell rather than donate. The key is that these items need to be worth enough time to justify the effort of selling them. There should be a high bar of entry for this container.

Let's focus on the fifth container a bit more. A lot of people often get stuck on this point. You must realize that selling takes time and effort. In fact, some people do this as their job! Selling items involves taking good photographs, writing descriptions, listing them on a platform, pricing, communicating with buyers, and maybe shipping or arranging for pickup/drop-off. This represents a lot of time, effort, and coordination.

So, the real question is, what amount of money makes the time investment worthwhile? If you have a blender that you paid $40 for five years ago and you might be able to sell it for $10, is it worthwhile? The answer would be no; the time you would spend is less than minimum wage. On the other hand, if you have a designer handbag that might sell for several hundred dollars, then this could be a good trade.

You need to set a threshold of what you think the item can be sold for. The mental overhead of managing items for sale and the space they take up as they're waiting to be sold is not worth it for low-value items.

Also, you need to set a timeline for selling the item— maybe thirty days. You don't want the garage to become a consignment store. At this point, you're trying to declutter, not create a side hustle. You don't want to be sidetracked from decluttering into a side business.

Now, here's the rule that makes this entire system work: **full containers must be processed within one to two days.**

This is non-negotiable. This is the rule that separates people who finish from people who stall out. If your Donate container is full, it gets dropped off at a donation center within two days maximum. If your Trash container is full, it goes to the curb on trash day. If your Relocate container is full, spend twenty minutes walking around your house putting those items in their proper homes.

Why is this timing so important? Because if you let containers pile up, you create decision paralysis. You start looking at the mountain of stuff waiting to be processed and get overwhelmed. The momentum dies. Worse, you might start second-guessing your decisions. You'll go through the donate pile and pull things back out. You'll convince yourself you need that thing after all. You'll stall the whole process and end up right back where you started.

Process as you go. Keep things flowing out of your home. You want to keep the momentum alive and prevent a backlog. There's a psychological benefit to seeing the stuff move through the pipeline and making progress. When you drop off that first load of donations, you'll feel accomplished. You'll feel lighter. You'll want to keep going.

Another practical tip is to put the donation bags in the car. As you run errands, those bags are at hand to be dropped off. Make the

process as easy as possible to get items out of your house. The less friction in the process, the more likely you are to follow through.

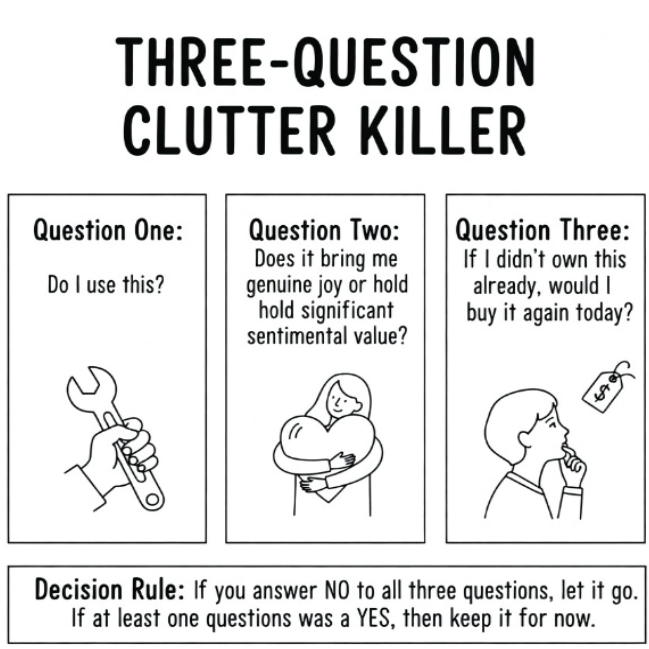
Set up your command center—the sorting station with your five containers—somewhere near the room you're working on, but not in the middle of your main living space. If you're working on the kitchen, maybe set it up in the garage or on the back porch if the weather permits. If you're working on a bedroom, maybe in the hallway. You want it close enough to be convenient (you don't want to be walking up and down stairs fifty times), but not so central that it's in everyone's way or creating visual chaos in a space you've already cleared.

Keep this sorting station operational and active throughout your entire project. You'll move it as you move from room to room, but the system itself remains consistent. This consistency eliminates decision-making; you don't have to reinvent the process for each space. You just work on the system. Touch an item, make a decision, put it in the appropriate container. Touch the next item, make a decision, put it in the appropriate container. The system creates a rhythm that makes the work almost meditative once you get into the flow.

Step 6: Deploy the Core Decision Systems

The heart of the problem is to decide what stays and what goes. You need a decision framework that can get through the emotional noise and allow you to make consistent choices. If you don't have a framework, each item will paralyze you with indecision, creating mental and emotional exhaustion.

To solve this problem, we have the **Three-Question Clutter Killer**. For each item you lay your hands on, ask yourself these three questions.



Question One: Do I use this?

This question is about today and now. It's not "might I use this someday" or "could I use this if the circumstances were different" or "I used this once three years ago." This question is simple: Do I use this item now in my life today?

Be honest. If you haven't used the item in the past year, you don't use it. There will be some exceptions, like seasonal items. Using items in the past is not the same as using them now. The possibility of using items in the future is not the same as using them now.

Question Two: Does it bring me genuine joy or hold significant sentimental value?

In this question, there are two key items: "genuine joy" and "significant sentimental value." Genuine joy is when you hold or see

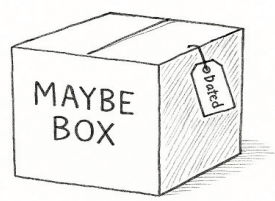
an item and your heart lifts, you feel happy, or you break into a smile. Sentimental items have a high bar attached to them. They refer to items that are truly meaningful. It is probably not that sweater you wore once to dinner; that does not make it sentimentally valuable.

Question Three: If I didn't own this already, would I buy it again today?

This question neutralizes the sunk cost fallacy by forcing you to evaluate the item based on its current value to you. The monetary cost of the item is removed, as well as the circumstances under which it was purchased. If you could acquire the item now, even for free, would you take it and bring it home? Are you willing to spend money on this item? Do you want to make physical room for it now?

If you answer no, then you have what you need to know. It's not useful to you, and it's just taking up space. If you answered all the questions negatively for the item, it should be released. If at least one question is answered positively, the item stays for the present. Here, we aren't looking for perfection but a reduction in clutter.

Sometimes you might stall out or hesitate over an item. Maybe it will be used again, or you're not sure if it has sentimental value. You don't want to waste time overthinking, so put this in the **Maybe Box**.



The Maybe Box must be for those genuinely undecided items. It should not be more than 10-20 percent of the items being evaluated.

This means about 80-90 percent of the items that follow the Three-Question Clutter Killer get a clear decision.

Place the undecided items into the box and label them with the current date in a way that can't be missed. Store the box in the basement or garage in a location where you won't see it on a regular basis. Set a calendar reminder for six months from the current date on your phone or other device. Now here's the critical step: when the reminder goes off, donate the entire box without opening it. You'll have the urge to open the box and go through it, but don't do it and don't second-guess yourself. Just walk that box over to the donation center and donate it.

Think about it. You put the box away for six months, and you didn't need to use any of those items. You probably didn't even remember that the box existed. Clearly, the box is no longer serving you. If you open that box, you'll restart the emotional decision-making process and go through a lot of mental gymnastics. Trust that in six months, you'll have the data you need to make the decision that you don't need the items.

The Maybe Box accomplishes two things. First, it allows you to make progress, preventing analysis paralysis from stopping your entire project. Second, it gives you empirical data about what you need versus what you think you might need. It turns a gut feeling into a data-driven decision.

Let's move on to the **Quantity Control Rule**. This addresses those categories that tend to accumulate in multiples, such as pens, spatulas, coffee mugs, towels, whatever tends to multiply at home.

For these categories, you need to do a bit of basic math and calculate the functional need. For example, if you're in a household of four people and everyone drinks coffee in the morning, then you need about eight mugs maximum. This means four are in use and the other four are spares.

If you cook regularly, you might have two pans on the burner at once. This means you might need a small saucepan, a large pot, a small skillet, a large skillet, and maybe something unique like a wok. You don't need more than this. This is your home, not a restaurant!

Think about your towels. Two to three per person and two for the potential guest should be sufficient. Generally, the laundry cycle should keep the towels replenished.

After you determine the reasonable quantity by category, choose the best quality of each category and keep those. You're curating and keeping the best while releasing the mediocre stuff that's taking up space and making it harder to find those things you use.

This rule is powerful and works because it's data-driven; it replaces vague decision-making with concrete numbers. You're no longer asking if you should keep a mug or towel. You already selected your favorite mugs or towels per person. So, the additional mug goes to the donation pile. Nothing more needs to be said.

The Quantity Control Rule works well for the following:

- Kitchen utensils
- Dishes and glasses (calculate based on household size, plus a few extras for guests)
- Towels and linens (2–3 per person, two sets per bed)
- Office supplies (one stapler, one tape dispenser, not one in every drawer)
- Cleaning supplies (one of each type)
- Toiletries (one backup, not a stockpile)

Generally, when you hit a category that tends to multiply, stop and do the basic math. Determine your realistic need and set that number as your maximum. Keep the best and release the rest.

Step 7: Establish Initial Sustainable Habits

Decluttering is an important first step in quelling the chaos, but the habits you build during the process may be even more important. If you wait until after you've decluttered everything to think about maintenance, you'll be starting from scratch on habit formation while also trying to prevent backsliding. That's going to lead to failure.

Instead, institute key habits right now, before you even start the room-by-room work. These habits will serve two purposes: they'll prevent new clutter from accumulating while you're working through your existing clutter, so you're not constantly fighting against fresh incoming stuff. And these habits will be so ingrained by the time you finish that maintenance will feel automatic rather than like a new challenge you must consciously think about.

Here are the three core habits to implement immediately, starting today.

Habit One: The Touch-It-Once Rule

This is the single most powerful anti-clutter habit you can develop, and it will change your life if you do it consistently. The rule is simple: when you touch an item, deal with it completely right then. Don't set it down in a temporary location with the intention of dealing with it later. Don't create a pile to "handle when you have time." Don't let things accumulate in transition zones.

For mail, this means opening it while standing by the recycling bin or shredder. Junk mail goes directly into the recycling; you don't even bring it further into your house. Bills get paid immediately or put in your designated action folder (which we'll set up). Invitations get responded to right then and either posted on a calendar or recycled. Important documents get filed immediately. The mail never makes it further into your house than the immediate entry

area, and it doesn't sit there longer than the time it takes you to process it.

For items you use throughout the day, this means they go back to their designated home immediately after use. The scissors go back in the drawer, not on the counter. Your jacket goes on the hook, not on a chair. The book goes back on the shelf, not on the coffee table. The cup goes in the dishwasher, not on the counter to be dealt with later. The tool goes back to the toolbox, not on the dining table.

This may feel like extra work at first. Your brain will resist it. You'll want to set things down "just for now" because you're in a hurry or you're tired or you'll deal with it later. But here's what happens when you push through that resistance and build this habit: you eliminate pile formation entirely.

Piles are what create visual chaos. Piles are where things get lost. Piles are what make you feel like you're drowning. Piles are what create the overwhelming feeling that your home is out of control. The Touch-It-Once Rule prevents piles from forming in the first place. It stops the problem at its source.

After about two weeks of consistent practice, this becomes automatic. You'll find yourself putting things away without even thinking about it. It will feel more natural to put something in its home than to set it down randomly. And the mental relief of not having piles accumulating is enormous. The visual calm is immediate. The time saved from not having to do massive cleanup sessions is significant.

Habit Two: The Nightly Reset

The Nightly Reset is a touch-up of the key living areas. This habit should be formed early and maintained; it should be ingrained into your system. It should be so ingrained that it's like brushing your teeth, regardless of your level of energy or how you feel. It would likely include the following areas:

Flat surfaces. This involves clearing flat surfaces before bed, including the kitchen counter, the coffee table, the dining table, and the entry table. Be sure to *clear* the flat surface, not just create a neat pile of stuff on it.

Relocation. This step involves returning items that have left their permanent spot and haven't been returned. The typical items might be remote controls, toys, shoes, and throws. All these things need to go back to their rightful place.

Touch-ups. Around the couch, straighten the cushions and fold the throws so your living room looks intentional rather than chaotic. This makes your space look organized and only takes a small amount of effort. In the kitchen, wipe the counter and clear the sink. The dishes should be washed and dried or loaded in the dishwasher. We all know it's demoralizing to wake up to a mess in the kitchen or the prior night's dishes before the day even starts. If the trash is full, then take it out. Don't wait until it overflows.

Each night, sometime before bed, spend about fifteen minutes resetting the main living spaces. The Nightly Reset takes much less time than having to do a deeper clean. The key, however, is consistency. This is a daily practice, not when things begin to pile up or when you have enough energy.

This process is instrumental in providing a sense of order and calmness before ending the day. There's a psychological benefit when you're in control of your environment. Some people find this helps them remove the mental load of something left undone.

Habit Three: The Sunday Basket (Optional but Highly Recommended)

This section focuses on the processing of paper. This could be the bills, mail, medical statements, or basically any paper item entering the household. For most households, this remains a constant

problem. It's more problematic for households with kids and less problematic for those who have gone paperless in some respects.

First, find a large, attractive bin that can hold a week's worth of paper. It needs to be attractive to be displayed in a convenient location. During the week, all paper enters the bin; there should be no other weekly paper deposited elsewhere. Set a reminder on Sunday to work through the paper items—paying bills, recycling, shredding, etc. The goal is to work through the entire bin.

This ensures that nothing is left on horizontal surfaces and your paper is processed in a timely manner. The bin will transform the paper into a manageable weekly task rather than a constant source of stress.

Summary

In this chapter, we explained the seven-step process. It began with the assessment, determining the "why," creating a momentum roadmap through strategic sequencing, gathering relevant supplies without buying organizational products, setting up the five-container sorting stations, and establishing the three foundational habits to prevent clutter from re-accumulating.

This is the infrastructure that drives a successful decluttering process. It separates those who finish from those who abandon the process and end up with half-sorted items and a house more in disarray than before.

Here, we haven't touched the stuff yet. We're building the framework that will make dealing with the stuff effective rather than overwhelming. This is planning, not procrastination, and is setting yourself up for success rather than just hoping for success.

When building a house, you don't start with the walls and the roof. First, you dig deep and lay the foundation, pouring concrete and letting it cure. It might seem like it takes forever and nothing is

happening, but you need the foundation. Otherwise, the building will soon collapse. Once a solid foundation is in place, it can withstand the storms and stress.

We have laid your foundation. Now you have a clear vision of where to start, how you're getting there, and where you're going. You have sequenced to build momentum instead of killing it by getting overwhelmed. There's a sorting system that prevents analysis paralysis. You have the habits that will prevent reaccumulation as you work. All the tools are now in place.

This is preparation and what it looks like. This is how you transform your home without burning out or giving up or magnifying your chaos. Now, finally, you are ready to start the real work. You're ready to go to each room, each space, and apply the systems and frameworks to transform your home from stress to peace.

Now the foundation is laid, the infrastructure is in place, and all the tools are there. You're not just hoping that it will work; you've created systems to make it work.

Before you begin, grab your free decluttering toolkit below. It includes everything you need to track your progress room by room.



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Now, let's go and create your new home.

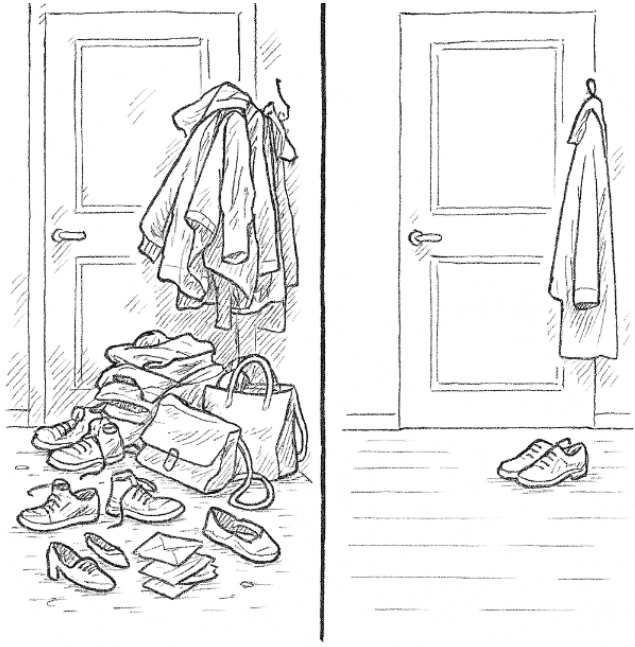
PHASE III

ROOM-BY-ROOM TRANSFORMATION

CHAPTER 3

Entryway - First Impressions of Calm

Time Budget: 1–2 hours
Impact: Immediate, visible transformation that sets the tone — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.



The Transition Space Principle

As we mentioned earlier, the entryway is the border between the outside and your home or sanctuary. If your entryway is cluttered, you feel like you haven't really arrived home. After a long day, you arrive through the door not to relief but to stress. Your brain takes note of any chaos in the vicinity. There may be unorganized shoes, unopened mail, bags on the floor awaiting an errand. All these items create stress upon arriving.

The entryway tends to set the tone for the entire home. When your entryway is cluttered, it gives the impression that things are out of control. Alternatively, if it is clutter-free, it makes you feel like the rest of the home is under control.

The entryway is a small space within the home, which means it can be transformed quickly. Typically, it will take one to two hours to transform the space. Remember, we're creating something that is functional, not perfect.

Step 1: Complete Removal

Remove all the items out of the entryway so you have a clear space. This implies that you are removing shoes, coats, bags, mail, and whatever else that can be easily moved.

A good starting item is shoes. They tend to accumulate in entryways because, each day, everyone kicks off their shoes and leaves them where they land. During the week, maybe a few pairs of shoes are worn, and before long, there's a collection of shoes at the entryway.

Remove the other common items like coats on the coat rack, accessories like scarves, hats, purses and backpacks, and shopping bags that belong in the car. If there's an entryway table or other furniture, remove its contents and things on the surface.

As you remove items, you might find things you thought you lost forever. There might be the jacket you thought you lost, gloves you replaced with another purchase. There might be a pile of mail that has been accumulating for weeks.

Once everything has been removed, take stock of the empty space. It probably feels bigger, and this is what happens when your entryway is not a storage unit.

Step 2: Quantity Limits

After you've cleared the entryway, you need to determine which items are returned to the entryway. The key is to limit the items that belong there; otherwise, the accumulation will start again, and you'll be back at your starting point.

Look at the shoes collected from the entryway. How many pairs of shoes do you have? How many pairs of shoes will you likely wear in the next few months? What season is it? For men, there might be one for exercise, one dressier pair for work or going out, and a casual pair. That's it—three pairs. Three pairs of shoes at the entryway would be appropriate for men. Women might have a few more depending on their circumstances. You have two feet, so one pair of shoes at a time is what you can wear. As you begin your decluttering, you might find sandals during winter or boots in the summer. Store the extra shoes and boots wherever you store seasonal items.

The same principle can apply to coats and bags. You have one body, so that means one coat at a time. At the entryway, each person can have one hook or space that will hold one coat and one bag. If you want to change your coat, then hang up the designated entryway coat in the closet and select another. This will force a decision rather than having the coats accumulate at the entryway. Some of you might be thinking, "What happens if it rains?" The answer is you swap out your coat. You don't need to prepare for all possibilities.

Clothing for other seasons needs to be relocated to proper storage. If you have a coat closet near your entryway, that's the ideal location. If not, coats can be stored in bedroom closets until needed. The entryway is for items in use during the current season; it is not storage for all contingencies.

These quantity limits are sensible and grounded in reality. Your entryway is typically small, so it holds a small number of items. With this boundary, the entryway can be organized with minimal effort.

Step 3: Ruthless Mail and Paper Edit

Your unopened mail is a deterrent to a clutter-free entryway. When mail is brought into the home, the pile quietly accumulates. The goal for this step is simple: zero mail remains in the entryway. There are no small piles, no items that are deferred for later. The entryway should not be the postal service.

Begin by going through the mail pile you may have identified and removed in Step 1. Set aside some time for this because, if mail has been accumulating for months, you want to give it due consideration. Open each piece and decide immediately. You have three options: trash, file, or action.

- **Trash** is anything that is useless to you. The typical items are junk mail, expired coupons, advertisements for services you don't want, credit card offers, and store catalogs you never look at. This will probably be 60 to 70 percent of your mail. Do not overthink these items or try to rationalize that you might look at these later; just trash them immediately.
- **File** is anything you need to keep for your records that doesn't require immediate action. Tax documents, medical records, insurance statements, receipts for major purchases—anything you might need to reference later. These items

go into whatever filing system you have for your home. If you don't have a filing system yet, create a temporary "to file" folder and deal with it when you set up your office or paperwork station.

- **Action** is anything that requires you to do something: bills that need to be paid, forms that need to be completed, invitations that need a response, and appointments that need to be scheduled. These need to go wherever you handle tasks like this. If you have a home office, they go there. If you have an action basket somewhere in your house, they go in that basket. At this point, the mail needs to move out of the entryway.

After you've processed your mail pile, you need to adopt a system that prevents the future accumulation of mail piles. These systems are essential for the organization of the entryway.

First, ensure there is a trash bin directly by the door. This allows you to sort mail immediately upon entry and throw away junk before it ever touches the surface.

Second, some choose to have a temporary holding spot for mail that requires action, such as a small file basket near the entry. (Refer to Habit Three: The Sunday Basket.) This basket must be processed weekly. Put a reminder in the calendar to process and empty it at that time.

Third, adopt the Touch-It-Once Rule for all incoming mail. You may remember from Phase II/Step 7 that this means handling it immediately. Open the mail and decide where it belongs rather than deferring it until later. In these cases, ensure that the recycle bin or shredder is ideally situated when the mail is being triaged.

This might sound like a lot of work, but it takes just a few minutes to open your mail, throw away the junk, and decide what to do with anything important. Compare that to the hours it takes to process

months of accumulated mail, not to mention the late fees from bills you forgot about or the opportunities you missed from invitations you never saw.

Step 4: Functional Zones Only

After you've gone through the steps of removal, quantity limits, and addressing your mail pile, you're ready to establish the functional zones of the entryway. The overarching idea is that all things have a designated space, and that space is determined by their function. Only the functional items stay in that location.

Your keys need one home, one designated spot. How many times have you misplaced your keys at home and turned the house upside down looking for them? When you come home, deposit your keys in the same spot. This could be a wall hook, a bowl on a table, a tray on a shelf, or a key rack mounted somewhere. You can choose the preferred location, but it should be obvious, accessible, and consistent.

We noted that for men, two or three pairs of shoes per person per season is sufficient. Those chosen shoes need a storage location. Typically, this might be a shoe rack or a bench with storage underneath. Even the bare-bones solution of a basket near the door or designated floor space near the entryway will work. The solution is secondary to the rule that only a set number of designated shoes belong in the entryway.

Your shoe storage solution will have a defined capacity. When it's full, you can't add shoes without first removing some to make space. This limitation is a built-in safeguard against the accumulation of shoes. When a shoe is promoted to the entryway, another should be "demoted" to the closet or wherever you store shoes. This promotes forced decision-making so that shoes don't pile up indefinitely.

Coats should follow the same rules. As suggested, each person should get one hook or one section of a coat rack. That space is for the coat currently in use. If you want a different coat, then demote that coat from the entryway to the closet and promote another coat to take its place. Don't add multiple coats on one hook. Don't drape your coats over furniture. There is one designated space at the entryway for coats.

It's common to have a small container for daily essentials like wallets, sunglasses, phones, earbuds, and maybe gloves. It's useful for these essential items to have a designated spot, but it's not a container to accumulate random items. You want to grab these as you exit the entryway and not spend time looking for them.

A common question might be, "What should *not* be in your entryway?" Simply put, anything that doesn't directly support the function of entering and leaving your home. Some common items people put in the entryway are store returns, items that belong to other people, and packages that need to be mailed. The list can go on. Your entryway is not a place to showcase your life. You transition at the entryway, so things that help you transition belong here.

As you encounter items that don't belong in the entryway, take them to their proper spot right away. Don't set them aside in another pile to deal with later. Escort them to wherever they belong, whether the bedroom, office, garage, or car. This immediate action prevents the accumulation of stuff that again becomes permanent.

The Clear Table Rule

If your entryway has a flat surface like a table or bench, you need to implement the Clear Table Rule. This rule simply states that the entryway surface must be completely clear before bed every night. This daily task maintains the space you created, preventing piles of stuff from accumulating again.

During the day, items will tend to land on your entryway surface. The mail might get set down as you hang up your coat and shoes. Someone will drop their bag there while bringing in groceries. A package that was brought in from the outside will sit there. This is normal and expected, but we don't want those items to accumulate and detract from our goal.

Sometime before bed each night, devote a few minutes to clearing that surface. You want to remove everything so you can start tomorrow with a clear space. The clutter stops before it has a chance to start. After clearing the stuff and returning everything to its rightful place, give the surface a wipe.

The entryway surface is a temporary landing zone; it is not a permanent location for anything. Landing zones are temporary by definition. Airplanes land and move to the gate; they don't remain in the landing zone. Items land briefly, then go to their proper homes. Anything staying in the landing zone for more than a day is a problem, and it doesn't belong there.

Your first inclination might be to make exceptions. "This package needs to go out tomorrow, so I'll leave it here to remember." Instead, put it in your car tonight. "These library books are due this week." Put them in your car now. They're going to the car anyway, so this is just speeding up the process. "This bill needs to be paid." Take it wherever you pay bills before going to bed.

The Clear Table Rule works because it eliminates decision-making; there can be no decision fatigue. There are no judgment calls about what stays or what goes. Everything is moved at night; nothing stays. This consistency creates a habit that runs on autopilot. You don't think; you just do. You don't have to decide. Just clear the surface, and your entryway stays organized and looks better.

Daily and Weekly Maintenance

By this stage, you would have created an organized and functional entryway. Until this point, it might feel like the prior steps were the challenge. The real challenge, however, is maintaining it. Maintenance works because small actions on a regular basis prevent big cleanups at a future date.

Daily maintenance maybe takes a few minutes before bed. (Refer to the Nightly Reset in Phase II.) Clear the entry surface completely and wipe it down. Hang up any coats and put away shoes that did not make it into their storage location. If there's mail, place it into the action basket or address it immediately. These actions, although small, prevent accumulation.

Weekly maintenance might take ten minutes. Address and empty your action basket. Check your shoe storage and demote any pairs that are out of season or not being worn; feel free to promote a shoe in their place. Review the coat hooks and make sure each person has only one coat hook and only one coat. No one should be taking over the hooks. Check the entryway for things that migrated there but don't belong. Take those extra items you find back to their proper homes.

Set up your seasonal maintenance to match the change in the seasons where you live. Change out your coats and shoes as needed. Bring the winter coats and boots forward when fall arrives. Store winter items away when spring comes in exchange for the raincoats and boots. Take an hour or so to reassess your systems. Are your quantity limits still valid? What, if anything, has changed about you that may impact your routine and the items that live in the entryway?

These maintenance habits are quite manageable. A few minutes daily, maybe ten minutes weekly, and an hour seasonally can keep your entryway functioning smoothly. What's the alternative? Compare that with the hours it would take to reorganize the space

from scratch every few months if it's not maintained. You would go through another major decluttering exercise.

Maintenance is about consistency; it's a habit. It's not doing it most nights, but then skipping it here and there. You can't do your weekly check some weeks and forget about it others. The instant you skip the maintenance is when things start to accumulate. It compounds quickly. Three days of skipped maintenance might mean a pile that takes more time to address than if you had just maintained it. A month of skipped maintenance means that, basically, you'll be starting over.

The entryway is a high-flow area where clutter accumulates quickly since everyone goes through the entryway. This is why maintenance habits are so important. They catch small problems before they get out of hand.

CHAPTER 4

Living Room - Comfort and Order



Time Budget: 3–4 hours
Impact: Most visible public space; affects the ability to relax — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

The Visual Chaos Problem

Typically, the living room is the place to unwind after a long day. This is the place where you sit down, kick your legs up, and relax. But if your living room is full of clutter, your brain doesn't relax. With visual clutter, you are constantly thinking about items that need attention, decisions deferred, and things lying in wait.

There are various categories of items that can create decision fatigue, even though you might be reclining. There may be books strewn about that need to be placed back in their home. Perhaps there are multiple remote controls on the coffee table. There might be a blanket or two on the couch. And, of course, the pile of unopened mail with a magazine sitting on top. These things force your brain to process them, causing a low level of stress or anxiety.

If guests visit, the living room is the one room they will likely see. You can close the door to the guest storage bedroom, and the garage can be avoided. But the living room is in full view and can't be readily sectioned off.

Often, the living room ends up being the repository for items that don't have a proper home. Things get set down "temporarily" but never move, and piles end up accumulating. There may be projects spread out across the coffee table or bags on the couch. Due to the central nature of the living room, items from other rooms just end up there. Over time, the living room becomes cluttered and filled with items that don't belong there. Your living room becomes a place where you can't truly relax.

Execution Strategy

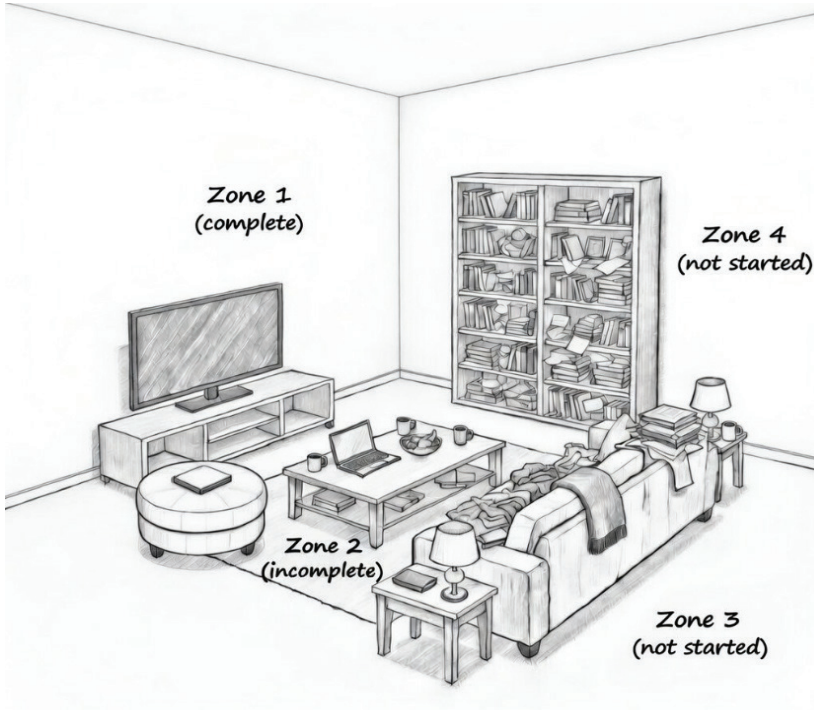
The living room is larger and has a wider category of items than the entryway, so we approach the living room with a different strategy. We emptied the entryway, but if we emptied the living room, we would quickly become overwhelmed. The technique is to work in zones, moving from one zone to another until complete.

Step 1: Zone-by-Zone Removal

Again, don't empty the living room in one shot like your entryway. You want to divide up your living room into zones and address one zone at a time. Some common zones are the entertainment area, bookshelves, coffee tables, side tables, and storage furniture.

Like our approach to decluttering the entryway, remove everything from one zone. All items get processed completely, not deferred for later. You need to make decisions on what stays and goes. Repopulate items that have been granted status in the zone, then move on to the next zone. Rinse and repeat. This disciplined

approach will prevent you from feeling overwhelmed. You'll see progress and quick wins you complete on a zone basis.



One approach is to choose the most impactful zone first. If the cluttered coffee table is an annoyance, attack that first. If your bookshelf is overflowing and giving you a headache, then start there. Generally, pick the zone that will have the greatest impact on the room to start.

Step 2: Category-Specific Guidance

As you work through each zone, your items will fall into different categories. There is a different decision framework for each category. Here's how we recommend approaching the most common categories in living rooms.

Books

Our books tend to be emotional items. They tend to represent our past or future vision of ourselves, but not necessarily our current selves. You might have an Italian language book because you wanted to learn Italian, but never did. You have a business book because you were going to start a side business. You have a few novels because you read them and might reread them sometime.

The key question to consider is: if you haven't read the book in the past two years, will you ever read it? Have you even *touched* the book in two years? The answer is usually no. Books take up a lot of space, and keeping them might not be serving you.

Keep the books you're currently reading. If there are books you consult based on your occupation or hobbies, then keep those. Don't keep books you *think* you should consult; these are aspirational. Maybe you have a few favorite books you might reread over time or hold special meaning for you. Keep those. Discard books you feel obligated to keep but don't really want.

Your book limit should be only what fits on your bookshelf. Do not double-stack. When you double-stack books, they are hidden behind other books, you forget about them, and they might as well not exist. You should be able to see every book you own and easily access any book you want to read.

Media (DVDs, CDs, Games)

Nowadays, if you want to find a movie or a favorite song, don't you find it online and stream it rather than referring to your physical media? If so, why do you still have your DVD player or your DVDs? When was the last time you put a DVD into that DVD player?

Consider the space the DVDs or CDs are taking up. Often, they take up the entertainment center. Is their space worth it?

Some people will have favorites or items with sentimental value that they want to keep, such as the DVD collection of family videos or vacations. If you have a favorite movie you watch regularly, then keep that. But some of the movies might be over a decade old. Are you really going to watch them now? If not, let them go.

Decorative Items

Decorative items should make your home feel good. When you have too many decorative items, the look is not decorative but cluttered; there's no visual interest. For decorative items, it's usually a case where less is more.

Let's implement **the 50% Rule**. This says to remove 50 percent of what you think looks good, and it will look better. This might seem counterintuitive. But when you have too many decorative items, your eyes are scanning every surface; there's nowhere to rest. As you reduce the number of items, each remaining item gets noticed and becomes more impactful.

Each decorative item should be intentional, not just taking up space. Ask yourself why you have the item. Does it have meaning or bring you happiness? If it's just there because you need something to fill the space, then that item is a filler item and can go.

Blankets and Throws

Only keep two to three blankets maximum in your living room that are routinely used. Some may have an additional blanket or two as decorative items. Only keep the blankets you use in the living room that are decorative or routinely used; store the extra blankets elsewhere. You can keep extras in a linen closet or bedroom closet and promote and demote them to fit the season. The living room should only contain blankets that have a purpose and not act as storage for additional blankets.

Step 3: Hidden Storage Audit

Often, entertainment centers and storage ottomans have clutter. You might know that if you open the door of the entertainment center, it's a mess, so you choose to keep that door closed. Even if you can't see the clutter, it can cause anxiety because you know it's there.

Let's start by opening the entertainment center cabinets and storage ottomans. Take out the contents and apply the same decision framework you used for visible items. Hidden storage should contain only items you use and need, not things you haven't dealt with yet and are holding on to indefinitely.

Ask yourself when you last used each item in hidden storage. If you haven't used something in the past year, you probably don't need it. That space could be used for items you do use, making them easier to access and your living room more functional.

Some common items that accumulate in hidden storage include old electronics that don't work, old cables and chargers for devices that were discarded long ago, instruction manuals for irrelevant items, DVDs or games you forgot you owned, and random items you didn't know what else to do with. You need to sift through all the items and only keep what serves a current purpose in your life right now.

The same principle that applies everywhere else applies to hidden storage. If you're not using it, then it's not serving you. Your storage space is valuable. Use the space for items that make your life easier and your living room more functional, not for items you don't want to deal with.

Daily Maintenance: The 5-Minute Reset

At this point, your living room should be decluttered and organized. The next challenge is to keep it this way over time. The key is

maintenance, and this requires a simple daily routine that takes about five minutes before bed each night. We call it the 5-Minute Daily Reset. This includes three tasks that prevent the accumulation of clutter: clear all surfaces, straighten cushions and fold throws, and return items to their homes.

Clearing all surfaces means exactly that, not leaving stuff on the surface in a neat pile. The coffee table should be clear except for perhaps one or two intentional items. The side tables and the entertainment center surfaces should be clear. There should be nothing piled on furniture or left sitting out temporarily. If something is on the surface, it should have a reason to be there; it shouldn't have just been left there one day and never moved.

On the couch or sofa, the act of straightening cushions and folding throws makes a big visual difference. A couch with neat cushions and a properly folded throw gives a calm appearance, whereas a couch with cushions askew and blankets piled up looks chaotic. This action has a significant impact on how the entire room feels. It makes the living room look cared for and maintained.

An important part of the reset is to return items to their homes. Any items that migrated into the living room during the day need to go back to where they belong. The shoes go to the entryway or bedroom, the bags go to wherever they're stored, the dishes and cups go to the kitchen, and the mail goes to wherever you process mail. The only things that should remain in the living room are those that are supposed to be there.

This reset prevents accumulation before it can start. When you perform this action each night without exception, items never have a chance to pile up. One item left out tonight becomes two items tomorrow and an accumulation of items by the end of the week. With the daily reset, the living room stays organized with minimal ongoing effort.

The time isn't significant, but the payoff is substantial. The next day, you'll wake up to a calm, organized living room instead of chaos. You can relax in your living room instead of feeling the clutter stress. The five minutes to reset protect the hours of work you invested in organizing this space.

Make this reset a requirement and part of your evening routine. It happens nightly, no matter how busy the day is and regardless of how tired you are. Some nights, you might feel like skipping the reset. Try to avoid this and just power through it. Maintenance works because of consistency. If you skip it once, it becomes easier to skip it again and rationalize it. Similarly, if you do this routinely, it becomes automatic and requires less mental effort.

Weekly Maintenance

In addition to your daily 5-Minute Reset, weekly maintenance will keep your living room functioning over the long run. This takes about fifteen to twenty minutes once per week and catches small problems before they become overwhelming.

Check each zone you organized and walk through the living room systematically. Look at the entertainment center, bookshelves, coffee table, and side tables, and examine any storage furniture. Is everything still in its rightful place? Are there items that have started to accumulate in any area? Are there spots that need attention before they become problematic?

Do a quick decluttering pass. Even with good daily maintenance, some items will accumulate over the course of a week. Magazines from last month can be recycled. Catalogs you've looked through can go. Mail that has been processed can be discarded or filed. Books you've finished reading can be returned to the shelf or passed along to someone else. Items that belong to other rooms can be returned to their proper homes.

Assess what's on surfaces. Even with daily resets, sometimes items start to creep back onto surfaces throughout the week. Do a thorough assessment and remove anything that doesn't belong. If you notice that certain items keep appearing in the living room, that tells you something important.

Review your storage solutions and systems. Are they still working well for you? If books are piling up outside the bookshelf, you probably need to do another round of book decluttering or reassess what you're keeping. If blankets aren't getting folded and put away during the daily reset, maybe the storage solution isn't convenient enough. If certain items keep appearing on the coffee table, maybe they need a designated home nearby. Pay attention to where your systems are breaking down and adjust as needed.

As you're doing your weekly check, take a few extra minutes to dust and wipe down the surfaces you've cleared. A clean, organized space is more inviting and relaxing than an organized but dusty space. This maintenance keeps the living room feeling fresh and well cared for.

This weekly maintenance routine should take fifteen to twenty minutes in total. It's much easier to spend this time weekly than spend several hours in the future on a major effort to declutter everything that has accumulated.

Common Living Room Challenges

The Coffee Table Clutter Problem

Coffee tables tend to act like magnets and attract clutter. Typically, they're in the central part of the living room, so it's natural for them to be a collecting spot for items. Sometimes, mail might be set down there while passing through the entryway. Throughout the course of the day, a glass or cup is set on the coffee table and never leaves. And of course, there are the remote controls and a few books that

accumulate. Before too long, the coffee table is covered, and you can barely see its surface.

The key is to set clear rules as to what is allowed on the coffee table and then enforce those rules consistently during your daily reset. It's better to set the rules as to what belongs in advance rather than make them up as you go. For the remotes, perhaps one remote control caddie holds all the remotes in one container. Maybe there's one smaller decorative item like a candle or a small plant. Maybe allow the current book you're reading to remain on the coffee table. Create a short, specific list of what is allowed on the coffee table and stick to that list. Everything else is not allowed to remain overnight on the coffee table.

After the rules have been established, the daily reset becomes straightforward as you are executing, not decision-making. You're not making decisions every time you clear the coffee table about which items should stay or go. You already know which items are the designated items, so everything else gets put away immediately as part of your routine. This eliminates decision fatigue and makes maintenance much more of a routine.

If your coffee table has storage areas like drawers, then apply the same standards to that hidden storage. Don't let these unseen areas become dumping grounds for random items just because they're out of sight. Only keep useful items in coffee table storage that logically belong in the living room.

The Staging Area Problem

It's common for living rooms to become staging areas for items that really belong elsewhere. Some items in the living room may be awaiting return to the store; they just happen to remain in the living room for weeks. Items that belong somewhere upstairs may wait on the side table indefinitely. Projects that may have been stopped or paused sit on surfaces for days. Unopened mail that needs processing

begins to pile up. Library books that need to be returned sit in a pile, waiting. These items stay in the living room because they represent tasks or decisions that have not been made yet.

The solution is to bypass the idea of staging in your living room. Items should go directly to their destination, not stay in the living room as a temporary storage spot. Don't set items down in the living room with the intention of taking them up later. If something needs to be returned to a store, then put it in your car right now.

If you find that the living room remains a staging area despite numerous efforts, it indicates a problem with the systems or routines elsewhere in your home. For example, you might have items accumulating because you don't have an effective system for handling returns. Perhaps items pile up because there's a high degree of effort required to put them away in their actual place. The solution is really to address the underlying problem. Try to fix the root cause of the problem, not just the visible symptoms.

The Toy Takeover Problem

With young children come toys, and with toys comes the Toy Takeover Problem. Toys have the habit of making their way to the living room, growing in number and adding to the clutter. This is understandable and expected, as kids usually stick close to adults, and the living room is an ideal spot to gather—and to experience the Toy Takeover Problem. Toys should not be so dominant and overwhelming that they make it unpleasant for others to enjoy themselves and relax in the living room. The living room is for all who enter—guests and family members, including adults and kids.

To address this problem, the toys located in the living room need to have designated storage solutions, and that storage solution needs a limit. There are many options for storage, such as a large basket, an ottoman with a lid, or a bookshelf with some bins. The idea is that the storage size should be clear and well understood. The toys

need to fit in the basket or in the ottoman. If there are too many toys for the designated living room storage space, then toys should be demoted to the child's playroom or bedroom. The storage space is a physical boundary that helps to keep everyone organized and prevent the accumulation of toys.

The toy cleanup process should be part of the 5-Minute Reset routine for the family. Before bed, as a matter of routine, all the toys should be put back in their designated storage space. This routine teaches kids that the living room is everyone's space and everyone has a hand in maintaining the space. It's not an extension of the play area. This builds good habits that serve children well in the future.

Many households will find a consistent overflow in the designated living room storage space. This is caused by an overabundance of toys in circulation at one time. To address this, rotate the toys through selected locations. For example, keep approximately half the toys stored in the closet and swap them out quarterly. This keeps the toys interesting and allows for seasonal adjustments.

The Electronics and Cable Chaos

Your living room likely contains a lot of electronic devices: a television, a soundbar, streaming devices, gaming systems, and other items. These devices all have their own cables, cords, and remote control devices. Often, these items create visual clutter or a tangled-looking mess that's difficult to deal with.

You'll want to organize these cables in a structured manner. Cable management solutions can help keep the cords from getting tangled around the entertainment center. Some common techniques are to direct cables behind furniture or use cable clips and hook-and-loop fasteners to keep the cords aligned but separated. If you have a lot of cables, label them to simplify future troubleshooting efforts.

It's common to have multiple remotes in use. Choose a specific location to house your remote control devices. This could be a

small caddie on the coffee table. Otherwise, your remote controls might be strewn throughout the living room or wedged between the cushions, making them difficult to find when you want them.

At regular intervals, assess your electronics and their accessories to determine their relevance. Have you used the gaming system in the last year? If not, it might be better off stored or donated. If you have cables for devices you don't use, they should be discarded. If you have controllers with dead batteries that you never bothered to replace, it probably means that you're not using that device anymore. Those instruction manuals for electronics can be found online, so consider discarding them.

Only the electronic devices and accessories that you use regularly should be kept. Technology changes rapidly, and holding onto outdated devices and their associated cables, cords, and accessories creates clutter without much benefit to your life.

Seasonal Adjustments

The living room will usually require seasonal adjustments to improve functionality. Typically, your needs in the summer will differ from those in the winter and vice versa. An intentional shift will help to keep the living room organized and functional throughout the year.

For example, you'll likely need more blankets in the living room for warmth in the winter months. You'll still want to have a limited number of blankets or throws, perhaps adding one additional throw if appropriate. One technique is to use heavier blankets in the winter and light throws in the summer.

Your decorative items will also change by the season, but the 50% Rule remains relevant. When rotating through seasonal decorations, remove the old decorations completely before adding the new ones. You don't want to create clutter by adding new decorations on top of the existing decorations.

Lastly, consider how the living room's use might change with the season. During the summertime, you might spend more time outdoors or in the backyard, so the living room is used less. In the winter, we tend to gather in the living room more frequently, so you may need to adjust the furniture arrangement. Adjust your space to your needs, which will vary by the season.

The Long-Term Perspective

At this point, you should have achieved an uncluttered and organized living room, but it's not a one-shot endeavor. The practice should be ongoing, requiring regular attention and maintenance. Both the 5-Minute Reset and the weekly maintenance routines must be kept to reap the benefits. These habits will keep your living room organized and functional over the long run.

As you move through life and turn the pages, your living room will need to change and adapt accordingly. Children will grow older. Their needs will change; their toys will change. Technology is changing rapidly, and this will impact your entertainment center and accessories. Adjust your systems as your life changes rather than sticking to those systems that have worked in the past.

Remember, you're not striving for perfection. You're creating a living room that meets your requirements and can be maintained with minimal daily effort. There will be ebbs and flows; sometimes the room will be more organized, and other times it will appear less organized. The important thing is to have a system in place to address issues and restore order as needed—and to apply this system consistently.

The organized living room will often be a template for other places in your home, as it's one of the most visible rooms in the house. The calmness emanating from the living room will provide inspiration to recreate the same atmosphere elsewhere in your home. Similarly, the maintenance routines used in the living room can be

applied and adapted to the other areas of the home. Although you were organizing your living room, these techniques laid a foundation that can be applied throughout your home over time.

The Impact and Moving Forward

Now, two key areas of the home have been organized: the entryway and the living room. Both these areas are high-traffic areas within the home. The skills and techniques you developed can be used in every other space you will organize with minor adaptations.

As you continue this journey, keep the principles you learned and applied. You want to completely remove the contents of the area to identify what you have to work with. Any psychological attachments need to be broken. Use category-specific decisions to help guide you in making difficult decisions. Determine designated spaces or homes for items you want to keep, rather than just shuffling the items around. Implement daily maintenance routines to prevent regression to your prior state; this protects your investment of time and effort.

Your home is starting to become a space that supports you and less a source of stress. As you continue to declutter and organize rooms, you'll feel the momentum build. You'll be able to relax in your home and find the items you need when you need them. Finally, you'll begin to live your life not fighting the friction of your self-imposed environmental clutter.

CHAPTER 5

Kitchen - Function, Flow, and Calm



Time Budget: 8–12 hours
Impact: Highest-frequency space; affects daily function and stress — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

The kitchen is likely the room that gets used the most. It's the hardest working space. It has high traffic and readily impacts how smoothly your household runs. It not only collects kitchen items like food and dishes, but also random items like mail, keys, and items that seemingly have no set location. A cluttered kitchen impacts meal preparation, planning, and efficiency. It can be a stressful place or a calm place depending on how the kitchen is organized.

This is a longer chapter for a longer project. Set aside eight to twelve hours for this space. It might be advisable to spread the time over multiple sessions to prevent being overwhelmed. The kitchen will take a long time, but potentially the garage or basement could be longer. However, the kitchen has a greater impact than these other rooms. A well-organized kitchen will reduce your stress level and save you time.

The Hardest Working Space

Many activities occur within the kitchen: cooking activities, meal consumption, lunch packing, mail sorting, and even homework. Since the kitchen serves multiple functions, it will tend to gather the clutter from other areas of your life. There could be backpacks, purses, and other things that really belong elsewhere.

Your kitchen might feel like an eclectic mix of a bit of everything. This visual chaos tends to create mental clutter. If you can't find things, or your counter is cluttered, or you open a cabinet and it's stacked full, you might feel anxiety before you begin meal preparations. Do you open a drawer and have to dig through several utensils to find your spatula? Is your frying pan stacked at the bottom of several other pots and pans you never use? Or maybe you go to prepare a meal, but there's no counter space.

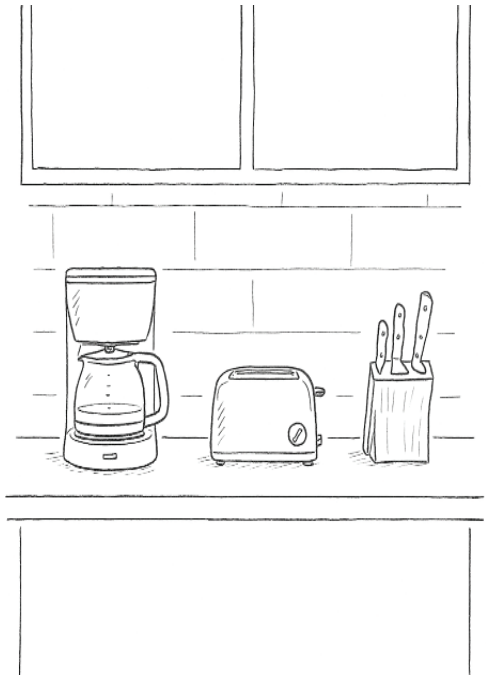
Are any of these situations relatable? Do you avoid cooking because your kitchen's unsettling? You might order takeout more often because you don't want to deal with your kitchen chaos. You know the kitchen is a mess and have just never addressed the situation. It's time to start.

Step 1: The Brutal Counter Rule

The foundation of your kitchen organization is to only allow the appliances you use daily to remain on the kitchen counter. Your overarching goal is to maximize counter space for actual food preparation.

So, what remains on the kitchen counter? The answer is derived from the amount of counter space real estate you have and those items you use most frequently. For those who drink coffee regularly, the coffee maker is a must-have. If you eat toast daily, the toaster. The knife block might stay if your drawer space is limited. The

minimalist view might be three items at most. You can adapt this thinking, allowing for additional items on the counter so long as they do not clutter the counter space.



Those items cluttering the counter need to be relocated. Appliances that are used weekly should go in a cabinet where they're accessible but don't take up real estate. The blender, food processor, and slow cooker probably don't need to sit on the counter. Appliances used monthly or less can go to the basement or get discarded. For some appliances, you might need to ask the hard question: Do you ever use the bread maker or the waffle iron? If you haven't used it in the last year, it should probably be donated.

Do you have decorative items on your counter? Some choose to include these items. However, consideration should be given to the level of maintenance and the space they occupy. Others choose to

have these items discarded or relocated to another room. The kitchen space primarily needs to be functional; the décor is a secondary consideration. A clear kitchen looks better when the surface is clean, not cluttered.

A clear countertop invokes a different feeling instantly. If you must move items around on the counter to chop vegetables, something is amiss. Your morning will feel better if you're drinking coffee without looking at clutter. Meal preparations will be easier when you're not negotiating space to cook. You'll save time if you're not wiping around unused appliances after cooking.

First, start with the counter. Clear and remove everything from the counter and give it a good cleaning. Wipe and remove all the stains in the crevices and crumbs in the cracks. Then decide what items return to the counter. If there's a debate whether something should be there, then it probably shouldn't. Is that air fryer used only monthly? Put it in the cabinet. Have you used the holiday mixer lately? Put it in the basement. How many cutting boards do you have? Consider keeping only a few.

This counter rule is the most influential action you can take in your kitchen. A clear counter promotes calmness and a space that's functional. You want to create a working kitchen, not one that's full of obstacles. When you see your kitchen with clear counters, you'll understand why this rule matters so much.

Step 2: Systematic Cookware Purge

Look at where you store your pots, pans, and baking dishes. Most likely, you have more than you need and more than you can use. The typical household will need five to six pans: a saucepan, a large pot, a medium skillet, a large skillet, and maybe a wok and a stockpot. If you have duplicates, then keep the best of each. Think about it:

you're not running a restaurant. Sometimes you might cook multiple dishes simultaneously, but your cooking is usually staggered.

Consider your baking dishes. You likely need two to three sizes at most. If you frequently bake multiple dishes simultaneously, you might need a bit more, but that's not the norm. How often do you make a casserole? If it's once a year, then you don't need multiple casserole dishes. Just keep one small and one large and donate the rest.

Look at your utensils. Generally, one of each tool should be sufficient. You don't need five spatulas, three can openers, or multiple ladles. If you have multiple items, pick the one you use the most or that works the best and donate the rest.

After you rationalize your cookware to fit your needs, you might notice some subtle things. First, it's easier to find things quickly because you aren't digging through a pile of pans. Second, when you put away dishes, it's easier since all the dishes fit in the cabinet. Third, you don't bang pots around in frustration trying to get to your desired pot.

Some items may have been given to you, so you don't want to let them go. Or maybe they represent your past self. You need to give yourself time and space to let go of these items. Your kitchen should reflect the current chapter of your life, not the past. If you baked muffins in the past and that time has passed, then donate the muffin tin. If you don't use a wok anymore, give it away.

After determining your useful cookware, organize it with purpose. Those pots and pans you use daily should be in the most accessible cabinet where you don't need to bend or reach too much. The items that are used less frequently should go in the higher or lower reach cabinets. If you still need to stack the pans by size, then do so, but hopefully, having fewer pans should minimize the need for stacking. The lids should be stored with a lid organizer so you don't spend time hunting for lids.

You're developing something that works for you and your routine; you don't need to keep all the pots and pans you've acquired. Your kitchen should flow easier, not harder. You should be able to access your items without moving others to gain access to them. In this way, cooking will be more enjoyable and less frustrating.

Step 3: The Food Storage Container Crisis

Most kitchens suffer from this problem. Likely, you have a cabinet or drawer full of containers, missing lids, and even portions of takeout containers that were washed and saved. Have you opened the cabinet and had containers fall out? Have you ever put food in a container you couldn't find the lid for and had to use aluminum foil to cover the dish?

Take out all your containers from the cabinet and go through the process of matching the containers with their lids. If a container has no matching lid, it gets recycled. A lid without a matching container also gets recycled. Generally, keep ten to fifteen matched containers of various sizes. That includes three to four smaller containers for the kids' snacks, some medium containers for lunch preparation, and larger containers for leftovers. If you have more than this, you have too much; you're storing containers rather than storing food.

The remainders are excess and can be donated. If you think you might need them someday, that's not true. You don't. Takeout containers should be recycled as they stain easily and don't stack well. And, since these containers are usually different sizes, they have the effect of making your storage location chaotic. If you have enough real containers, there's no need for them.

As you impose limits on the number of containers, your cabinet will begin to look more functional. You can stack the containers, locate the desired size container, and find the lid. This change will eliminate the frustration of finding a functional storage container.

Your containers should be further organized by small, medium, and large sizes; different sizes should not be commingled. The preference is to have clear containers so you can see the contents without opening each one. If you choose opaque containers, then label them. Label makers and masking tape work best. Be sure to include the storage date on the label.

Remember, you're creating a functional working system, not a perfect system. Depending on your lifestyle, adjust the parameters. If you cook for the week, then increase the number of large containers. If you have packed lunches, then increase the medium containers. Generally, try to stick with fifteen containers, but vary the size as needed. This is driven by cabinet space availability and using it efficiently.

Also, it's worth considering the type of containers you use. Glass containers are heavy, but they can go from the refrigerator to the oven or be steamed. Plastic containers are lighter but wear out faster. Vary the container type to match your cooking and lifestyle.

Step 4: The Pantry Edit

It's time to address the pantry. Your focus should first be on those expiration dates. Discard items well past their expiration dates. The expired items are not food; they're clutter taking up the space where real food should be.

Empty your pantry shelves so you can assess what you have. Vacuum and wipe down the shelving. There, you'll likely find crumbs and spills you didn't know existed. Next, you'll want to sort through all the removed items. Consolidate your duplicates into one box or container. If there are two boxes of the same cereal, combine them. If there are multiple open bags of flour, consolidate.

Now look at those items you haven't touched in months or years. Did you buy quinoa a year ago, thinking you were going to use it?

If it's unexpired, donate it to the food bank; otherwise, discard it. If you haven't used the ingredients for years, there's no reason to think you'll suddenly start using those ingredients now. This might be a difficult thing to accept, but a necessary one. The pantry, *your* pantry, is not a museum of your cooking inspirations or aspirations. You are trying to maintain a functional space for the food you consume.

Let's examine the canned goods. Those cans with bulges, dents, or rust must go. If they're past their expiration, they need to be discarded. Canned goods can last a long time, but not indefinitely. Why do you have so many cans of the same soup you've never eaten? Consider donating them.

As you repopulate your pantry, you'll want to group similar items together into broad categories. Baking supplies, breakfast cereals, dinner items, and snacks are common categories. This categorization facilitates meal planning because you can see your items immediately. Again, clear containers are preferable for items you buy in bulk or in open packages. Transfer cereals, flour, sugar, rice, and pasta into airtight containers rather than keeping them in the containers they arrived in. The clear containers allow you to assess inventory; the airtightness promotes freshness, prevents spills, and assists in stacking. Generally, it's just more appealing if the containers are the same size. Containers should be labeled with their contents and expiration dates.



A common technique for the pantry is the **one-in, one-out rule**. For example, before you buy a new box of cereal, you must finish the prior one first. This prevents pantry overflow and forces you to use items at your disposal rather than accumulating more items. Further, it stops you from buying items you might already have but may have forgotten about.

The pantry should only contain items you will use in the next six months. If you don't intend to use it, then don't store it. You might think the act of discarding is wasteful, but keeping food you won't eat is creating clutter. The "waste" aspect happened when

you decided not to use the item; it already passed. Now, you're only making space for items you intend to consume.

The well-organized pantry will be less wasteful as you are more aware of what you own. You won't accidentally purchase duplicate items, and you'll use existing items before expiration. Meal preparation will be factual, based upon what you have. Overall, you should save time, money, and space.

Step 5: Refrigerator and Freezer

The refrigerator and the freezer require the same treatment as the pantry. Often, these places are like an abyss where food goes to never be seen (or eaten) again. The tendency is to put leftovers into a container and push them into a corner where they're forgotten until their real estate is in demand.

First, we apply our procedure of removing everything from the refrigerator to assess the inventory. Check the expiration date of condiments. These will last a long time, but typically not a year. One-year-old salad dressing needs to be discarded. Consolidate multiple bottles of ketchup or mustard. Do you have a lot of sauces? Pick the favorites and discard the rest.

Look for expired products like dairy, vegetables you've been avoiding, or mystery leftovers. If you don't remember the contents of a container or when it was made, it should be discarded. Your impulse will be to open and investigate the container, but it's better to just discard it. Leftovers older than four days should be discarded. If there's mold or wilted items, just discard them. (Don't think about cutting mold off the cheese so you can eat the inside!)

Wipe the shelves, drawers, and sides of the refrigerator. There will be spills, sticky spots, and crumbs throughout. If possible, remove the drawers and wash them in the sink rather than trying to

wipe them down. The cleaner the refrigerator, the easier it is to keep organized.

After that, return only the items you will use and keep. Try to organize by category. Dairy products should go in one area, vegetables in the crisper drawers, and condiments in the door. Leftovers should also have a designated location for easy assessment. New groceries should be situated at the back so older items are consumed first; this simple rotation can prevent waste.

The freezer may contain items from over a few years ago. Remove everything and look for freezer-burned items, meat with ice crystals, and frozen vegetables you didn't know were still there. Items that exceed one year should be discarded. If you haven't eaten it in a year, you aren't going to eat it now. And the freezer-burned items will have a unique taste you might not be ready to appreciate.

If possible, organize the freezer by category, grouping similar items together. Freezer bags can be used to group similar items, and adding a label with the date they were frozen takes the guesswork out of your frozen bags.

Some people use baskets or bins to create zones for organization. There could be zones for meat, vegetables, prepared meals, ice cream, and treats. This prevents items from getting buried somewhere and forgotten.

Set one day a week for "leftovers night." This will save time and money and reduce waste in the long run.

An organized refrigerator and freezer make meal planning easier. You know what you have and can plan meals around items that need to be used. Duplicate purchases are less likely to occur because you've checked your inventory. You'll feel more in control and less wasteful. When you open the refrigerator, you can find what you need.

Step 6: Junk Drawer Transformation

It's still possible to have one "junk drawer." Although it's a *junk* drawer, it's not a *chaos* drawer where random items accumulate; it needs categories and dividers.

First, we remove everything from that junk drawer. Go through everything and determine if it's truly junk and should be discarded. Check the batteries you find; if they're dead, then dispose of them. There might be free pens you've accumulated. Only keep a limited number of working pens. You might have mystery keys. Try to find out if they unlock something. If you can't figure it out now, you won't figure it out later. The list goes on.

There will probably be a handful of smaller items like paper clips, pins, twist ties, or rubber bands. You'll want to keep a reasonable number of these items and discard the excess.

Whatever remains, you need to organize it. One common approach is to buy a plastic organizer with small boxes or compartments of various sizes. Each item needs its own section, its own spot, so that you can find it when needed.

Keep only the tools that you need and use: a flashlight, scissors, a screwdriver, tape, a small notepad, working pens, and a few batteries. This is the usual list.

If your junk drawer has organization and limits, it becomes useful instead of frustrating. It will be easier to find what you need quickly. You know what it contains, and you won't worry about it overflowing every time you open it. This adaptation makes daily life smoother. You'll stop wasting time digging through clutter and won't buy duplicate items because you can't find the one you already own.

Daily Maintenance: The Ten-Minute Kitchen Reset

Once the kitchen is decluttered and organized, the key, as always, is maintenance. A decluttered kitchen will revert back to a cluttered state within weeks if a ten-minute routine is not performed. The routine maintains calm and prevents backsliding into old habits.

Broadly, the routine is to clear the surfaces, wipe down the surfaces, return designated items to their homes, and clean any dirty items. Any items that have landed in the kitchen need to go back to their proper home. (Keys have their designated home. The mail goes to its processing area. Backpacks belong in the mud room or the bedroom.)

Don't leave the dishes sitting in the sink overnight. Some dishes can go to the dishwasher, and other items need to be washed by hand. If the dishwasher is full, then run the dishwasher. If there are hand-washed dishes, dry them and put them away. Avoid leaving dishes to drip dry overnight. A clear sink without dishes promotes a calming feeling in the morning. You don't want to wake up to unaddressed dishes; this leads to the feeling of starting the day behind schedule.

Wipe down all the kitchen surfaces before the night is done: the counters, the stove, the table, and sometimes the chairs. It only takes a few minutes, and the benefit is that the kitchen begins the next day clean. Hot water with soap works just fine, and for messy times, maybe some all-purpose cleaner. This should be a nightly habit, not just when the kitchen looks dirty.

If the trash is full, take it outside; don't let it overflow. Don't stop halfway by taking out the trash but not replacing the trash bag. Replace the trash bag so it's ready for the new trash.

This routine could take ten to fifteen minutes, but it maintains a functional kitchen. Your mornings will be calmer, and you will feel more in control. You won't have to negotiate space to make breakfast, coffee, or pack the lunches.

Many will resist this nightly routine because they're tired. This is because it's not yet a built-in habit; it's akin to exercising a muscle that's been rarely used. At the onset, it will be difficult, and your initial inclination will be to skip it "this time" and address it in the morning. Don't start off by skipping the maintenance step. This will set you back before you even get started. The second and each successive week will make this routine easier as it becomes more routine and automatic. There are no decisions in this routine. It's really about execution, so it should not be mentally challenging. At some point, it will become a habit, and *not* performing the routine will feel wrong.

Everyone can participate to some extent in the nightly kitchen reset. Children can clean their plates and set the dishes in the sink. They can help relocate items from the kitchen to their proper homes. Every family member can have their own little routines related to kitchen cleaning.

Weekly Maintenance

The kitchen needs some deeper cleaning on a weekly basis. Typically, the kitchen should be in an organized state, such as was outlined in Chapter 5. A deeper cleaning will involve wiping down the cabinet fronts, backsplashes, microwave, etc. In addition, the floors should be swept and mopped to prevent buildup, which will make things more difficult later.

Creating a Kitchen That Serves You

The kitchen is a place where you naturally gather. A well-functioning and organized kitchen causes your household to run more smoothly. The energy of the kitchen spreads to other parts of the house and your life. A cluttered kitchen leads to a cluttered home and a

cluttered life. Create that kitchen that achieves your goals, hopefully one that is organized and functional.

After decluttering the kitchen, all items should have their place. Cleaning should be automatic, as there should be no decision points, only execution. After an item is used or cleaned, it is returned to the proper location. Groceries have their designated spot in the refrigerator or pantry. It is about consistency that takes away the guesswork and prevents accumulation.

The benefits of daily improvement will compound over time. Remember, you're not decluttering and organizing for perfection. You're creating a system that works for you and your lifestyle. Don't try to fit another person's view of the ideal kitchen; you need to create your own view. If there's a lot of takeout food, then scale down the dishes. If there's weekly meal preparation on Sundays, then scale up the storage containers. If you have kids who need more snack storage, adjust accordingly.

Subtle changes will occur in the kitchen after you're organized. The first week will be more of an effort, with increased vigilance. You must consciously enact the routine. Later, it will become more natural as you start putting things away, and it becomes more second nature. After a month, you'll form new habits, and the nightly routine will be automatic. Before long, you'll look at subtle ways to improve the initial organization to be slightly more functional. This is a work in progress.

This is a denser chapter because your kitchen deserves this time and attention. The kitchen is the space that affects you most during the day. When you create the optimal space, it will support your other activities. Mornings will be calmer, evenings less stressful, and overall family life will flow more smoothly. So, set the time and take the time to do things properly. As we said, this is usually not a one-session endeavor. That would be too much. Spread the work over a few days or different weekends as needed. Maybe you want to tackle

a session per day per weekend. One for counters and appliances, another for cookware, and still another for storage containers and other items. You want to break it down to manageable pieces and give your best effort to each piece.

Commit to finishing this and not starting only to abandon it with a few zones or sessions complete. Finish the kitchen and commit to the ten-minute maintenance routine. This will transform the kitchen from chaos to calmness.

Soon, your guests will comment on how nice the kitchen looks. Of course, impressing others is a secondary impact. The primary goal is to create a space that helps your family function each day.

CHAPTER 6

Dining Area - Gathering Without Clutter



Time Budget: 2–3 hours
Impact: Reclaim this space for its intended purpose — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

The dining area has the primary purpose of providing space for meals and gathering. For many people, the dining table has become a multipurpose table. It might hold mail, homework, projects, and random items. Many people have inadvertently turned the family dinner table into a horizontal filing cabinet, and now is the time to reclaim the table.

A cluttered table forces you to clear space before meals and creates stress every time you walk past it. In contrast, a clear table invites gathering and makes your home feel calmer. When this area is sorted out, the impact of having a functional dining room table can be immense. This is a shorter project compared to the kitchen; two to three hours should be sufficient.

The Horizontal Surface Problem

The dining room table attracts clutter. A large flat surface is an inviting surface for something to be set on top of it. The children's school papers gravitate to the table. Sometimes groceries may end up on the table. A project or a craft might be set on the table. Before long, the surface is no longer visible and is covered by items that belong elsewhere.

Dining table clutter happens because the table is in a convenient space. It's harder to put the items where they belong versus just setting them on the table. The table is also a repository for items because it has more empty space than other options.

The cluttered dining table impedes activities. You can't readily eat meals there, as that would require clearing the table. As a substitute, you might eat in the kitchen, on the couch, or even standing around. When the table is avoided, eating is less communal, and the dining area becomes somewhat useless.

The cluttered dining table has an impact on the home. For those walking by, it serves as a reminder of projects that remain undone or decisions to be made. It's time for better. You and your family should be able to gather for a meal without encountering chaos.

Step 1: Complete Table Clearing

Like before, the first step is to remove everything from the dining room table to get to the clear surface. Let's use the Five Container System. Every item on the table must be put into one of five containers, which we will name: Keep, Relocate, Trash, Donate, and Monetary Recovery. Here, we added an additional container labeled "Needs Decision," which includes those items where some more time is needed to determine the outcome.

- **Keep** is for items you want to keep and which belong on the dining room table. On a general basis, there should be little if anything here.
- **Relocate** is the category for items that belong in the home but not on the dining table. Most commonly, mail goes to the mail processing area, school papers go to the homework station or the children's rooms, keys go to their designated hook, and remote controls go to their caddie. The list goes on and on.
- **Trash** means garbage. It could be junk mail, broken items, pens that don't work, or various items that really serve no purpose. Don't save items in hopes of figuring out what to use them for later; just discard them now.
- **Donate** items that are in good condition but are no longer useful to you. This could be school supplies the kids have outgrown, books you won't or haven't read, or decorations that someone might use (but not you).
- **Monetary Recovery** is for high-value items that you want to sell rather than donate – there should be little if anything here.
- **Needs Decision** refers to items that require a greater level of thought. The key is to get through the table-clearing phase without getting derailed with decision-making. However, you need to commit to addressing these items in a few days. This is not a box to be hidden away permanently.

Most often as you sort through the items, very little will belong on the dining table surface. Your dining table should hold dishes, food, and people during mealtimes. When there isn't a meal, maybe one centerpiece is appropriate. Everything else should go.

After clearing and sorting, wipe down the table surface thoroughly. Be sure to clean the leaves or extensions if they exist. The uncluttered table is now calm and inviting. The hard part is keeping the table surface empty except for the centerpiece.

Step 2: The Project Box System

Often, there are legitimate in-flight projects in the household. These can't readily be packaged up as you're decluttering. There might be a jigsaw puzzle that the family is working on together. Maybe a craft project that takes several sessions to complete. These things take time and need a home, but that is not the dining room table.

We're going to introduce the **Project Box System**, which means that for each active project, we assign a labeled box or container to that project. Every project box has a designated location on a shelf or closet. So, you can have a project box for a puzzle that's in progress. If the project is being worked on, the box comes out, and work occurs on the table. When finished for the day, the project or puzzle is placed back into the box, and the box is returned to storage. This is a workable system as it promotes project continuity without giving up table space.

Enforcement is the key to this system. Projects that are not actively being worked on are put away. The projects live in boxes, not on the dining room table. Also, you should limit the number of active projects. Two projects are a reasonable number. For example, each child has two boxes, so this is the number of projects they can work on. If there are more than a few projects in progress, it will be more chaotic and overwhelming. If the child wants to start another project, then designate a project that will be abandoned. This teaches some decision-making and prevents the project boxes from creating clutter.

For items that have accumulated on the table, they need to be returned to their rightful place. At this stage of the book, many of the items likely have their own space; they simply were not placed in their spot. Mail should go to the mail processing area, keys on hooks, bags to the bedroom or the mudroom. When everything is processed, the dining room should be clear.

Step 3: Storage Furniture Audit

The dining room typically has some furniture besides the dining room table. This might be a china cabinet, sideboard, or buffet. The dining room furniture should store only dining and entertainment-related items: dishes, glassware, serving platters, special table linen, and items for entertaining guests.

If this is your first time decluttering the dining room furniture, you'll probably find non-dining items there. Many will find things like office supplies, craft items, and other random household supplies. It's time to address items like these.

Start first by removing the contents inside the dining room furniture, then sort through the items using the Five Container System. Determine which items belong in the dining area and which do not. Relocate the items you no longer need and put them in the proper bins.

For items that are dining-related, be realistic and honest about what is needed. How often do you host those formal dinners? Determine the number of place settings you'll need and donate the excess.

Take a harder look at serving platters and bowls. Often, we have multiples of similar sizes that we've acquired at some point. How many serving bowls do you really need? Maybe one or two, depending on whether you serve multiple dishes simultaneously. Select the best and donate the rest.

Examine and take stock of your glassware. Think about the number of wine glasses you might realistically use. Unless you host large dinner parties, you don't need that many. For most, just enough for your typical gathering size plus a few extras is sufficient. Look at water glasses, coffee mugs, and any other drinkware stored in the dining area through the same lens.

For many, table linens have accumulated over time. You may have received a few as gifts or bought one for that special occasion, and they're all piled up in drawers. Take stock of your tablecloths, keeping those you like and use, and donating the rest. The same considerations apply to placemats and cloth napkins. How many do you need?

After purging non-dining room items and excess dining items, organize the remaining logically. Items that are most frequently used should be readily accessible. Daily dishes should go in easy-to-reach parts of the cabinets. The special occasion items should be placed in less accessible areas. The table linens should be folded in the drawer, and the serving pieces by size or type.

This approach will make hosting and meal preparation easier as everything is accessible. Also, it prevents the dining area from storing non-dining items. If there's a set organization for the items that belong there, miscellaneous items are less likely to be stored there.

Step 4: Centerpiece Reality Check

Many people think that having a centerpiece is a necessity. It isn't. A clear table is calmer and more functional. If there's no centerpiece, the table is ready for meals at any time. There's no centerpiece maintenance, and it's visually calming.

If you decide you want a centerpiece, then choose something simple, low profile, and readily movable for meals. Think of a low bowl with a few decorative items, a small vase with flowers, or a

simple candle arrangement. There are practical matters to consider. If you choose to have fresh flowers, they need to be changed periodically. Candles need replacing; seasonal decorations need to be adjusted. Depending on the centerpiece, it might need dusting or wiping. Maintaining the centerpiece might feel like another chore. If so, then skip the centerpiece.

Your dining table is primarily for you and your guests to gather for meals. If there are items that interfere with this purpose, they don't belong on the table. A centerpiece that is constantly in the way or a chore to maintain should be removed. Sometimes less is more.

The Clear Table Rule

The most important rule for maintaining your dining room area is simply clearing the dining room table. Sometime before bed, go to the dining room area and clear those items that remain on the table. If there's mail, send it to the mail processing area. If there's school homework, put it in the backpack or homework boxes. Clear any remaining dishware into the sink or dishwasher. As the dining table is normally empty, everything should be returned to its proper spot.

After clearing the dining table, wipe down the surface to clean it and create a sense of completion for the next day. If there's a centerpiece, touch it up with a dusting or whatever is needed and return it to the table. The goal is to return the uncluttered dining room back to that state nightly.

Each member of the family should contribute and take responsibility for cleaning the dining room. Even young kids can carry their papers to their room or put their craft supplies in a project box. When everyone contributes, the routine takes minutes instead of becoming one person's burden.

Creating Boundaries around the Dining Area

The dining room area needs some established boundaries to stay functional. There are two categories of boundaries: physical and behavioral. The physical boundaries refer to the designated homes for items so they don't migrate to the table and can be returned to those homes. The behavioral boundaries refer to the family rules about how space is used.

If mail seems to land in the dining area, then create a mail processing station near your entry—a small basket or tray where mail lands when you walk in. Once or twice per week, process the mail: pay bills, respond to important items, and recycle junk. This way, mail never touches the dining table.

Your kids might do homework at the dining table each evening, but it should never remain on the dining table overnight. Create a homework station for your children in their bedrooms or in a corner; it should have supplies, good lighting, and space to work.

There needs to be some clear rules set for projects. Some projects can be worked on at the dining table, but must be packed up when not in use. Projects that take weeks to complete need to find alternative surfaces. For example, a puzzle can be worked on a piece of plywood or cardboard that slides under a bed or couch when not in use. Similarly, a craft project can be worked on at a desk or craft table in another room.

These boundaries need to be clear to everyone in your household to prevent frustration. It's not about being rigid but about preserving the functionality of the space for everyone. If there's understanding, everyone in the household is more likely to respect the boundaries.

These boundaries should be enforced consistently. If you allow the table to become cluttered for a few days, you're teaching everyone that the boundaries are flexible. If you clear the table consistently, then everyone learns that space matters.

Using the Dining Area Intentionally

When your dining area is clear and functional, use it with intention. The goal is not pristine, unused space; the point of maintaining a clear table is so that it can be intentionally used.

Try to eat meals there whenever possible, even simple meals or solitary meals. If no one's around, it's not necessary to always eat in front of the TV or on the couch. The dining room is still appropriate for enjoying a meal with a different experience. Now you can invite friends over for meals without embarrassment. You can turn off the television and phones and connect through conversation.

As we've mentioned, there are other activities the dining room table can host, such as board games, puzzles, homework, or snacks. After all these activities, the dining room should be returned to an uncluttered state, ready for meals.

If you rarely use the dining room table, then investigate the root cause. You don't want wasted or unused space in your home. It might be that the dining room is too formal or too large. Maybe you need to rethink the space of the dining room so that it's more functional.

When the Dining Table Becomes a Desk

With remote work in today's economy, many people work from home and use the dining table as a desk during the day. In these circumstances, make sure the work materials don't remain on the dining table during meals and overnight. Like the project box, create a work box where you keep your work office supplies so that you can set up and clean up efficiently.

Sometimes you might find it difficult to pack up the home office. In these cases, use a dedicated workspace elsewhere. Some common alternatives are a desk in a bedroom, a corner of the living room, or

even a small table in a hallway. The dining table can serve double duty temporarily, but it might not work as a permanent office.

If your work materials stay on the dining table overnight or during meals, it sends the message that work is always present. It's necessary to set some boundaries between work space and dining space to protect your mental health and relationships.

Dealing with Resistance

Some in the family might pose resistance to the clear table rule. They may complain about putting items away nightly, protest that it's better to have that project stay on the dining room table, or, worse, ignore the rule entirely and pile items on the table.

In these cases, you'll need to explain the clear benefits, mainly that the family can eat together without visual stress. Also, try leading by example. If you consistently clear off the table, your family will eventually follow.

This may be a shift in mindset for some, and the first week might be the most difficult. Each subsequent week should be easier, and eventually, it should feel like a routine. Most likely, some time will be needed to adjust to the new routine and mindset.

The Emotional Shift

When your dining room is uncluttered and more functional, you'll feel better. It will be a shift to a calmer you. A clearer house and dining area open possibilities, as there is less hesitation to spontaneously invite people over.

As you declutter and organize room by room, the momentum will naturally build. Decluttering and organizing are achievable, as you have demonstrated by the entryway, living room, kitchen,

and now the dining room. You're gradually moving toward and expecting order, not chaos.

The dining room should be a gathering space, allowing us to build connections. This will happen organically if space is available and used. If the space is cluttered, the opportunities will disappear since there will be no gathering. If you prioritize it, you'll find the dining area and hosting guests less stressful.

Maintaining the Clear Space

The dining area is not a one-shot, one-and-done project; none of these decluttering efforts are. However, the maintenance after the major decluttering effort is simpler in that it's just execution; there are no decisions to be made. The dining table is cleared, wiped down, and items that don't belong in the dining room are returned to their proper location.

If clutter begins to creep in, then address it immediately before it becomes a problem. Sometimes the clutter creep is persistent, and in those cases, you may need to reassess and fine-tune your systems, as something may be amiss. The root cause might be that a proper home was not found for some items, or that project boxes are not appropriate or are not being used.

Remember, this process is not about perfection; it's about creating something that's functional. Sometimes, you'll have messy days when items get set on the dining table temporarily. This is natural; life happens. Just fix it. The dining table gets reset to a clear surface at night, and everything is back to normal. This consistency is what matters.

Your dining area should exist primarily for meals and gathering. When you understand that purpose by keeping the space clear and functional, you're honoring your family and your own need for a stress-free environment. This is not luxurious or something special;

it's a basic need that deserves protection. A clear table is not about aesthetics but more about function, peace, and connection.

CHAPTER 7

Home Office - Productive, Focused, and Clear



Time Budget: 2–3 hours
Impact: Reclaim this space for focused, productive work — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

The home office has one primary purpose: to support your work. Whether you work from home full time, manage household paperwork, or use the space occasionally, it should be a place where you can sit down, focus, and get things done. For many people, however, the home office has become something else entirely. It has quietly turned into the room where things go when they have nowhere else to go. Old cables, outdated manuals, dried-out pens, stacks of paper that have not been touched in months, and items from other rooms that simply migrated here and stayed.

A cluttered office makes it harder to focus and adds a layer of low-grade stress to every task you sit down to do. In contrast, a clear and organized workspace allows your brain to settle into work without processing the surrounding disorder. When this space is sorted out, the impact on your daily productivity and peace of mind can be

significant. Like the dining area, this is a shorter project compared to the kitchen. Two to three hours should be sufficient to work through it thoroughly.

The Desk Surface Problem

The desk surface attracts clutter for the same reason the dining table does. It is a large, flat, accessible surface, and it is easier to set something down on it than to put it where it belongs. Over time, the surface fills up. Papers stack. Supplies accumulate. Mugs, receipts, sticky notes with completed tasks, chargers for devices you no longer own—all of it lands on the desk and stays there. Before long, the actual working surface is gone.

Desk clutter impedes your work the same way dining table clutter impedes meals. You cannot readily use the space for its intended purpose because it first requires clearing. You might find yourself working from the kitchen table, the couch, or the corner of a bed rather than dealing with the desk. When the desk is avoided, the work suffers. It is time for better.

The visual impact of a cluttered desk also follows you outside the office. Every time you walk past and see the disorder, it is a reminder of work undone, decisions deferred, and systems that are not functioning. For those who work from home, this is especially significant. When the office is in view from the living spaces, the clutter does not stay contained to working hours. It lingers.

It's time to address it.

Step 1: Clear the Desk Surface

Like the dining table, the first step is to remove everything from the desk surface to get to a clear starting point. Use the Five Container System. Every item on the desk must go into one of five containers:

Keep, Relocate, Trash, Donate, and Monetary Recovery. One can use the Needs Decision container for items that require more thought but commit to addressing those within a few days. This is not a container to be hidden away permanently.

- **Keep** is for items that belong on the desk surface and are used daily. There should be very little here—your computer, a lamp, and perhaps one or two active items.
- **Relocate** covers items that belong elsewhere in the home: paperwork that needs filing, supplies that belong in a drawer, and items from other rooms that migrated here over time.
- **Trash** means exactly that. Dried-out pens that have not worked in months, broken supplies, outdated business cards, old calendars, manuals for items you no longer own, sticky notes with completed tasks—these go directly into the trash without a second look.
- **Donate** covers items in good condition that you no longer need.
- **Monetary Recovery** is for anything of genuine value worth selling, though there is typically very little of this on a desk.

Most often as you sort through the items, very little will belong on the desk surface. Your desk should hold your computer, a lamp, and the one or two things actively being worked on right now. When there is no active work, the surface should be clear. After sorting, wipe down the desk surface thoroughly. The uncluttered desk is now calm and ready. The challenge, as always, is keeping it that way.

Step 2: Tackle the Paper Problem

Paper is often the most persistent source of clutter in the home office. It accumulates faster than almost anything else—bills, receipts, school notices, warranties, articles printed to read later and never touched again, paid bills that have lingered well past their useful life. Are all the pieces of paper in this room helping you? Most of them are not. Sort all papers into four categories: Action, File, Shred, and Recycle. Work through every single piece.

Action items are those that require something from you—a bill to pay, a form to complete, a response to send. Process action items immediately or schedule a specific time to address them. Do not let them sit. File items are important documents worth keeping: insurance papers, warranties, medical records, and tax documents. For financial documents generally, seven years is the standard guideline, with tax returns kept permanently. Shred sensitive materials rather than recycling them—your personal information is on those pages. Everything else is recycled.

When in doubt about whether to keep a document, ask yourself: If I needed this again, could I find it online or request another copy? If yes, recycle it. The goal for your filing system is simple—you should be able to find any document in under two minutes. If that is not currently true, your system needs simplifying, not expanding. Label folders clearly. Keep only active or legally required documents. Go paperless when possible; switching bills and statements to digital delivery eliminates a significant source of incoming paper before it ever reaches your desk.

Going forward, apply the Touch-It-Once Rule to all incoming paper. When mail arrives, open it immediately. Junk mail and catalogs go straight into recycling before they ever reach the office. Bills go directly into the action folder or get paid on the spot. Important documents get filed right away. The pile forms when

things are put down temporarily. Temporarily, in most homes, means permanently.

Step 3: Desk Drawers, Shelves, and Storage

The desk drawers and any shelving in the office should store only items that support your work. If this is your first time decluttering this area, you will probably find non-work items that have migrated here over time. It is time to address items like these.

Start by removing the contents of each drawer and sorting through them using the Five Container System. For supplies, be honest and realistic. How many pens do you need? Test every pen and pencil and discard the ones that do not work. The quantity guidelines are practical: working pens, five to ten maximum; pencils, three to five; notebooks for active projects, two to three; sticky note pads, one to two. One small supply of each item is sufficient.

Use drawer dividers for small items when you put things back. This one step prevents the drawer from becoming a jumbled collection within weeks. When supplies have designated spots, you stop losing things and stop rebuying things you already own. Supplies you no longer need but that are still in good condition can be donated to a local school or community organization. Someone will use them. You are not wasting them—you are passing them to where they are needed.

If your office has bookshelves, apply the same honest assessment. Remove outdated reference books—software manuals from several years ago, industry guides from a field you left, textbooks from decades past. Keep only books you reference or that genuinely support your current work. Donate the ones collecting dust. Remember, you are reflecting the current chapter of your life, not chapters that have long since passed.

Step 4: Electronics and Cables

Technology accumulates quietly. You replace a device and the old one ends up in a drawer or on a shelf. Cables multiply. Chargers pile up for phones replaced years ago. Remove obsolete electronics from the office. Old phones, outdated devices, printers that no longer function, chargers without a current match—these serve no purpose in a functional workspace. Recycle old phones, chargers, and devices properly by checking your local municipality for e-waste drop-off locations rather than placing electronics in the trash.

For cables, pull every one out and lay them on a flat surface. Match each cable to a device you currently own and actively use. Label cables clearly so you can identify them immediately. Any cable you cannot match to a current device gets recycled. Use cable management solutions to keep what remains organized—a cable box, adhesive clips along the back of the desk, or simple hook-and-loop fasteners work well. When cables are labeled and managed, you stop buying duplicates of things you already have.

The Clear Desk Rule

The most important rule for maintaining your home office is simply clearing the desk surface at the end of every workday. Before you close the laptop and step away, take a few minutes to return the desk to its uncluttered state. If there is mail, send it to the mail processing area or handle it immediately. If there are papers, file them, add them to the action folder, or recycle them. Return supplies to their rightful place in the drawers.

After clearing the desk, wipe down the surface. This creates a sense of completion and signals to your brain that the workday is done. When you return the next morning to a clean desk, you are not carrying yesterday's unfinished business with you visually or

mentally. The goal is to return the uncluttered office back to that state every single workday evening.

This does not need to take long. Five minutes is typically enough. The key is consistency, not perfection. If you allow the desk to accumulate for a few days, it becomes harder to reset. If you clear it consistently, it stays manageable with almost no effort.

Creating Boundaries Around the Home Office

The home office needs established boundaries to stay functional, especially for those who work from home. There are two categories of boundaries: physical and behavioral. The physical boundaries refer to the designated homes for items and the clear rules about what belongs in this space. The behavioral boundaries refer to the habits around how and when the space is used.

If paper seems to land everywhere in the office, create a simple inbox—a small tray or basket where incoming paper lands when it first arrives. Once or twice per week, process the inbox completely: file, act, shred, or recycle. This way, paper never piles up on the desk surface itself. If supplies keep disappearing into other rooms, designate specific homes for them in the drawers and return them consistently. Physical boundaries prevent clutter creep before it starts.

The behavioral boundaries matter equally. If you work from home, set a clear end to the workday. Close the laptop. If you have a dedicated office, close the door. These physical acts send a signal to your brain that work is finished. If your office shares space with another room—a corner of the bedroom, a section of the living room—create a visual boundary through a bookshelf, a rug, or simply turning the desk chair away at the end of the day. Work materials should not remain visible in living spaces overnight. If they

do, it sends the message that work is always present, and your home stops feeling like a sanctuary.

These boundaries need to be clear to everyone in your household. It is not about being rigid, but about preserving the functionality of the space and protecting the mental separation between work and home. If there is understanding, everyone is more likely to respect the boundaries. When you enforce them consistently, everyone learns that the space matters.

The Emotional Shift

When your home office is uncluttered and functional, you will feel the difference. It will be a shift to a calmer, more focused version of your workday. Your mornings will feel lighter and easier because you are sitting down to a clear surface rather than immediately feeling behind. The work itself—the thinking, the creating, the problem-solving—will come more readily when the space around you is clear.

As you declutter and organize room by room, the momentum will build naturally. You have already worked through the entryway, the living room, the kitchen, the bathroom, the dining area, and now the home office. You are gradually moving toward and expecting order, not chaos. Each completed space reinforces that this is achievable and that the systems work.

The home office should be a space that supports your work and protects your rest. You deserve a workspace that functions smoothly. Give yourself permission to let go of the items that no longer serve your current chapter—the outdated manuals, the broken supplies, the cables with no match, the paper that has been waiting for a decision for far too long. Letting go of these things is not wasteful. It is practical.

Maintaining the Clear Space

The home office is not a one-shot, one-and-done project; none of these decluttering efforts are. However, the maintenance after the major effort is simpler because it is just execution—there are no big decisions to be made. Daily, clear the desk at the end of the workday. Weekly, process the paper inbox completely so nothing carries over. Monthly, purge old papers and files that no longer need to be kept. Quarterly, assess your office supplies and discard what has dried out, broken, or accumulated beyond what you need. Annually, do a deeper file purge and shredding session, working through every folder.

If clutter begins to creep back in, address it immediately before it becomes a problem. Sometimes the clutter creep is persistent, and in those cases, you may need to reassess and fine-tune your systems, as something may be amiss. The root cause might be that a proper home was not found for certain items, that the paper processing routine is not being followed, or that supplies are not being returned to their designated spots after use.

Remember, this process is not about perfection; it is about creating something that is functional. Sometimes you will have messy days when items pile up on the desk temporarily. This is natural; life happens. Just fix it. The desk gets reset to a clear surface at the end of the day, and everything returns to normal. This consistency is what matters.

Your home office should exist primarily to support your work and protect your time. When you honor that purpose by keeping the space clear and functional, you are honoring your own need for focus, productivity, and a clear separation between work and rest. This is not a luxury. It is a basic need that deserves protection.

CHAPTER 8

Bedrooms - Restful and Organized Retreats



Time Budget: 4–6 hours
Impact: Sleep quality, morning stress, mental peace — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

Think of your bedroom as a peaceful place where you can rejuvenate; it's not an extra storage space. It's where you wake up and wind down each day. In the bedroom, your brain can shut off, unwind, and recharge. A messy bedroom will affect your sleep quality, creating more stressful mornings and leading to increased anxiety during the day. This chapter will assist in transforming your bedroom into a more restful place.

A rule of thumb is to set aside four to six hours per bedroom. This time allotment may seem like a lot, but it's worth the initial investment. Also, a good portion of this time will be spent making clothing decisions; this is typical for most people. As you transform your bedroom, each day will feel less stressful.

The Sanctuary Principle

Your bedroom should provide a restful and peaceful sanctuary for rest. To the extent that there's clutter, it's not projecting a restful atmosphere. Look around the bedroom. What do you see? Are there piles of clothes? Are surfaces covered with random items? If so, your brain will be processing all these tasks, so it can't really relax.

The piles of chaos create anxiety in the background that affects sleep. You might think the clutter isn't affecting you, but your brain is registering it. If you have clothes on the chair, it signifies there's laundry to attend to. A stack of paper serves as a reminder of tasks you haven't yet tackled. If your closet is overflowing with clothes on the floor, it indicates that your life needs some organization. These reminders increase stress, and a high stress level prevents deep rest.

In contrast, an uncluttered and organized bedroom projects a different message to your brain. Clean surfaces indicate that things are under control, while organized spaces indicate nothing pressing needs attending to. This different messaging to the brain affects how quickly you fall asleep, how deeply you sleep, and your anxiety level when you wake up.

Your bedroom is not a storage room or a laundry holding area. At the onset, it might be a dumping ground for items that may not have a proper home. The primary purpose is rest, and everything should support that.

Step 1: Surface Clearing

The initial focus will be on the visible surfaces in the bedroom, and these include nightstands, dressers, and other flat surfaces. Flat surfaces will tend to accumulate clutter because they are convenient places to set things down.

Your nightstand should typically have a lamp, a book, and a glass of water. Other items, such as lotions, medications, old receipts, and coins, can be relocated. You're probably only reading one book at a time, so there's no need to create a bookshelf on your nightstand.

Take everything off the nightstand and sort through those items. If you're not currently reading the book, then return it to the bookshelf—or donate it if it's never going to be read. Medications should go to the bathroom medicine cabinet. Lotions also typically belong in the bathroom. Receipts should be processed or placed in the trash. Your miscellaneous coins should go in a designated coin jar. Any remaining random items get returned to their proper homes or discarded.

The dresser surface should be basically clear. The top surface may hold one or two intentional items, like a small jewelry box or a lamp. The dresser is not a catchall for mail, jewelry, wallets, or other random items; it's for storing clothes.

Start by removing everything from the dresser's surface. For larger spaces, we've categorized the items into Trash, Relocate, Donate, and Needs Decision. The dresser surface is small, and the items should be dealt with immediately. Any mail found on the dresser should go to the mail processing area. Keys go to the key hook. All the jewelry goes to the jewelry box. All the loose change goes to the coin container. All the items need to move to their designated location.

There might be a chair in the bedroom, and often it just becomes another storage location. This will be further addressed in the next section. At this point, remove everything from the chair and floor and sort it. The bedroom floor should not have any items except furniture.

After clearing the surfaces, wipe them down. The dresser and nightstand might need a bit of dusting. The cleaner surface will feel different than the cluttered one, exhibiting a calmer atmosphere and signaling that the space is cared for.

The critical point is keeping the surfaces clear going forward. Here's a useful tip to help with your maintenance: don't set miscellaneous items on the dresser. If you have jewelry, set it in the jewelry box when you take it off. If you have a glass of water by your bed, remove it in the morning. These actions prevent clutter from accumulating.

Step 2: Dealing with "the Chair"

Often, bedrooms have a chair where clothes accumulate. If not a chair, it might be a section of floor space. When you return home, you change clothes, and those clothes get draped over the chair. Sometimes, before going out, you try on an outfit and change your mind and toss that outfit on the chair. Maybe you wore a sweater outside to run an errand and returned immediately home. The sweater is still clean, so it gets draped on the chair and not thrown into the hamper. Before too long, the chair is covered in a mountain of clothes.



Why does this happen? The chair becomes the designated middle point between the clean and dirty clothes. These are the clothes that are clean enough to wear again, but since they've been worn, they're not truly clean clothes. They don't belong in the closet with the clean clothes. So, these clothes reside in limbo on the chair.

The solution is to change your mindset: there's no middle point between clean and dirty. The clothes are clean or dirty. The simple question is, would you wear this article of clothing outside again? If yes, then it's clean. Dirty clothes go to the hamper, the clean clothes to the closet or the drawer. Afterward, the chair should be empty.

This might take a bit of time, depending on the size of your pile of clothes. You may find items that have been on the chair for weeks. There might be items that are dirty but were just shifted around and never addressed.

After you've addressed the chair pile, you need to address the chair itself. Does the chair serve a functional purpose in the bedroom? Would you or anyone sit on this chair in the bedroom? If not, then remove it. If there's no chair, then there's no mountain of clothes on a chair.

The maintenance approach is to make immediate decisions on clothing. Dirty clothes go to the hamper. "Clean enough" clothes go to the closet or the drawer. This habit may take two weeks to form. Likely the first week, there will still be a pile. The second week should be automatic.

The "no middle point" rule changes things. As clothes are either clean or dirty, there can be no piles. Choosing outfits becomes easier; you go to the clean clothes and select. You aren't sifting through a pile and trying to discern the cleanliness of an article of clothing. Even doing laundry is easier because the hamper contains the dirty clothes; there are no other considerations.

Step 3: The Major Project - Clothing Declutter

We're at the most time-intensive part of the bedroom organization: decluttering clothing. This might be a four-hour project depending on your situation. This is best addressed when you have focus and are not exhausted or rushed. You'll want to have several donation bags on hand and a full-length mirror if possible.

Most people will find clothing decluttering an emotional experience. Your clothes carry memories of money spent or past chapters of your life. It could be the dress you wore on a special date, jeans when you were a different size, or professional clothes for a job you've long since left. When you let go of these items, you might feel like you're giving up parts of yourself.

If we keep the clothes we no longer wear, it doesn't preserve memories or experiences. Our memories exist within us, not inside our clothes. How does keeping a pair of jeans you can't or won't wear anymore serve you? The outdated professional wardrobe may remind you of a job you left. Why is it still there? These items are likely not bringing any joy but just taking up space.

Begin with your everyday clothes. Empty the closet and drawers onto the bed. This is a forced step because you can't sleep until you address the clothes on your bed. You need to appreciate the volume of what you own versus what you wear. Start by trying on items you haven't worn in a long time rather than relying on your memory. Provide an honest self-evaluation of each item. Does it fit now? Would you feel good if you wore it? Is it free from stains, holes, and excessive fading? If the answer to any of these questions is no, then send the item to the donation bag.

The fit test is key, as it is based on your current body, not a perceived future version of yourself. Many will struggle with this point. Some people have clothes of multiple sizes due to weight fluctuations or because they endeavor to return to a previous size.

Holding on to these old clothes creates emotional pain each time we see them.

If you lose weight, you should buy new clothes that fit your new size and today's styles to celebrate. Would you really wear clothes that were in fashion five years ago? If you keep old clothes as a source of motivation, they just take up space.

Donate and discard the clothes that don't fit you now. This is being honest with yourself and being kind. Now you're growing beyond your former self, and someone else in the world can enjoy your donated clothing.

Often, we hold a portion of the closet for special occasions. What's your current lifestyle? If you work from home, do you mostly wear casual clothes with the occasional business suit for select meetings? If so, how many business suits do you need? Do you attend one formal event per year? If so, how many dresses do you need? Keep those items you need and will use rather than items for an imaginary future someday.

We often keep formal wear items. These could be the bridesmaid dress from ten years ago, a cocktail dress used after college graduation, or the first suit you bought for your first real job. All of these represent chapters of your life that have long since passed. These physical objects are not needed to remember those chapters; these items should be donated to make space for your current chapter.

Sentimental clothes represent another group of items we often hold on to, and some of these might be worth keeping for their significance. These might be your wedding dress, a newborn's coming home outfit, or clothing that belonged to someone who has passed on. These items can be kept and stored in a labeled container in the basement; your everyday closet should be used for everyday clothes.

There are other sentimental clothes that should be donated or discarded. These might be T-shirts from concerts you attended

decades ago. Perhaps you have a team jersey for a sport you played in the past but not anymore. You may even have clothes from when you attended college. If there's a sentimental aspect, then take some photos of the items you want to remember. These can generally be discarded.

Often, there is a "someday" (aspirational) category of clothes. These are clothes for a hobby you don't do, a climate you don't live in, or even a job you don't have. These articles represent an imaginary life, not your current life. You might have ski or snowboard clothes because you thought you would take up the sport. These "someday" clothes occupy space that could be filled by your clothes today. It's better to donate them to someone who will use them. There's a skier who could use a relatively new set of attire or another who might utilize the office attire. As you donate these clothes, you'll have more space for the clothes you wear today.

Our lives have ebbs and flows, which may lead to some genuine uncertainty for some articles of clothing. For these clothes, pack them into a box labeled with today's date, and store them in the basement. Set a calendar reminder for six months from now. If you haven't retrieved an item from the box within six months, then donate the entire box. If the clothes weren't needed for over six months, it's a sign they're not necessary.

As you sort through your clothes, put them into clear categories: Keep, Donation, Trash, and Sentimental. The Keep clothes get put back in the closet or the drawers. Those that are stained or torn go to the Trash. Clothes you don't want or don't fit will go to Donation. The sentimental items go to the labeled container and are moved to the basement temporarily.

For most, this process is exhausting due to the evaluation, memories, and decision-making. You'll have the inclination to keep items to avoid making an honest decision. Push through this phase to get to a wardrobe that contains only clothes you wear and feel

good about wearing. Once you achieve this state, getting dressed each day becomes easier as you choose items you genuinely like instead of sorting through clothing you never wear.

Step 4: Under the Bed

For some, this might be an insignificant step, as there might be nothing to address. But for others, this could require some work. For many, the space under the bed is a space of unintentional storage where items are placed simply to get them out of sight. Look under the bed. Do you see some shoes, bags, socks, or things you thought you misplaced?

Extract everything out from under the bed and sort through it. Items commonly stored under the bed are off-season clothes, bedding, and shoes. Anything stored under the bed should be in suitable storage containers; there should be no random or loose items. The other items should be relocated to their proper homes or the trash.

For shoes, a rule of thumb is to use a shoe organizer. If you have more shoes than it can hold, then you probably have too many shoes. Donate any pairs that you haven't worn in the last year.

If you don't need under-the-bed storage, then leave the space empty. The empty space under your bed makes cleaning easier and prevents the area from becoming an area for clutter. Vacuuming or sweeping under the bed can be done without removing the storage containers.

Some people prefer to keep the under-the-bed space completely clear for personal, practical, and psychological reasons. Feng shui principles suggest that clutter under the bed doesn't provide restful sleep. Even if you don't believe in feng shui, there's just something calming about knowing the space under your bed is empty.

Step 5: Closet Organization

This section provides some basic closet work as it pertains to bedroom organization. The detailed closet work can be found in Chapter 10. Here, our focus is to remove items that don't belong in the bedroom.

Look through the closet and remove any non-clothing items. Some people find office supplies, decorations, or random household items. The bedroom closet should contain clothing or bedroom-related items like bedding. Any other items should be relocated.

Now that the non-bedroom items have been removed, look at the remaining clothes. Is everything crammed together, or is there sufficient spacing? The functional closet has space between items. You should be able to see what you own and access it easily. If you can barely move hangers, you have too many clothes. This is often the case. It's time for another round of decluttering.

Typically, your closet should be organized logically by hanging similar items together. The shirts hang together, the pants hang together, and the dresses hang together. This categorization makes getting dressed easier because you can see your options. When hanging clothes, try to use matching hangers if possible. Mismatched hangers create visual chaos even when the closet is organized.

The closet floor should be free of anything except possibly shoes. Shoes that you wear frequently can stay on the floor, organized with a shoe rack. Boxes and bags don't belong on the floor as they create clutter.

The goal is a closet that functions smoothly, and the test is that you can find what you need quickly. All items should have a designated spot without overflowing or cramming. This organization will make the morning routine easier, reducing stress.

Daily Maintenance: Morning and Evening Resets

After decluttering and organizing your bedroom, the maintenance routine is rather minimal. Two routines prevent accumulating clutter and preserve the calm, restorative feeling.

The morning reset is the routine of making the bed. A well-made bed will transform the bedroom; it creates order and leads to a productive day. Later in the day, when you return to the room, a made bed makes the room appear calm, whereas an unmade bed makes the room appear chaotic. Often, the morning is filled with rushing and preparing for the day, so many people will resist this step. This is something you need to consider based on your morning routine.

The advice here is to make your bed every single day without exception. This is like using a muscle that has not been used. At first, it feels unnecessary; later, it feels easier. Eventually, you'll feel odd if you don't make your bed in the mornings.

The nightly reset occurs before you sleep. This step involves putting clean clothes away into the closet or drawers, putting dirty clothes in the hamper, clearing surfaces, putting your phone on the charger, and clearing the clutter that has accumulated during the day. This will ensure that you wake up to an organized room rather than a chaotic mess. Also, it serves to promote psychological calmness during the night.

These two habits, making your bed in the morning and clearing surfaces at night, take less than ten minutes, promoting a calm feeling and supporting a restful night of sleep.

Children's Bedrooms

The children's bedrooms are covered in Chapter 9. The children's bedrooms need to go through the same decluttering exercises,

but with some appropriate age modifications. Obviously, young children can't declutter and organize by themselves, but they can participate in the process and learn habits along the way.

Children will follow the behavior they see. If your bedroom is organized and you maintain it daily, they learn that this is how spaces should be. Conversely, if your bedroom is chaotic, they learn that clutter is acceptable. Children learn more from your actions than from listening to what you say.

The Emotional Impact of an Organized Bedroom

After your bedroom is maintained in an organized and clear manner, you'll begin to perceive emotional benefits. You'll fall asleep more easily, and you'll wake up calmer. You'll feel more in control because there's less chaos around you.

In the morning, the stress reduction is powerful. A made bed and an organized room make dressing easier. You can find what you want to wear as your inventory is on full display. You aren't digging through piles of clothes. This signals the start of a calmer day.

The evening benefit is equally important. When you enter your bedroom at the end of the day, a clear and calm space helps you decompress. You can relax because the bedroom promotes a restful atmosphere. You aren't bombarded with reminders of tasks undone or decisions unmade. Your bedroom has become a place that encourages rest.

This transformation takes more effort to establish but minimal effort to maintain. The three to four hours you spend decluttering clothing and organizing your bedroom save many more hours in the future. More qualitatively, you'll have better sleep, less stress, calmer mornings, and a sense of control in at least one area of your life.

Respecting the Sanctuary

After the bedroom is decluttered and organized, guard and protect the space. If there are items that belong elsewhere, don't deposit them in the bedroom; put them in their proper location immediately. The worn clothes are either dirty and go to the hamper or clean and go to the closet or dresser. If there are items that accumulate on surfaces, then remove them by the end of the day. If other family members want to leave things in the bedroom, then redirect them to the proper location for that item.

Try not to combine activities that interfere with rest, like working in bed. Try not to watch news in bed or cave in and store extra items in the bedroom.

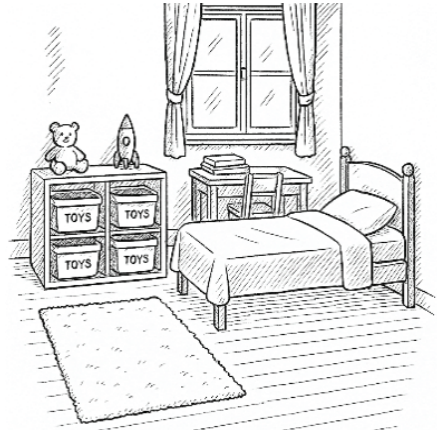
Your bedroom is a retreat from the stress of everyday life. When you adhere to that function by keeping the space organized and peaceful, you give yourself the gift of better rest and lower stress. You deserve a bedroom that serves you. You deserve to sleep in peace.

CHAPTER 9

Kids' Rooms - Fun, Order, and Independence

Time Budget: 3–5 hours per child's room
Impact: Independence, responsibility, reduced parental stress — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

A child's room works when you let them manage it. They can take responsibility for their room and begin to build independence. It's not about creating a space like those on social media or magazine covers. Children can only manage small, simple systems, and when there are too many things, they can become overwhelmed.



A good rule of thumb is to set aside three to five hours per child's room. The decluttering and organizational effort should be a collaborative project. It's not something you work on when your child is at school and then present to them. The goal is to involve them in an age-appropriate way, and in time, they can grow into more responsibilities.

The Balance

Children need the right number of toys, books, and clothes to play with and learn from. When there is too much stuff, they get overwhelmed. For example, when there are fifty stuffed toys, the child will not have a favorite because there are just too many; they can't form a view. Similarly, when there are hundreds of toys scattered, it's impossible for them to play or clean. The sheer volume of stuff makes meaningful engagement impossible.

In today's world of excess, parents are often the culprits. They may buy or accept too many items or receive hand-me-downs from friends with kids. Before long, the child's room is full of stuff—more stuff than the child can constructively play with, let alone maintain.

The solution is to keep the toys to a manageable number. It's not deprivation but liberation. When there are fewer toys, they will play more deeply with them rather than jumping from one toy to another. If there are fewer clothes, getting dressed is easier because there are fewer choices, and even the laundry becomes easier.

You want to design a room that gives your child room for responsibility and independence. Too many belongings can get in the way of this. A room full of toys promotes accumulation, whereas a manageable number teaches them to value what they have and care for their belongings.

Age-Appropriate Involvement

The level of involvement and the role will vary based on the age of your child. Teenagers should take charge of the process, with input from the parents. They should decide which items to keep and which to discard. The parental role is to enforce standards for cleanliness and give latitude to teenagers. This relative level of autonomy reflects their growth toward adulthood.

Tweens—that is, children between the ages of nine and twelve—should collaborate equally with the parents. When sorting through their belongings, they'll have significant input on those items to keep and discard, with the parents helping to validate those decisions. The parents can help by providing observations, such as which toys have not been used recently or which clothes are no longer worn. Tweens can understand logic and can actively participate in the organization process.

Young children, between the ages of five and eight, require parents to lead while they give input on their likes and dislikes. Parents can make the fundamental decisions, while the children can tell them about their favorite toys. At this age, children can only provide input to the process.

Toddlers, between the ages of two and four, need parents to do the work while they "help" with simple choices. The parents can hold up two toys and ask which one they want to keep. Parents make real decisions while giving the toddlers the feeling of participation. The toddler age group benefits from organization but can't meaningfully contribute to creating it.

Regardless of age, parents should involve their children to the extent they can participate. This teaches children valuable skills about evaluating belongings, making decisions, and maintaining order. Toddlers, young children, tweens, or teenagers who learn these skills will carry them into the future.

Step 1: The Toy Tsunami

Toys are a challenge for parents today when managing clutter. This is driven by a variety of factors: the number of toys many kids have, the constant inflow of toy inventory, and parents who want their children to have everything. The decluttering effort starts by categorizing toys into groups such as cars, dolls, and blocks. From these groups, parents can see the sheer amount of each type of toy.

When parents can see piles of stuffed animals, the excess will be undeniable. No child can reasonably play with so many stuffed toys. This excess is why children's rooms often feel so cluttered.

To drive decluttering and organization, we use containers. The size of the storage container determines the number of stuffed animals to keep. Your child chooses the favored stuffed animals that will comfortably fit into the bin with the lid closed properly. Any excess that does not fit into the category bin gets donated.

For the category bins solution, the bins need to fit into a place like a wall shelf. It sets the boundary for the bin size and the number of toys. This does not mean that parents should purchase larger containers to hold more toys. When children receive a new stuffed animal, for example, they must choose which stuffed animal to donate and which to keep.

One useful technique is to set number limits for each toy category. For example, for stuffed toys, the limit might be five to ten. (Children only have a few favorites they gravitate towards. The rest sit in the pile unused.) For building blocks, the approach is a bit different. The bin size should be driven by what allows the children to build something meaningful without making cleanup inefficient. A guideline is that the building block clean-up time shouldn't exceed twenty minutes. If the child spends twenty minutes playing and it takes an hour to clean up the building blocks, then there are simply too many blocks.

Over time, toys become broken or incomplete. You may observe that some puzzles have pieces that have gone missing and will never be found. Similarly, some games may have missing parts. These should be discarded. There's no sense in holding onto a puzzle you can't complete or games you can't play because key components are missing; they are just taking up space.

Cheap plastic toys that you receive for "free" should be thrown away. Think about kids' meal toys as an example. They're not quality toys. They were useful for engagement when you had the meal, but afterwards, they're tossed aside. They're of low quality.

Parents and children should sit together in the sorting phase and discuss the children's likes and dislikes. Children will pretty much tell you which toys make the cut and which should be voted out. This will make the decluttering and donation efforts easier as parents don't need to keep what their children don't want.

Some toys will have sentimental value. Here, we apply similar logic as for adult items. Select and keep a few special toys as keepsakes and donate the rest.

Once the sorting phase is complete, organize the toys logically. Similar toys live together in the same labeled bin. The groups might be building blocks, stuffed animals, dolls, action figures, play cookware, etc. It's best to use clear bins so children can see the contents without reading the labels. Sometimes, a picture of the contents on the side of the bin, such as a picture of the building block, is helpful to illustrate the contents.

As you design their storage system, sit down at the child's height to see the world from their perspective. Then, create a system to store toys based on the child's height. If your child can't reach the shelves to put the toys away independently, then the system doesn't work. You want low shelves, accessible bins, and child-height hooks. When a child can access and clean up their toys by themselves, then they are more likely to do so.

Step 2: Books

Children's books will tend to accumulate as they age. You may still have books from when they were newborn through to their toddler years. There have been birthdays, new purchases, and hand-me-downs since they were born. You probably have many books that never get used but just sit on the bookshelf.

Start by emptying that bookshelf and sorting the books. One technique is to sort the books by age and only keep the age-appropriate books. If your child is now on chapter books, then donate the board books. Ask your child which books they like and read. They will readily point out silly books or books they don't want for various reasons. Donate these also, as there's no sense in keeping items they won't look at.

The goal is to select an optimal number of books that are appropriate and of interest to your child. The books need to fit on the bookshelf in such a way that your child can self-select the books with little effort. The titles need to be visible, and there needs to be space for your child to pull out books easily.

Some books may pertain to seasons or holidays. There may be special books for winter, summer, or special days like Halloween, Easter, or Christmas. These books don't need to remain on the bookshelf throughout the year. These seasonal books can be stored in a container in the closet to keep the bookshelf manageable and can be rotated out when the occasion arises.

Sometimes there may just be too many legitimate books for the bookshelf. In these cases, you can have a bin your child can "check out" books from and return to when finished. This will keep the bookshelf from overflowing.

Step 3: Artwork and School Papers

Today's school children create vast amounts of paperwork and artwork. Weekly, there can be a substantial stack of papers returning home for these efforts. If you keep everything from school, you'll need several boxes per year to house it.

For commemorative items, select the pieces to keep. One option is to save things that commemorate special days like Mother's Day or showcase developmental effort. These select items can be saved in a flat storage box. Other artwork can be saved through digital photo albums organized by school year. In this way, you can share photos with friends and relatives without storing boxes of paper. Your child can help choose and explain the items they are most proud of.

Practice papers, worksheets, assignments, and tests generally don't need to be kept and should be discarded. The work was performed, the knowledge gained, and holding onto these items is of no value.

For special projects that took significant effort or showcase special creativity, save one or two per year.

Children can have a memorabilia box. One approach is to use a standard file box per child for all their school years. The box might contain report cards, special awards, and selected artwork.

Overall, these outlined approaches prevent storing boxes of artwork and school paper you will never open or view again. The most precious items can be saved in a memorabilia box or flat box, which are easily accessible.

Step 4: Clothes

Children grow quickly and will outgrow their clothes in no time. Most parents buy or acquire too many clothes for their children. The clothes may be bought, hand-me-downs, or gifts. However

they're acquired, too many clothes create the same problem as too many toys. It creates decision fatigue, cluttered dressers, and difficult laundry.

A good working rule is seven outfits maximum for the season. This means seven of everything: pants, tops, socks, and underwear. This is sufficient for the week and the days between laundry, but not so many that the choices become overwhelming. You may have a little bit extra for special occasions, but seven is a good baseline number. Seven outfits ensure that each article of clothing will make it through the cycle without a pile of clothes being ignored.

Once you discover that an article of clothing doesn't fit or is too worn, remove it from the rotation. Don't pass it over as you search for the current day's outfit.

For hand-me-downs, have a system to address them if you have multiple children. When one child outgrows clothes, immediately sort them. Those that are in good condition go into a labeled bin for the next child, while items that are stained, worn, or damaged get trashed or used as rags.

Enact a seasonal clothing rotation to manage the space and wardrobe. Rotate the new season's clothes in from the storage bin and place the old season's clothes in the storage bin. This introduces variety and ensures that there's a review of clothing. Through this process, you'll see if there are clothes that no longer fit and should be released.

Teach your child to manage their clothes. Dirty clothes go in the hamper immediately, while the clean clothes go to the closet or the dresser. This habit prevents the clothing pile that is found in many children's rooms.

Step 5: The Nightly Pickup Routine

If you set a nightly routine to maintain organization, it will go a long way toward keeping the children's rooms in order. Set aside about five or ten minutes each day where your child can help return things to their proper location. It's best to utilize the same slot daily, whether it be before bath time or bedtime. If you adhere to the routine, you'll find that the consistency will help your children.

The purpose of this routine is to set the room back to an organized state after the daily activities. The golden rule is that if there's something on the floor other than furniture, then relocate it to the proper location. The work is complete when there's nothing left on the floor. The decluttering effort should have created a system of organized toy bins, so the toys need to return to these bins. The bookshelves were decluttered, so the books just need to return to their spot. If there's clothing lying around, then hang it in the closet, put it in the hamper, or fold it in the dresser.

A helpful tip is to make this a game to motivate your kids. You can set a timer and watch your kids run around, organizing and trying to beat the timer. Put a song on the speaker, as some kids like to sing a cleanup song when tidying up. You can award points to each child who returns an item to its rightful location.

As children get older, the routine will become more ingrained. They've readily internalized the reward or benefits of the cleanup routine. If the room isn't clean, you could impose a delay in screen time or no screen time.

This evening routine prevents a messy room from reappearing because you're resetting the major areas daily. As toys begin to accumulate, they're returned to their bins before the pile grows out of control. If there are clothes on the floor, they're returned to their specified location. When morning arrives, everyone wakes up to an organized room. Getting dressed in the morning is easier because the

clothes and toys are where they should be; this promotes a calmer start to the morning.

This routine is usually met with streams of protest. Children may whine, complain, and stall. At this point, many parents relinquish and abandon the routine. But push through and persist through the first week. The next week things will become easier, although you may still need to power through. In fact, it will take about six weeks to firmly ingrain this routine so that kids can do it themselves. The alternative is you, as the parent, taking on larger organizational tasks every few weeks to compensate. This routine will build organizational habits that continue from childhood to the teen years and then young adulthood.

Teaching Independence

The goal of organizing your child's room is to teach them independent space management. To achieve this, parents need to put systems in place that the children can use.

As we mentioned earlier in the chapter, the storage bins should be clear plastic and labeled. These labels and clear plastic containers will help children to see the contents of the bins without emptying them out to find what they want to play with.

The systems you set up need to be simple. The system can't be complicated and organized by size, shape, and color. Think of broad categories like all blocks together, all books, all dolls; this is something kids can manage. After the system is set, teach them the system and let them do it independently. Sit back and be the observer and not the doer; try not to jump in or directly fix their organizational efforts. If the children can organize well enough, consider that a win. Remember—we're striving for independence, not perfection.

If your child cleans their room independently, show praise and congratulate them. Don't focus on items that may have been slightly misplaced or bins that are not being perfectly organized. Positive reinforcement and encouragement give them motivation.

Managing Gift-Giving Relatives

Living in large or extended families often promotes generous gift-giving. Grandparents love to give gifts for every occasion, and on top of this, there will be gifts from aunts, uncles, and various family friends. Before long, these gifts can accumulate and take up a lot of space.

To curb or control some generous gift-giving relatives, here are some approaches.

Some families create a holiday list for relatives to choose from, and this helps ensure that gifts are useful. Other families focus on nonmaterial items like zoo memberships or college fund contributions. Another popular approach is the **four gift rule**: things you want, things you need, things you wear, and things you read. This helps children to receive diverse gifts rather than just toys.

After a major onslaught of new toys, evaluate the toys. As one new toy comes in, another old toy goes out. Give children input as to which toys get voted out. This maintains the overall quantity, prevents accumulation, and teaches children decision-making. Your overall goal is to manage toy clutter. If the gifts are too excessive, just quietly donate them before things get out of hand.

The Rotation System

Some families have a lot of toys and can't let go of enough inventory. These families can use the toy rotation system to manage their large inventory of toys. This system recommends storing one-half

to two-thirds of the toys in the closet or an area where the toys are not currently in use. Only about one-third to one-half of the toys are actively used by the child. At a set time, rotate the unused toys with the used toys. This can be achieved by either putting away the current set and bringing in a new set or rotating in a way that maintains the number of toys actively being used.

The rotation system creates a sense of newness. Old toys become exciting when they reappear. And if there's a smaller number of toys, children engage more with each rather than jumping from toy to toy.

The rotation system requires discipline, as you must commit to the rotation plan. If there's no rotation, you're simply storing unused toys under the guise of rotation. If this is the case, you should just keep the best toys and donate the rest. If you don't maintain the number actively in use, then you've just increased the volume, and this will increase the clutter.

This rotation system isn't necessary if you declutter to a reasonable quantity, that is, the manageable number of toys your child uses. But it's an option if you're unable to reduce the quantity and acts as a useful compromise.

Respecting Your Child's Space

Your child's room is their personal space, so they should have growing autonomy as they age. You should focus on setting boundaries for cleanliness and quantity and give allowance for their autonomy.

Allow your children to have artistic license. If they want their stuffed toys on their bed rather than in a bin, that's fine, so long as it's functional. If they want toys on a shelf rather than in a bin, that's fine as long as it's organized.

As children grow older, privacy is important, so don't forget to knock, especially in a teenager's room. Don't micromanage every

detail, as teenagers need their independence. There will be a need to maintain order and cleanliness, but this needs to be balanced with self-expression. Your kids may have posters or decorations you don't agree with, but that's part of their natural development.

The Long-Term Goal

The initial goal is to help your child declutter and organize, creating a neater space. But more broadly, it's about teaching life skills that they will carry with them into the future. It's about decision-making and valuing and assessing quality over quantity. You show them that sometimes less is more and that it's important to care about their belongings.

Children who can clean their room reduce the parental workload. There's no need to nag your children to clean their room because they have their own routine. This allows parents to focus their energies on other efforts.

Take the time to set this up at the onset and involve your children in age-appropriate ways. Monitor the maintenance procedures. The investment of three to five hours per room and nightly maintenance should relieve significant future work.

CHAPTER 10

Closets and Hidden Storage - Out of Sight, Not Out of Mind



Time Budget: 4–8 hours for all closets and storage areas
Impact: Functionality of valuable real estate, prevention of "black holes" — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

Closets and other hidden storage places represent valuable real estate. When these spaces are functional and organized, your life will become easier. You might have some closets filled floor to ceiling with boxes of things, with no apparent organization. When something is needed, the boxes get pulled out in search of that one item. This isn't the way it should be. If the closet is working properly, you can find what you need when you need it on your own.

Typically, set aside four to eight hours to work through the closets and storage areas of your home. As you address these spaces, you maximize your useful real estate and sidestep further accumulation.

The Hidden Storage Problem

Out of sight, out of mind: this saying is pertinent to the closet space and other storage spaces. When you can't see something, you forget you have it, and then you will never use it. Envision some of your current closet spaces. For example, your hallway closet: What items do you hold at the right end of the closet? Similarly, think about the highest shelf in the linen closet. Do you know what's there? Some people store things in the attic, but have you ever ventured to the attic to retrieve a stored item? Do all the items make a one-way trip, never to be seen again? These items are taking up space with no benefit.

Closets are dumping grounds for items we've made no firm decision about. You probably have items you didn't know what to do with, so you shoved them into the closet, never to be addressed or seen again. Maybe guests were en route. Surfaces were cleared, and everything ended up in the closet and never resurfaced. Over time, the closet was filled with items you made no decision about.

When your storage isn't accessible, you won't access or use what you own. If your camping gear is under all the boxes in the most inaccessible place in the closet, you aren't going to go camping without a deeply motivating factor. If a winter coat or scarf is buried under bags, you aren't going to find it; you'll just end up buying another scarf rather than going through the effort. Over time, you'll waste money as you buy duplicate items, replacing things you already have.

Like other rooms, your closets need to be decluttered and organized to be functional. You should only keep items that you use.

Step 1: Hall and Coat Closets

The coat closet is a good place to start, and this is usually the closet closest to the entryway. This closet serves as a permanent spot for coats in season, clothing accessories, shoes, and umbrellas. For many, this closet may currently be a catchall for anything that needs to be out of sight.

First, remove all items from the closet and place them in a visible nearby location so that you can see everything you own. Once you have an empty closet, vacuum and fully wipe it down. It's best to start the decluttering process with a clean and empty closet before repopulating it with useful items.

Sit down and look at the pile of items in front of you and reflect on them. You'll likely notice violations noted in previous chapters. For example, you might see coats for all seasons rather than only the current season. Beyond that, there may be children's coats that you aren't sure fit your children. Another common discovery is the quantity of items. Maybe you have five winter coats but usually choose between two.

Begin by sorting the closet piles into categories of items to Keep, Relocate, Donate, or Trash. Keep in mind that this closet should contain the current season's coats and entry-related items. If you have multiple seasons of coats, institute a rotational program. Every season, rotate into the coat closet the current season's clothes and shoes and rotate out the prior season's items. This promotes a functional closet without overflow.

As you sort, take stock of the duplicates and decide which items you want to keep and which should go. If you have five winter coats but really only wear two, then three should go. Try to determine if five winter coats are necessary to begin with. This same thought process should be applied to your jackets and other items for different seasons. If there are many children's coats present, then

check them against your children's current sizes and current needs. Since children grow quickly, some are likely too small and ready for donation. There may also be items that have nothing to do with the entryway, and these should be relocated to their proper destination.

A smaller tip applies to umbrellas: try to have one or two umbrellas on hand per adult. You may have umbrellas that don't fully open or have broken spokes aren't going to be fixed, so just launch them into the trash.

After sorting through the closet pile, repopulate the closet using functionality in your organization. The rod should contain the current season's coats, with the most frequently used items made the most accessible. Use a shelf for hats, scarves, and gloves, and place them in a basket for ease of access. If the closet is close to the entryway, the storage of shoes here is sensible. The floor space can be used to house a shoe rack or organizer.

When the decluttering is finished and the closet is organized, establish a system of maintenance. This really means periodically returning items to their designated spots and ensuring seasonal rotation. This maintenance keeps the closet functional throughout the year.

Step 2: Bedroom Closets - The Deep Dive

In Chapter 8, Step 5, the focus was to remove items that didn't belong in the bedroom. Here we explain the detailed closet work. Clothes are responsible for a large amount of the clutter in the home, and many of them are found in the bedroom closet. It can be a big project, but the approach is to attack the closet in three zones: hanging clothes, shelves, and the floor.

Let's start with the clothes on hangers. Do you know which clothes you wear on a regular basis? The key is to identify the hanging clothes that you use on a regular basis. Try this technique:

turn all the hangers in one direction. When you wear an item, return and hang the item back in the closet in the opposite direction. After six months, clothes hanging in the original direction have not been worn and should be evaluated as donation items. This technique is objective and provides data. It's not what you *think* happens; it is what has happened over six months. When you see ten shirts that haven't moved, it's hard to argue with this data.

If you have wire hangers that come from the dry cleaners, remove them and replace them with real hangers. When you use matching hangers, it creates visual appeal and is more functional. Your clothes hang more sturdily and are less likely to fall off. The same style hangers give a uniform and organized appearance even when the closet is full. Some like wooden hangers, while others think velvet-covered hangers work well; whatever the case, choose one type per bedroom and stick with it.

The hanging clothes should be organized categorically, then by colors within that category. So, all shirts should live together, then pants, dresses, etc. With shirts, organize them by short and long sleeves and by color from light to dark. This method ensures that you zone in on the appropriate shirt each day. For example, in the winter you'll probably wear long sleeves, and based on the attire, your shirt will be color coordinated.

During the organizational process, apply a fit and wear test to each item. First, does an article of clothing fit? Second, do you wear the item? If the answer to both questions is no, the item should be launched into the donation pile. Don't keep items for miscellaneous reasons, such as if you lost some weight it might fit, the item was expensive, or it just needs some repair and then it would be fine. These items need to go, and you need to declutter.

Let's look at shelving. Closet shelving should hold sweaters, jeans, sweatshirts, and other folded items. Again, apply the fit and wear test to each item. For items you want to keep, fold sweaters, jeans, and

sweatshirts into separate piles. Keep similar items in designated areas of shelving. You should be able to see the items you want to access, and those items should be accessible without disturbing other piles of clothing. If you can't, you have too much clothing.

The closet floor should be used for shoes in organizers or racks and seasonal items in labeled bins. It shouldn't contain loose, random items or bags of things. If there are items scattered on the closet floor, your closet is not organized.

Try to conduct a quantity reality check on accessories. For men, shoes should probably come to seven to twelve pairs total. This includes work shoes, casual shoes, athletic shoes, and formal shoes. If you have thirty pairs of shoes, you're not wearing most of them. Keep the ones that fit well, are comfortable, and match your actual lifestyle. Donate the rest. For women, the number of shoes might be double that of men's shoes. The shoe count for both men and women mentioned here is lower than the average shoe count in the United States but more aligned with a decluttering philosophy.

Purses and bags should total three to five at most. Logistically, this includes one everyday bag, one work bag if needed, one formal bag for special occasions, and maybe one casual weekend bag. You do not need fifteen purses, so keep your favorites and donate the others. The same goes for belts and accessories. Again, these purse estimates and accessories are lower than the United States average for women, and the guidance here is to align with the goal of having less stuff.

After decluttering and organizing, the bedroom closet should feel more spacious and functional. It should be easier to see what you own, and there shouldn't be things hidden under piles of clothes. The hangers should slide easily along the rod and not be too crowded. The shelves should be accessible, and any item should be reachable. The floor should be clear except for organized shoe

storage and seasonal bins. This functionality makes getting dressed easier and ensures you're using the things you own.

Step 3: Linen Closets

Most households will have linen closets that hold many more items than their households need. Open that linen closet and look up and down and at each shelf. Do you know what's really on each shelf beyond what is clearly visible? Looking at the floor, is it an eclectic mix of items that are not linen?

Let's start with sheets. The rule of thumb is that you need two sheets per bed maximum. One set is on the bed, and the other is the spare. If the one on the bed is dirty, you either wash it and replace it on the bed or utilize the spare. If you have a guest bedroom and a lot of guests, you might consider three sheets per bed. Depending on your bed sizes, you may be able to use the same spare sheets on all the beds to reduce the number needed.

If you recently changed your bed size or mattress, evaluate if the fitted sheets are relevant. Did you upgrade the twin bed to a double bed, making the twin sheets irrelevant? Irrelevant sheets or excessive sheets should be donated.

Next, examine your towel count. The rule of thumb is three towels per person maximum. This includes bath towels, hand towels, and washcloths. Depending on your laundry cycle, two towels might be sufficient for a weekly laundry cycle; otherwise, go with three. Beach towels should be two per person; you probably aren't at the beach that often. These towels can be kept in the seasonal bin as you do not use them throughout the year.

You may have worn towels and mismatched towels; these can be used as rags or donated to animal shelters.

The blanket count should be limited to one extra blanket per bed and two for guests. For most, if the everyday beds have enough blankets, then a few guest blankets should be sufficient.

Other types of linens may be housed in the linen closet, such as tablecloths, cloth napkins, and decorative blankets. The quantity of these should be based on an assessment of your typical party size plus two extras. You need to accurately assess if they're ever used.

Here, the shelf-by-shelf rule should be applied. If you pile items on top of other items to fit everything into the closet, then there's too much stuff. Within the linen closet, you should have organized stacks of linens with some bins to aid the organization. You don't want towers of linens precariously stacked with a good chance of toppling over.

Some families use the linen closet to house medical supplies. In this case, check for expired medications and toss those immediately. If there are duplicate items, consolidate; you want to have backup consumables but not duplicates.

Non-linen items and nonmedical supplies need to be assessed and relocated to their proper location, which may be Trash or Donations. These items were probably shoved into the closet because there was an opportunity for them to live there.



Try to assign each shelf a category, such as sheets, towels, etc. For each category, sort by size. If you're storing medical supplies here, then use labeled bins. This organization allows you to find things more quickly.

Step 4: Attic, Basement, and Long-Term Storage

Attics, basements, and other long-term storage areas have a way of holding onto things. They start out as temporary storage and

somehow become permanent as the items are forgotten. Eventually, years pass, accumulation happens, the cycle continues, and you've forgotten what's there.

The approach for these areas is to pretend you're moving residences. If you were moving to a new house, would each box or item stored be moved to the new house? If the answer is no, then discard or donate the contents. The approach is simple: if it's a box being stored, open it and review. If it's an item being stored, then give it due consideration. Don't let any box bypass the evaluation.

When you begin to open boxes, the contents will fall into some common categories such as sentimental items, schoolwork, seasonal decor, etc.

Sentimental items are the most stored items. For sentimental items, set quantity limits and choose a specific-sized container. A large plastic bin is a good candidate, and it forces prioritization. Many items are sentimental but not items you should be keeping. In these cases, you can digitize the items by taking photographs. This might be your children's artwork or awards. Only keep the physical item if the object is essential to hold the memory. An example might be your grandmother's wedding ring. Other items from your grandmother, like her coffee mugs, would likely not be worth keeping. Essentially, the memories live within you, not within the items. Remember, you can think of your life as a book, and you are currently in a specific chapter. Keep items from your current chapter and only some meaningful items from the past chapters.

Memorabilia should be treated like sentimental items. Generally, you can take digital photographs. This is a sensible approach as this will make them shareable and safe. Awards and trophies should be limited to a few favorites.

For your kids' schoolwork, try to target three to five school projects to keep each year that showcase growth and development.

For the other items, photograph or scan them to maintain a record of them while discarding the originals.

For seasonal decor, one designated bin should be sufficient for minor holidays such as Halloween or Easter. For Christmas, you might have three to four bins. That said, realistically evaluate your needs at each holiday. For Christmas decorations, if you have three bins but only have a small tree on the mantle, then you have too much seasonal decor.

There's a category of storage of items held because we "might need it someday." This might include things like old electronics, sporting equipment, craft supplies, and maybe some backup appliances. This is where money may have been wasted in the past. Although the money spent may have been wasteful, holding onto older equipment is not constructive, as the money was already spent and is a sunk cost. These items are only taking up space.

When adding items to these locations and storing for the future, apply the "someday" test. Do you have concrete plans to use the item in the next year? Could it be cheaper to rent when you use this in the future? Often the answer is that it's not advantageous to store the item.

Sometimes you have small appliances that are very rarely used, like a bread maker, a mixer, or an extra microwave. You must weigh the possibility that you'll use them against storage space or cost.

If you use shelving for storage, use heavy-duty shelving to maximize both vertical and horizontal space. For nine-foot ceilings, build or buy an eight-foot shelf to maximize storage. Also consider the length of the shelves; it may be advantageous to extend the shelving the length of the wall for a consistent look. The bins on the shelf should be clear so that the contents inside can be seen, with easy-to-read labels. If something needs to be retrieved, you should be able to go to the shelving unit, read the labels, and verify by looking

through the contents of the bin. There should be no need to move multiple boxes in search of the desired item.

Whether storing things on shelving, in storage, or in the attic, group the items by categories. Keep the outdoor items together in one area, sorted by categories like camping or skiing. For items that are used more often, make them easily accessible; store the others higher up or more out of reach.

Once set, commit to not adding to your long-term storage without removing something from it. When you're considering storing an item, you need to consider if it's worthwhile. Often, you'll find that it's more of a candidate for donation.

Maintaining Organized Closets and Storage

After the closets and storage areas have been decluttered and organized, the challenge is to maintain them. They're prone to accumulation because these spaces are out of sight, and items can be set there and forgotten. Try to resist shoving items into these spaces when you don't know what to do with them. If they need a proper home, then find that home. The one-in, one-out rule prevents accumulation. If you buy a new coat, then donate one coat rather than transferring it to storage.

Always keep your storage areas accessible. Don't stack bins so high that some are unreachable without collapsing your bin tower or hide bins behind other bins. If the bins become inaccessible, the storage is dysfunctional.

Conduct seasonal closet reviews. As you rotate out the seasonal clothes, evaluate the items that were worn during the prior season. Any items that you didn't wear this season aren't likely to be used next year, so donate them during the seasonal swap rather than storing them.

Conduct a review of your long-term storage annually. Once per year, walk through your attic, basement, or storage area and take stock of the stored items. Decide if those items are still needed. This will prevent your storage areas from becoming space for items that are never used.

The Psychological Shift

Before you organized your storage areas, you probably felt uncertain about what you owned and might have made some "just in case" purchases of items you already owned. After your organizational efforts, there's a psychological shift. You'll feel more in control. You'll have functional storage areas. You'll know where things are and belong.

When you can see and know what you have, you'll naturally stop buying duplicate items. There will be no more "just in case" items. You'll no longer avoid decisions by tucking items in the closet because you're organized and now there's no room to avoid.

Closets and storage areas are valuable pieces of real estate. When organized, they become functional and enhance your daily life rather than hiding chaos. The time spent implementing order gives you less stress and helps you access your belongings with more confidence.

CHAPTER 11

Bathrooms - Clean, Functional, and Stress-Free



Time Budget: 2–3 hours per bathroom
Impact: Daily efficiency, safety, visual calm — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

Your bathroom is used very frequently in the home due to the necessity of personal hygiene, grooming, and personal care. Even though it's a relatively small space, it tends to feel cluttered or overcrowded with products.

Typically, you can expect to set aside two to three hours per bathroom. The organized bathroom will make your daily routines smoother, reduce stress, and help manage your product inventory with clear surfaces and items that are easily accessible.

The High-Frequency Space

The high-frequency nature of the bathroom means that, with each trip, any clutter and disorganization is revisited, creating frustration. If you can't find your toothbrush on the counter because there are

too many items, that's annoying. When you open a drawer and several items spill out, that's frustrating. Disorganization is when you knock over bottles in the shower looking for your shampoo.

Your bathroom might be as small as eighty square feet, so counter space is limited and storage is minimal. When you have a cluttered counter or the storage can't handle what you've accumulated, the space feels chaotic. Visual clutter has a disproportionate effect because your eyes have nowhere to rest.

Functional items must be easy to access, which doesn't necessarily mean these items stay on the counter or on the shower ledge. They need to be accessible, while their backups and rarely used products remain out of sight.

Like other areas of the house, you want the bathroom to project a calm and clean feel; this sets the tone for the start of the day and to wind down at night.

Step 1: Medicine Cabinet and Under Sink

Looking through the medicine cabinet, most people will find expired medications, old cosmetics, and skincare products past their shelf life. Examine medications for the expiration date and trash those that have long since passed. When someone is sick, you need medications that work. Expired medications are not helpful in that moment of need.

Cosmetics also have recommended life spans. Mascara lasts about three months after opening, foundation lasts up to two years depending on the type, and lipstick lasts two years. Sunscreen generally lasts about one year after opening. When you can't remember when you opened a product, it has probably expired.

Skincare products also have shelf lives after opening. Serums last at most one year. Moisturizers have separation or discoloration when they've gone bad. If there's a change to the texture or smell,

then it has gone bad. Here's something to remember: when in doubt, throw it out.

There are common culprits that reside in the medicine cabinet. Look for them and remove them. Think opened and half-empty bottles of lotions you no longer use, samples of makeup, and hotel toiletries you collected but never used. These are items you haven't used; you aren't suddenly going to start using them now. Most of these items should be trashed, but unopened hotel toiletries may be acceptable at some homeless shelters.

After removing the unused items, clean and wipe down the shelf space before returning those items you intend to use. Set the items back by category—for example, medications, first aid, and skin care products.

Looking in the cabinet under the sink, you'll typically find a mix of cleaning products, hair tools, beauty products, and miscellaneous items. Pull the under-the-sink items out and sort them into the typical categories of Trash, Relocate, and Donation. Group the remaining items by category.

For consumables, apply the **one backup principle**. For shampoo, you should have one in use and one as backup. If you have more than that, you have too many and need to use up the extras over time. This same principle applies to conditioner, body wash, and other consumables.

Cleaning supplies are often kept under the sink. Commonly there are an eclectic mix of brands, some open while others were never used. Consolidate and use up the supplies before purchasing additional supplies, adhering to the one backup principle.

Bins or caddies can be used to improve organization. You can group hair products and tools together in a bin, first aid supplies in another, and cleaning supplies separately. It's easier to focus on the bin to retrieve the required item. Also, you don't want items to get mixed together.

The space under the sink is limited. If you're forcing items in or stacking items precariously, then you have too much stuff. You need to be able to see the item or bin you want and access it without moving multiple items to get to it.

Step 2: Shower and Tub

Although small, the shower or the tub ledge can accumulate a fair amount of clutter from shampoo, conditioner, body wash, facial scrubs, masks etc. Just looking through the bottles on display can give the viewer a bit of stress.

Collect all the bottles from the shower or tub and assess the inventory. Determine if there are bottles that aren't being used by any member of the household; discard these bottles. If there are duplicate bottles of the same product, consolidate them into one container. There might be products you don't like the smell of or items that make your hair feel strange. Just discard these items, as holding them is not going to increase their likeability.

The rule of thumb is to maintain five to seven bottles maximum per shower or tub. The typical product necessities are shampoo, conditioner, bodywash, shave cream, and face wash. If the bathroom is shared with a partner, you can increase the shampoo and conditioner count. Keep in mind that some bottles can be shared. If children are sharing a bathroom, they can share products appropriate for them. Generally, you won't require multiple bottles of shampoo unless different family members have specific needs.

Some showers have a built-in niche. Use this niche to limit the products. If there's no niche or it's a tub, use a caddie to limit the products. When trying a new product, finish the old one or discard a product so there's room for it. Arrange the products by accessibility. The shampoo, conditioner, and body wash should be the most

accessible. Other products that are used less frequently should be less accessible.

From the maintenance standpoint, thwart accumulation before it occurs. Don't leave empty bottles in the shower or tub; toss them in the trash. If there's a new product that doesn't suit your taste, discard it. Use the caddie or the built-in niche to keep yourself from accumulating too many products.

Step 3: Countertop

The bathroom countertop should have a minimal number of items on top. In contrast, many people's bathroom counters have various products, useless decorative items, and other random objects. These conditions make the countertop difficult to wipe down due to the extra effort required to move the clutter around.

The countertop should hold essentials like a soap dispenser, toothbrush holder, and a few cosmetics that are used daily. Other useful bathroom items should go in the drawers or cabinets. Some people have decorative items, such as decorative rocks or a candle that's never lit. These items often take up space and don't serve a real purpose, so they should be removed.

Hair tools like hair dryers, straighteners, and curling irons shouldn't be permanently based on the countertop unless they're used daily. Otherwise, relocate them to a cabinet or drawer.

For items that belong on the counter, organize them logistically. If there's a bar of soap versus a dispenser, consider using a dispenser; it promotes a tidier appearance. Toothbrushes need a holder to allow the water to drain properly, rather than using a cup where the water pools at the bottom. Group the countertop in a logical format so that it looks purposeful or intentional and not random.

Having only the designated items on the countertop and nothing extra makes the countertop feel larger. If the surface is covered with

items, it just feels smaller and cluttered. This is psychological but does have an impact.

When the countertop is set, commit to maintaining it. Each item should be returned to its storage location after use so that only the essentials remain on the countertop.

Step 4: Drawers

Bathroom drawers can become quickly disorganized as smaller items migrate and mix. Hair ties will mix with bobby pins if thrown in a drawer. If the drawers don't have any organization, they will quickly become a mess of items, making it hard to locate anything.

All the bathroom drawers' contents should be emptied, sorted, and categorized. Some of the common categories are hair accessories, first aid items, cosmetics, and tools like tweezers and nail clippers. In the process of categorizing and sorting, discard items that are broken, expired, or just useless.

The key to maintaining organization in drawers is using dividers and creating compartments. You want to create zones for like items to stay separate from other items. The hair ties might live in one area, close to the bobby pins; cotton swabs live in their own compartment, but in a different zone. Similar items should be grouped together so that all hair tools and accessories are in one drawer, first aid in one location, and cosmetics in another location. You want to be efficient with your use of space. Shallow drawers work better for smaller items like cosmetics and hair ties, while deeper drawers are more useful for larger items like hair tools and product bottles. Categorization and organization make things easier to find and give you a good idea of when to restock certain items. If you're holding excessive duplicates and rarely used items, discard them. Some duplicates may be necessary, like a few lip balms or hairbrushes, but you only need a few.

After organizing, each item should have a specific spot so that putting items away becomes automatic. If you use the nail clipper, it goes back to its location; if you return a hair tie, it goes back into its compartment. There is no decision. It's routine. You just need to adhere to the organizational system you set up, and it will prevent chaos later. If, over time, you find something isn't working or could work better, then refine it. You're creating something that works for you.

Step 5: Towels and Linens

Let's take stock of your bathroom towels. Does it feel like there are just too many towels there? A good rule of thumb is that each person should have one bathroom towel and one hand towel in use. Towels need space and air circulation to properly dry. When there are too many towels hanging on the rack, they will maintain their dampness and develop that undeniable smell.

As we said earlier, there should be at most three towel sets per person split between the linen closet and those in use; the same applies to washcloths. For bathmats, there should be maybe two per bathroom.

Just like when you organized your linen closet, you should take inventory of your towel quality. If you have stained or threadbare towels, use them as rags or donate them to an animal shelter. When storing towels, try to fold them neatly to promote an orderly look and feel. A useful technique is to roll the towels since it saves space and provides a nice look. Depending on space availability, consider putting those extra towels for the bathroom in the bathroom rather than the linen closet.

Step 6: Daily Maintenance

After the bathrooms have been decluttered, install a daily maintenance ritual to keep surfaces clear and maintain an organized atmosphere.

The ritual might involve wiping down the counter each day to remove toothpaste or soap scum. Use a designated cloth that stays in the same spot so it can be located easily. After products are used, they should be returned to their location. Commonly, the hairdryer or toothpaste may be left on the countertop to be addressed later. Try to avoid these common mistakes.

After using a towel, hang it up appropriately so that it can air out. Don't leave the towel on the floor or countertop or bunched up on the bar to develop that damp, musty smell. If there are items on the floor that shouldn't be there, whether dirty clothes or products that were set down on the floor, pick them up and return them to their rightful location. Empty the trash weekly at least. Overflowing trash creates visual clutter and just looks unappealing.

This maintenance ritual prevents the bathroom from deteriorating into a cluttered mess that would require larger deep cleaning projects to address.

Safety Considerations

The bathroom has some relevant safety considerations that should be addressed as part of your decluttering efforts. As you organize any medicines into the bathroom medicine cabinet or cleaning products under the cabinet, conduct a few safety checks. Any medications in the bathroom cabinet should be stored out of reach of children or even in locked boxes. The cleaning supplies should also be out of the reach of children or be childproofed with locks or similar devices.

In the tub or shower, there should be nonslip mats, as falls in the bathroom cause significant injuries. Examine any mats to see if any have lost their gripping ability and need to be replaced.

There are various electrical considerations in the bathroom. If the lights appear dim, consider upgrading the light bulbs or adding additional lighting. Check that the fans and the ventilation are working appropriately to prevent the growth of mold. If you live in an older building, check that the electricity has the appropriate safety features. In particular, look for a GFCI (Ground Fault Circuit Interrupter). These monitor the flow of electricity in the circuit, detecting tiny imbalances in electricity and shutting off power almost instantly. You can recognize this by the presence of "test" and "reset" buttons on the electrical outlet.

Special Considerations for Shared Bathrooms

If the bathroom is shared by multiple people, the organization becomes more complicated. You'll have more duplicate products competing for the same space. Each person should be allocated some specific storage space to prevent the mixing of products and promote accountability.

Depending on who is sharing the bathroom, the cleaning duties may be rotated or shared so that no one person has the burden of dealing with the entire bathroom. This teaches children some responsibility for shared spaces. With children, teach them some basic techniques to maintain the bathroom. This might include hanging up their towel after use and putting their toothbrush in a designated location. This makes the bathroom more functional, less stressful, and just better in the event of guests needing to use it.

If the bathroom is shared by roommates, then clear expectations for storage and cleaning responsibilities need to be set. This might be challenging depending on individual circumstances.

The Transformation

After your bathroom has been decluttered and organized, you'll notice general improvements in your daily routine. The stress or frustration of navigating through the clutter that was once there will be no more. The morning preparations will be easier, and the evening wind down will be easier. There will be no decision-making since you're accessing and returning items where they belong. The visual calm of clear counters and organized storage will make you feel more mentally calm and in control.

You'll have fewer items in the bathroom, so there is simply less stuff to address during the cleaning process. You won't have to move products or items you don't use just to clean.

The bathroom declutter will have a compounding effect over time as it is a high frequency space. Just take the time to discard unwanted products, organize what remains, and maintain it consistently. If you do this, then the bathroom environment will be more supportive of your daily routines.

CHAPTER 12

Laundry Room - Simplifying Chores



Time Budget: 2–3 hours
Impact: Efficiency of a necessary household task — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

The laundry room should be thought of as a processing center: the clothes enter, get processed, and leave. It is not a holding area for selected clothes to enter, stay, and pile up over time. Laundry is a necessity that happens weekly or sometimes more often, and when it's organized, it's less frustrating.

A few hours should be sufficient to organize the laundry room or space. This will allow you to complete your laundry loads without navigating clutter or sidestepping obstacles.

The Goal: Efficient Processing Center

Laundry is relentless. We wear clothes and need clean clothes, and so the cycle is never ending. Let's try to make the laundry room or space more workable for you. The purpose of the laundry room or space is to take the dirty clothes as input, clean them, and return

them to the dresser or closet as output. The key is that everything in the laundry room must assist this production line.

Your laundry room might have inadvertently become a dumping ground for household items, or maybe half-used detergent bottles. These items detract from the production line mentality. Our tendency is to ignore the laundry room, as it is usually tucked behind a closed door. However, much of our time is spent doing laundry, so we should try to make the task as organizationally efficient as possible.

When you devise a system that's clear and efficient, you optimize the routine so it no longer feels like a drag.

Step 1: Supplies Purge

Examine the laundry room and take inventory of the laundry supplies. Commonly, there will be multiple containers of open detergents, fabric softeners, and a collection of free samples. We accumulate products because we try a brand when it's on sale or receive free samples and hold onto them only because they're free. We never take the time to examine what we use or need.

If there are multiple bottles of the same detergent, consolidate the products into one container. Discard the free samples, unless you commit to using them from this point forward until they're exhausted. Generally, try to keep one of each product: detergent, stain remover, and fabric softener. For some, fabric softeners have been replaced by dryer balls, so they may not be necessary.

After consolidating and discarding items, keep the remaining favored items close to the washer and dryer, with the backups in a less accessible location. When doing the laundry, you don't want to have to make decisions about detergent or other products. It's simply using the product at hand and executing the process. Depending on

the layout of the laundry room, some find it useful to have a basket to contain all the products for a neater or more organized feel.

Step 2: The Single Sock Situation

One of the unsolved mysteries of the world is the origin of single socks. At some point in the process, whether before the wash, during the wash, or in the drying phase, socks lose their mates. Many people have a partial drawer of socks with no mates. For most, those mates never return, and their population continues to increase.

The single socks need to be given a timeline to reunite with their counterpart. Establish a missing sock container for the orphan socks and give them a one-week or one-cycle timeline to reunite. After the next cycle, see if any socks reappeared; otherwise, discard the socks. This might seem a bit harsh but having a partial drawer of single socks that never get worn is itself wasteful.

If socks are consistently missing, you may have to investigate the root cause. Sometimes socks get stuck in towels or bedding. Depending on how carefully these items are examined or folded, they might remain there indefinitely, bypassing the one-cycle rule. If you have children, sometimes a sock is left under the couch or bed, and again it will escape the one-cycle rule. Some families institute a rule that each family member puts their used socks in a mesh bag daily. The mesh bag enters the hamper and goes through the laundry cycle with all the socks delivered back in the mesh bag. As long as the socks in the mesh bag were correctly paired, there shouldn't be a problem.

This discipline prevents the accumulation of orphan socks.

Step 3: Surface Clearing

Laundry room surfaces should, by default, be clear. Look at your surfaces. Most commonly, there will be items on top of the washer, dryer, and folding surfaces. They are usually storing places for supplies, household items unrelated to laundry, or just clothes waiting to be folded or put away. Generally, try to keep the detergent and fabric softener contained in a cabinet or on shelving, not on the flat surface. In some laundry rooms, there may be the necessity to create storage locations. These might be a small rolling cart or tension rod shelf above the machines.

Clear and wipe down the laundry surfaces. When doing laundry, you need a flat surface to spread out, organize, and fold the clothes. The laundry process should start with flat, empty surfaces and end with flat, empty surfaces. Try to maintain this flat surface and prevent clutter from building up.

Step 4: Lint Trap and Vent

Cleaning the lint trap and vent focuses on safety and efficiency rather than organization. Set a routine for when the lint trap is typically cleaned, whether after the wet clothes go into the dryer or after the dryer load is finished.

Second to the lint trap is cleaning the dryer vent. The dryer vent accumulates lint beyond what the lint trap catches. Ideally, the vent should be cleaned annually. If you notice that your dryer is taking a longer time to dry, it's an indication that the vent needs to be cleaned. Other more pressing indications may be visible lint around the vent opening or, worse, a burning smell when running the dryer.

Depending on the location of your laundry room, the venting may have more unique challenges. Some people find that the vents have been blocked by vegetation or that birds have built a nest in

the vent openings. The vent cleaning can be done by professionals, general contractors, or by you, depending on your level of comfort.

Step 5: Sorting System and Clothing Purgatory

You might not have thought about your sorting system for clothes entering the laundry cycle. This is an issue about efficiency and organization.

If you have sufficient space, try to use multiple hampers for different reasonable categories, such as light, dark, and delicate. This is the optimal system since, once a hamper is full, that hamper goes through the laundry cycle. Also, this method prevents an extra sorting step on laundry day, for example, assuming you don't wash whites with colors. However, if space is limited, keep an extra container near the washer to presort the clothes before they go to the washer.

The goal is to have laundry move through the cycle without stopping during the cycle. Often people finish a load without folding the clothes for a few days, leading to wrinkles. This is where the clothes stall out and are held in purgatory. If your laundry cycle stalls out and clothes are held up, then examine why. It might be as easy as varying the timing of the cycle so that washing or drying finishes at a time when the folding can be done promptly. A useful technique is to set a reminder on your phone to transfer the clothes to the dryer or to fold the clothes. This brings you back to the laundry room to move clothes through the cycle.

Step 6: Ironing Station

Personal ironing seems to be less common nowadays, and the skill is not as commonly practiced by the younger generation. You should evaluate whether ironing is necessary for your situation. In the

past, it was common to iron work shirts or outfits. Now, clothes are often sent to the cleaners to be washed and pressed. There may be more casual dress at work, and remote work requires less formal clothing. Also, wrinkle-free fabrics and dryers with steam options are very prevalent, reducing the need to iron. If you haven't used your iron for months, consider donating it or putting it in the closet for nonroutine use.

If the ironing station is used, keep both the iron and the ironing board close by. Start the ironing task, finish it, and then pack up the ironing board when complete. Don't have in-progress ironing in the laundry room. This gives a cluttered impression. Start and finish the process in one sitting.

You might need pressing, but not full ironing. A compromise might be a small handheld steamer. These devices are quick and easy to store and meet most household needs of removing those light wrinkles without the setup of traditional ironing.

Step 7: Cleaning Product Storage

In some households, the laundry room serves two purposes: a laundry room and cleaning supply storage. This section applies to those whose laundry room also stores cleaning supplies.

The cleaning supplies should be sorted by category, such as floor, bathroom, kitchen, or general. For example, the bathroom-specific supplies might be toilet cleaner, tub cleaner, and glass cleaner. The floor-specific supplies might be a mop, bucket, and floor cleaner. During bathroom cleaning, you might access both the floor and bathroom supplies.

The storage should be labeled to help everyone in the household maintain organization. Where possible, use vertical shelves that are clearly labeled and have caddies that fit into the shelving. The most frequently used supplies should be kept at eye level, and the backup

supplies should be kept in less accessible areas higher up. As with medicine cabinet or bathroom organization, if there are harmful cleaning supplies, keep them out of the reach of children.

It's useful to use bins or caddies for each category. This keeps the supplies organized and contained during and after the cleaning process. The appropriate caddies can be brought to the room for the task and then returned to storage. This may seem like a small detail, but it's better than grabbing a handful of supplies and then returning them to storage all mixed up.

A lesser-known fact is that there are expiration dates on your cleaning supplies. They are usually hidden or less obvious than for medication or food products. For example, typically bleach lasts for six to twelve months once it's opened. Disinfectant sprays and wipes generally last one to two years. After the expiration date, the effectiveness or potency of the product will decline.

Take stock of your cleaning supplies, looking at the duplicates or supplies that were tried and never used again. Consolidate the duplicate supplies into their respective containers and determine if you will honestly use those one-off supplies you bought. Most often, you favor some supplies and gravitate to those. The backup supplies should be reasonable amounts of one to two per product, as you are running a household, not a janitorial business. Depending on your cleaning routine, these items can be set up to be delivered regularly to meet your needs.

Step 8: Seasonal Items and General Storage

Depending on the size of your home, sometimes the laundry room is used for more than laundry and cleaning supplies, based on the room's space availability. Some people allow the room to hold seasonal items or general backup items for the house.

The key is to designate specific areas for laundry, cleaning, and seasonal items, for example. This prevents the potential mixing of various supplies.

General backup items might be things like toilet paper, paper towels, or light bulbs. If these are stored in the laundry room, they need a clearly labeled, designated shelf or space. You need to evaluate the backup supplies and tone down restocking to an appropriate level if there's too much. Generally, one to two packages of toilet paper should be sufficient. For busy households. these items might be regularly delivered, and their supply has never been re-evaluated but simply allowed to accumulate.

Seasonal supplies are things like pool supplies or winter gear. Pool supplies might be things like goggles, pool toys, and sunscreen. Whatever the seasonal gear, keep it in a specified zone and respective bins.

If the laundry room has grown into storage beyond the laundry room items, your storage should be purposeful and not just a catchall for other household storage items. Often, before decluttering, items landed there out of convenience rather than by intention. It might be more sensible to store other household items elsewhere. If there are tools in the laundry room, is the basement or garage a more logical place?

Daily and Weekly Maintenance

The laundry room is easy to maintain. Some of the maintenance tips are strategic, while others are more general.

Strategic Maintenance

When doing laundry, follow the **load-to-load rule**. This rule says to start the new load of laundry after the prior load has finished its

cycle. This means the first load must be finished, folded, and put away. This way, there's no visual clutter of laundry buildup—for example, wet clothes waiting for their turn to dry.

The inside of the washing machine should be cleaned approximately every one to two months. Generally, you can run the hot water cycle with vinegar or washing machine cleaner. This will remove detergent residue and mildew smell, extending the life of your machine.

Cleaning the lint trap is an essential step; some do it before drying the next load, while others empty it after the load is done. This helps the dryer to function more efficiently.

General Maintenance

The machines should be wiped down once a week with a damp cloth. This prevents the buildup of lint, dust, and detergent. This gives the machines a clean look, and you're more likely to set clothes on top of the machines than avoid them out of fear of soiling your clothes.

A light mopping or sweeping around the machines helps maintain a clean look by removing any lint or dirt. How many times have you dropped clothes just taken out of the dryer and shaken them vigorously to remove dust after picking them off the floor?

Monitor the stock of the laundry supplies and replenish items that are half full. This ensures that the product will always be in stock but not overstocked. Many have these items on automatic delivery at regular intervals. Monitor them to see if a delivery needs to be adjusted to maintain the right amount of inventory.

Whenever the items are used, they return to the proper location. This prevents clutter and gives an accurate picture of the inventory.

The Efficiency Principle

Each week, households likely spend several hours on laundry. You want your laundry to move through the conveyor system as efficiently as possible. If you have an organized laundry system and an organized room, it will be more efficient. This will allow you to sidestep the wrinkled clothes that sat in the process too long or spending more time than necessary completing the laundry.

The laundry room is often ignored in decluttering because it's hidden from the guests. It's a space that is focused on practicality rather than style. Even so, taking the time to organize this space will make the task more efficient and less frustrating. The time spent organizing the space will save time in the future, as less time is wasted on completing the laundry process.

CHAPTER 13

Garage or Basement - The Final Frontier



Time Budget: 12–20 hours (largest single project)
Impact: Capstone achievement, major storage functionality — see Appendix for your room-by-room checklists.

This final frontier of home organization is a unique project in this book. These spaces may represent years or decades of items, projects, and things you abandoned. Decluttering the basement or the garage will represent a capstone effort. For some, it could take a whole day or twenty-four hours spread over several sessions.

The basement or garage can be an overwhelming space. You must draw on your decluttering knowledge from the other parts of the home. Given that you've had success getting to this point and have developed skills, this space, although nebulous, can be conquered.

Why This Comes Last

This space is last because it represents the items that were set aside to be dealt with later. During the decluttering efforts in the prior rooms, you probably encountered items and punted on making a

decision about them. Those items were too important to directly discard at that point, so you sent them to the garage or the basement to be dealt with later. This space can be thought of as a museum of your prior chapters of life, hobbies, abandoned projects, inherited items, and the list goes on. This is okay.

It's fair to say you needed to address the rest of the house first. You need to have worked on smaller problems, built your decision-making capacity, and learned to let go of items that are no longer relevant to the current chapter of your life. You learned how to release the stuff but not the memories with techniques like digitizing. At this point, you've begun to see the value of space and peace, and this has prepared you for the basement and garage.

The Garage and Basement Reality

Let's conduct a short experiment. Stand in the basement or garage and have a look around. How many items have you not opened in the last year, two years, five years? This is a rhetorical question, but you know these items are occupying valuable real estate in your home.

Many people don't park a car in the garage simply because the car cannot fit due to clutter. The garage is designed to protect cars from the elements and from potential theft or vandalism. When you can't park your car in the garage due to clutter, those items cost you functional space. Similarly, for your basement, if it's full of storage boxes, you never get to access or enjoy using the basement. The finished square footage is wasted.

There's a cost to storing items. Obviously, there is the space it occupies, but there's also a mental weight knowing that you have the stuff but don't use it. And, as we've mentioned, there's a missed opportunity to use the functional space. Over time, these costs accumulate unconsciously in your mind.

Step 1: Mental Preparation

For most, this space will require a major decluttering effort, so prepare yourself mentally and give yourself the best chance to succeed. You'll need to set some realistic expectations. This space will likely take five sessions of maybe four hours each. If you anchor to this view, it will prevent frustration that might cause you to stall—or worse, not finish the effort.

During the process, like other parts of the decluttering effort, you'll be confronted with items that were purchased but never used and the sick feeling of wasted money. You must accept that the money is already gone. Keeping the unused items doesn't recover that expense. Let go of the guilt and focus on creating a functional space.

It's likely that you will get dirtier in this process than other rooms, as both the garage and basement accumulate dust and grime. You'll encounter items that you haven't moved or touched in years and items covered in cobwebs (and other unpleasant things). Wearing gloves is useful, as it gives you more initiative to dig in and work through the dirty items.

This project should be scheduled strategically when the weather is predicted to be moderate. You don't want to attack the garage during the summer heat or the freezing cold of winter. If you live somewhere where the temperatures are generally more extreme, then plan to have shorter sessions over a longer period or take more breaks.

For the donations, try to plan out the donation pickup schedule as you get into the project. This promotes accountability and prevents donation items from sitting in the garage for prolonged periods. Depending on your location, some charities will pick up large items for free. Some declutterers might need to rent a dumpster to remove broken appliances, furniture, or just significant amounts of trash.

If this is the case, decide beforehand and arrange your sessions to coincide with its arrival.

Sometimes you might need muscle to help you move items physically through the process. Arrange this beforehand so it doesn't become an obstacle or deter you from the process.

Step 2: Zone-by-Zone Decluttering

You don't want to declutter the garage or basement all at once. This will tend to overwhelm you and likely cause you to stall. The best approach is to work through this space by creating zones and working through them. (This technique was introduced earlier in the book.) Look at the garage or basement space and determine the potential categories, such as sports equipment, lawn and garden, automotive supplies, and miscellaneous. The miscellaneous category will be the worst because it's a catchall of items that don't fit elsewhere.

Strategically, you want to go for a quick win and start with a category you know you can make decisions about easily. For example, if you actively use sports equipment, then that might be a place to start. Seasonal decorations might be another quick decision category, as you might be familiar with what has been in use versus what wasn't used during the latest season. Don't attack more than one zone or category at once; pick a category and finish it. You want to complete a zone to build momentum and give you confidence. During the process, you want to be able to look up and see the zones stack up one by one as they're completed.

For each selected zone, pull everything into a central area and go through the usual process. Sort it, make decisions, and organize what you're keeping. Clean the area where those items were stored. Once the zone is done, rinse and repeat the process by moving on to the next zone.

This structure and process create visible progress. If you pull everything into the central area and begin the sorting process, it would be too overwhelming. Moving through the items by zone allows you to stop at the end of a session without having a totally dysfunctional space.

Step 3: The Moving Question

As you sort through the items in your garage or basement, pretend that you're moving to a new house. Specifically, ask yourself if you were moving to a new house, would this be moved also? If the answer is no, there is no reason to store the item any longer. This question cuts to the heart of whether the item is worth taking up valuable real estate.

Utilizing the moving house process to think through useful items is a valuable lens through which to evaluate the clutter. Moving is both expensive and exhausting if it involves hiring movers and packing your belongings. If you don't intend to use the item, there's no sense in packing or paying for the moving expense. You'll find that many items will fail this test and should be donated or discarded.

Step 4: Open Every Unknown Box

Most of you will have boxes with mystery contents. You need to open the boxes now and make decisions on the key items. These boxes often contain items you forgot about and then subsequently bought replacements for, things that should be trashed and some that are worth keeping.

A useful technique is to use the **six-month rule**. Simply put, if you haven't opened or thought of the box in the last six months, you don't need the contents in your current life. Some of these boxes you have might not have been thought of or opened in several years.

As you go through the process of opening boxes, make sure you sort that box. Don't repack the boxes to deal with later. Trash, donate, relocate, or keep each item. Often, there are some sentimental items that require deeper or more emotional decision-making. As illustrated in Chapter 10, a useful technique is to limit sentimental items to the size of a large bin. Items that have less sentimental value can be digitized so that the photos can be reflected on in the future.

Step 5: Category-Specific Guidance

When evaluating categories of items in the garage or basement, here are some useful guidelines as you work through the zones.

Tools tend to accumulate because they appear to be permanently useful. However, there can be some improvements. If there are duplicate tools, keep the best one; you don't need four of the same item. If there are broken tools, discard them. Generally, if they haven't been repaired, they will never be repaired. If there are tools you accumulated for a hobby that has since been abandoned, these items take up space and should be donated.

The tools should be held in a toolbox or on a pegboard for visibility. The pegboard can have outlines of the tools or labels so the home for each tool is visible, with the goal of maintaining some type of order.

Sporting goods will tend to represent either your past activities or ambitious future aspirations. Try to keep the equipment for the sports you currently play and those you've made concrete plans to take up. A good rule of thumb is that if you or a family member hasn't used the equipment in the year, it will never be used. If there are younger children who might grow into the equipment, then that's a valid reason to keep it.

Holiday decorations should be limited based on what was displayed in recent years. Assign a designated large bin for each

holiday, and if there are more decorations than fit in the bin, then there are too many. Most holidays should have one bin whereas Christmas decorations tend to need more— maybe two to three bins. Some common culprits to be discarded or donated are items that were inherited or gifted to you but that you never use. Also, there may be a variety of decorations that have malfunctioned yet continue to be stored.

Lawn and garden supplies should align to your current lawn and garden maintenance needs. Often, there are items representing hobbies we wanted to take up, like pots purchased with the hope of growing flowers, but this was never achieved. Other times, people have downgraded to a smaller home and transported the lawn supplies without assessing their usefulness. For example, you might not need that riding mower anymore. If there are multiple bags of similar products like fertilizer, consolidate them. Generally, keep supplies that you use easily accessible while disposing of the rest.

Automotive items tend to accumulate beyond what most people commonly use. Today, many people don't perform car maintenance themselves for a variety of reasons. Some people wash their cars, while others prefer to take them to the car wash. Some change their own oil, while others take it to the shop. Any items that aren't used should be discarded: old car parts, excess motor oil, or even car washing supplies. There are some die-hard car enthusiasts who could benefit from your extra supplies.

Paint is one of the most common garage or basement clutter items. After your major painting project is complete, there's likely a partial can of paint remaining for each color. If you want to keep these cans for touchups, make sure they're labeled by room. These old paint cans may sit for years until the next painting project, at which time you will likely go to the store and pick new paint. If there are empty, dried out, or partial paint cans, dispose of them

per your local guidelines, which might include drop-off locations to assist in disposal. Paint should not be thrown in the trash.

Furniture waiting in the garage tends to stay there indefinitely. If there's garage furniture that hasn't found a permanent location in the last year, arrange for it to be donated unless there's a concrete plan for the furniture. If you have furniture in the garage, your car might not fit in the garage. You should reclaim the garage for some functional use.

Sentimental items are items most have tended to avoid, simply carrying the existing boxes forward and never venturing to look through the contents. These could be boxes from parents' homes, old school papers, and memorabilia—often decades of stuff that leads to full sessions of emotional decision-making. Apply the principles from Chapter 10, utilizing the one large bin maximum. One useful technique mentioned earlier was to digitize items you find somewhat precious. Only keep the things that bring you joy so that you aren't holding onto things out of obligation.

Step 6: The Donation and Disposal Process

As we mentioned earlier, before jumping into the basement or garage and starting your decluttering effort, you need to arrange where the unwanted items will go to. If not, this will kill the momentum of your decluttering effort as bags slated for donations stack up. If you expect to have large, bulky items to be donated, research donation pickup services. Similarly, if you expect to have heavy trash-related items, arrange those removal services. If there's hazardous waste items such as paint, plan for their safe removal to protect the environment and be compliant with regulations.

Some items can be removed by yourself via your car, while other items should be scheduled for pickup. All these methods allow you to plan for the orderly removal of the clutter in batches. These steps

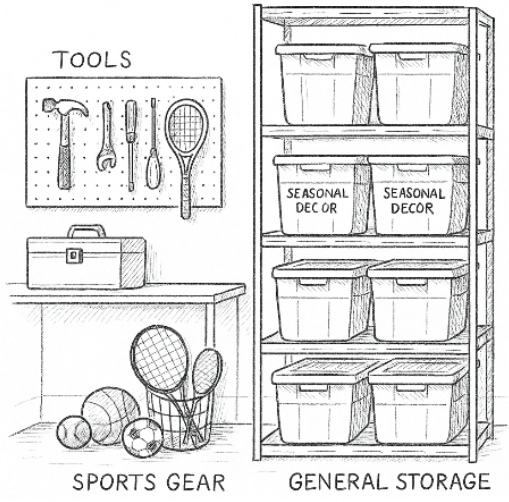
serve as small psychological wins as you see the space open and free up, allowing you to build motivation and tackle more zones.

Step 7: Organization Systems for What Remains

After decluttering a specified zone, organize the remaining items you're keeping into proper systems that maintain order and prevent reaccumulation.

It's best to use heavy duty shelving built from metal that can bear significant weight and will survive literally for a lifetime. Try to maximize both the vertical and the horizontal space. Once the shelving is in place, the space above the shelves can't be used, so build shelves to the ceiling if possible. Similarly, depending on the wall space, try to extend the shelving to the edge of the wall to prevent having a useless few feet of space between the shelving and the adjacent wall.

The containers should be clear bins with labels for the items stored within. If possible, label your bins on all six sides; this gives visibility from all angles depending on your vantage point. You don't want opaque mystery boxes.



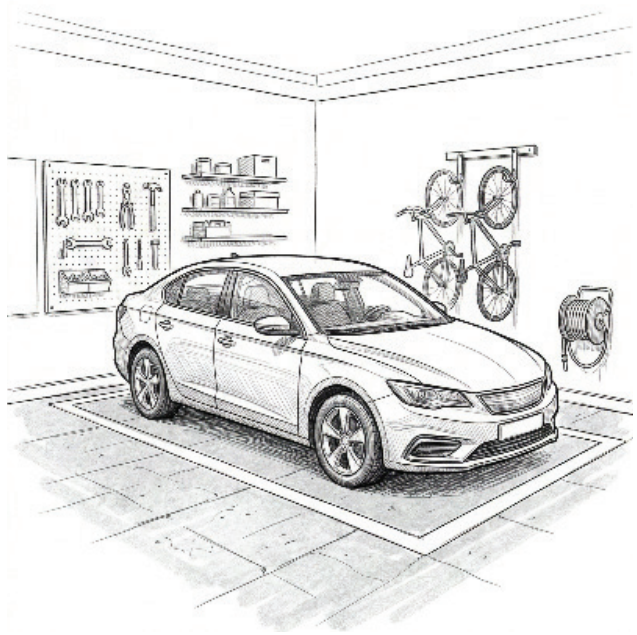
Look towards the floor and implement the **off-the-floor rule**, which basically says nothing should live on the floor except vehicles and large equipment. Usually, if there's water damage or flooding, it happens at the floor level. The shelving elevates everything from potential damage and provides a clean and more functional space.

Once you create your zones, assign categories for your zones. For example, you might have a corner zone where you store seasonal decorations, and within that you might store your Halloween, Easter, and Christmas bins. This creates functional departments for your storage space, which allows you to find and return items efficiently.

When storing items, you should consider their durability related to temperature or moisture. Items sensitive to temperature and humidity, like photos and documents, shouldn't be stored in the non-air-conditioned garage. If you went through the effort of sorting and preserving these items, you don't want them to be damaged due to an act of God.

Step 8: The Parking Test

If you have a garage, a simple test is to ask yourself if you can park your car inside it. If not, then the problem is typically too much clutter or the need for more robust storage solutions. The primary purpose of the garage is to house and protect your vehicle. If it can't do that, then it's not functional.



When the initially decluttered garage still can't fit the car, examine your storage solutions more critically. Potentially, you can use shelving mounted above the height of the car or ceiling-mounted storage racks. Both allow you to have freedom of movement around your vehicle. Obviously, you can remove or relocate items to achieve the functionality of a garage.

Step 9: Final Assessment and Maintenance

When you think the decluttering effort in the garage or basement is complete, perform the final assessment. Walk around the space and determine if you can find what you need within a few minutes. Assess if there's good visibility and accessibility. Most importantly, the items that you see should serve your current life rather than being remnants of past chapters of your life.

As a part of your maintenance protocols to prevent the reaccumulation of clutter, use the one-in, one-out rule. For each item entering the basement or garage, one must leave to avoid accumulating clutter. In addition, every three months, take a walk through for items that might have migrated here but weren't addressed. Act to either discard, relocate, or donate the items. On a seasonal basis, make a concerted effort to swap out items, perform a mini-audit, and remove any items that you didn't use last season.

The Achievement

When both the garage and the basement are complete, it represents the final frontier of the decluttering journey. These were the spaces that you likely resisted decluttering, had history with, and were most emotional about. Finishing the effort indicates that you've built up the mindset to have a clutter-free life and the skills to do it.

Throughout this process, you made hard decisions and learned to value space and peace more than keeping a lot of stuff. You learned to focus on the current chapter of your life rather than the past or potential future outcomes.

Enjoy and savor the moment as all the rooms in your home are organized. You transformed your home from one of chaos to a functional space, creating workable systems along the way. The maintenance will require minimal daily effort, which allows you to live rather than manage clutter.

The garage and basement are the end of your initial organizing journey. Now it's about entering the maintenance phase. You can evaluate items before entering the home, release items that aren't serving you, and maintain organized systems throughout the home.

Again, think of your life as a book, and you are moving through the chapters. You've closed the chapter on clutter and started a new chapter on functionality and peace. Now it's time to enjoy your home!

PHASE IV

SUSTAINABLE LIVING AND MINDFUL EXPANSION

CHAPTER 14

Maintenance Routines - Keeping the Calm Alive



The organization of your home and each room involved thousands of decisions as you examined and assessed various items. You released items through donations or discarding that were no longer important to you and created systems that support your current life. The decluttering work was no doubt considerable, but there's still more. Maintenance systems are required; otherwise, clutter will begin to creep back in. Here, we reinforce how to maintain the calm that was created through your efforts.

The Maintenance Mindset

A useful analogy is to think of decluttering as working out and maintenance as the fitness routine. In other words, decluttering puts your home into shape, while maintenance keeps it that way. Decluttering is time-consuming, while maintenance should be much faster, measured in minutes rather than hours.

We need to maintain our home because life just happens. You'll receive new mail, buy things, and receive gifts. The kids will bring home papers and artwork, and people will make messes. It's unstoppable but normal. Unlike before your decluttering efforts, you now have systems to process rather than allow for haphazard accumulation.

In science, there's the concept of entropy, and this speaks to the measure of natural disorder and energy spreading over time. In other words, your home naturally moves toward disorder unless energy is applied to maintain order. Your home requires maintenance; otherwise, the organized closet will become disorganized over time. Fighting entropy requires small and consistent efforts that stop clutter from overwhelming you and becoming major projects.

These small efforts aren't about scheduling reorganizations of your home. They are all maintenance items that safeguard the time and energy you invested in decluttering efforts, whether daily routines, weekly check-ins, or monthly resets.

Daily Maintenance: The Nightly Reset

Nightly resets are an anchor to your daily maintenance by stopping clutter before it has a chance to take hold. Executing the nightly reset will make your home feel organized and manageable. If you complete this fifteen-minute nightly routine consistently, in the morning, you'll wake up to a relative level of calmness. The Nightly Resets were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

The Morning Quick-Check

The morning check builds on the evening reset, preserving the momentum. It should be quick and not a major undertaking. The

relevant Morning Quick-Checks were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

Weekly Maintenance: Spot-Checks and Deep Cleaning

We need the weekly maintenance because some areas will just collect clutter despite your best efforts and the daily resets. This will prevent these areas from getting out of control. For many people, there will be four to five areas where items appear to accumulate quickly. The typical hot spots are flat surfaces that invite items, such as the entry tables, counters, or dining table. Generally, your specific hotspots will depend upon your family habits and traffic flow.

Attack these hot spots using targeted approaches of perhaps ten minutes for each spot. Simply remove any items at the hotspot and return them to their proper location, designate them for donation, or put them in the trash. This will prevent accumulation and allow the area to look and feel uncluttered.

The relevant Weekly Maintenance routines were described in Phase III in their respective chapters.

Monthly Maintenance: Rotating Deep Dives

Monthly maintenance focuses on areas not covered in the daily or weekly care that need specific periodic attention. Typically, it will take two to three hours for each of these rotating deep dives. Here, we lay out common deep dives distributed throughout the year.

Month one focuses on cleaning the refrigerator and freezer. It's like the initial decluttering effort but somewhat easier. The initial effort will have sorted out most of the clutter, and now it's more about maintenance. Start by removing the contents of the refrigerator, for example, and sorting through the items. Look for

expired items and send them to the trash. If there are duplicate items, consolidate. Give the refrigerator shelves and drawers a good wipe or cleaning.

Month two moves to the pantry and food storage. Again, this is like the initial decluttering effort specified in Chapter 5. Reorganize the pantry so that similar items live together if they've inadvertently shifted around. Consolidate duplicate packages. Wipe down the shelves to remove crumbs and spills.

Month three moves from the kitchen to the bathroom. Check for expiration dates on products in the medicine cabinet, cosmetics, and skincare. Refine the organization of the drawers and cabinets as needed. Some areas will require some deep cleaning, such as behind the toilets and inside the cabinets. Wash or clean items that haven't been frequently cleaned, like the shower curtain or the bathmat. In general, you're addressing items that haven't been touched in the daily or weekly maintenance routines.

Month four allows you to visit your closets. If you implemented the backward hanger technique to identify unworn clothes, you might be at the point of determining which clothes are candidates for donation. The clothes suitable for donation can be removed. Over the past year, you might have discovered that your shelf organization wasn't working optimally, so this is the chance to tweak and refine as necessary. Clear the closet floor to prevent it from becoming overstuffed again.

Month five focuses on the kids' rooms. This could involve removing clothes that no longer fit, rotating in age-appropriate toys, and donating younger toys. Examine areas that tend to collect items, like under the bed or between the furniture. Monthly maintenance keeps the kids and you from becoming overwhelmed.

Month six is for paperwork and files. Often you won't have enough time to address all the paper or digital items daily or weekly, so it's necessary to set aside time monthly. If there are current papers,

make sure they're filed appropriately. For medical records, make sure the list of emergency contacts is up to date. This saves time when schools request the information. This general maintenance helps promote a proper paper management system.

Month seven is for spot-checking the garage or basement. Take a visual walk through and identify items that may have been inadvertently set there. Feel free to reorganize items that are commonly used to a more accessible row in storage. Check for moisture or pest issues that may need attention. This monthly check maintains the progress made in the major organization effort of Chapter 13.

Month eight directs focus to the linen closets, and this should be a relatively easy lift. It might involve reorganizing some shelves that are a bit jumbled or replacing some sheets that are worn. If there are medical supplies in the linen closet, then a quick check for expired medical supplies is in order. This helps to preserve the decluttered linen closet that was introduced in Chapter 10.

Month nine addresses the entryway closet as a separate category than other closets. Here, the focus is on seasonal swapping and purging unnecessary items. The entryway should be cleaned vigorously with a vacuum, mop, and a wipe-down of the surfaces. This maintenance keeps the entryway functional and clutter-free-looking.

Month ten tackles digital decluttering. This section focuses more on managing, organizing, and deleting the duplicates of all things digital. Have you noticed that you seem to have an increasing number of useless emails? Rather than scrolling by unwanted emails, take some time to unsubscribe. Clear out any unused apps on your phone, tablet, and computer. For a deeper dive on digital items, see Chapter 15.

Month eleven focuses on deep cleaning kitchen tools and appliances. This applies to the oven, dishwasher, and microwave. If

the drawers are messy, reorganize them. Determine if there are items that can be donated. These steps target key areas of the kitchen beyond what's covered in the weekly surface cleaning.

Month twelve is preparation for the holidays. Examine the holiday decorations before putting them up. This allows you to isolate the unused items for donation rather than just carrying them forward into storage for another year. Organize the gift-wrapping supplies and plan for any gifts by making space. This proactive approach will reduce typical holiday stress.

These monthly tasks are distributed over the year and touch on key areas of your home so that each area receives deeper focus once a year. Based upon your current circumstances, feel free to adjust the monthly activities to align with your schedule. For example, backward hangers might need a bit more time to gather data after the initial decluttering efforts. If so, closets might be moved to later than month four in your schedule. This prevents any space from deteriorating significantly between maintenance sessions.

Seasonal Maintenance: Transitions and Deep Cleaning

When the seasons change, it's a natural time to conduct seasonal maintenance and deep cleaning. During this time, equipment and clothing should be rotated, and a session of deeper cleaning is in order. These are usually spread across the weekend and will include clothing swaps, changing outdoor equipment, and aligning your items with the weather.

Spring cleaning or spring maintenance involves changing winter clothes for summer wardrobes. If there are winter items that were not worn, send them to the donation bin before they accumulate in storage the next year. There might be a need to prepare outdoor items like garden hoses or sprinklers for use and store the snow shovels and

snow blowers. In general, these activities align with saying goodbye to the cold weather and welcoming the warmer temperatures.

Summer maintenance focuses the review on outdoor toys and equipment. Inspect outdoor items such as pool supplies, camping gear, or beachwear to make sure they're in working order. This will help maintain your outdoor spaces and ensure the equipment is ready when the time comes.

Fall maintenance signifies a change from summer clothes to fall and winter clothes. It's also the time school begins, so be sure to organize the backpacks and related back-to-school items. Entertainment and play activities tend to retreat indoors, so adjust your storage and organization for this. Generally, look at items that focus on transitioning from warmer to colder weather.

Winter is the jolly season, so prepare for both gift-giving and receiving. Take the time to make space for new items before the holidays. After the holidays pass, conduct a post-holiday donation run to remove items you no longer need. A useful technique to prepare for the season is to stock your pantry more deeply so there are treats for guests and for any additional holiday cooking that might arise. This will reduce the holiday stress of running out sporadically for miscellaneous items.

These seasonal maintenance routines allow you to evaluate your system. Do your current maintenance routines appear to be working efficiently? If you discover there are a lot of miscellaneous items to handle, adjust or tweak your schedules or habits to be more optimal. These quarterly evaluations help to ensure your systems continue working for your benefit.

Customization: Creating Your Personal Maintenance Schedule

The previous schedules outlined in this chapter were a framework or baseline, not set in stone as rigid requirements. Perhaps you can start with this as a template, but customize the routine to adhere to your home's specific needs, your schedule, and your challenges.

For example, think about the size of your household. The more people there are, the messier things get and the more maintenance is required. A family of five will have different needs than a busy professional couple living without kids. Also, consider the age of your children. Toddlers create more of a mess and require more maintenance than teenagers. Those with toddlers will want to focus more on toy organization, while those with teenagers might focus more on paper organization and clothing.

Also, think about your work and related schedules. If you work the evening shift, the morning maintenance might be better than the evening reset. For some, mornings might be a rush to get to the office, so the morning routine, though small, might not be appropriate. Related to this, consider your personal energy level. In the morning, there simply may not be enough energy to initiate a morning routine. Conversely, if you're a morning person, consider shifting some of the evening routine to the morning.

You can create a custom schedule by first identifying hotspots. Identify areas where clutter accumulates the fastest, and these will be where you should focus your weekly attention. Second, try to assess how much time it will take you to complete the tasks. Third, you'll need to phase in your routines. This means starting with the daily routines and getting some type of rhythm. When the daily routines are solid, then layer in the weekly routines. After, build in the monthly routines. You want to build up the routines over time and not try to do everything at the onset.

To keep the maintenance on track, you can set a schedule of calendar reminders. Similarly, you can create a checklist for the daily, weekly, and monthly routines until you internalize them so that you don't forget them.

Try to involve all members of the family unit in the maintenance effort. Even your children can play roles in this process by assisting in clearing dishes, making their beds, or organizing their clothes. Try to be consistent when setting the maintenance schedules, as it's better for children to have an established routine to follow.

A Realistic Family Routine

In the following, we show a representative mock schedule for a family of four with two working parents and two children in school. It's designed to be illustrative and to give you a framework to modify as necessary.

Each day would start off with the daily maintenance routine, and this is something each family member can participate in. Before breakfast, each person takes the time to make their bed and check their bedroom—usually before 7:30 a.m., depending on the day. Each evening, the whole family is involved in the routine, with children assigned to clear stray items from the common area.

The parents will divide and conquer, with one parent handling the kitchen while the other tackles the bedrooms and bathrooms. This might occur around 8:30 p.m. each evening before the kids' bedtime.

In this schedule, the weekly maintenance occurs on Saturday morning. This includes hotspot checks of key areas identified for this household, including the entryway, dining table, and coffee table. This routine also includes the processing of paper held in the Sunday mail basket. One parent supervises the kids in busy play activities while the other handles the maintenance routines.

The monthly maintenance routine is scheduled for the last Sunday of the month in the afternoon. The focus will be on the deep dive scheduled for that month. Parents will focus on addressing the deep dive, and the kids will get free unstructured play after they have organized their rooms.

The seasonal maintenance is scheduled for the first Saturday of each quarter, starting with January. The family can work together performing clothing swaps, donation runs, and seasonal deep cleaning. This quarterly intensive maintenance schedule addresses areas that only need attention a few times a year.

Accountability and Motivation

Initially, try to track your progress so that you have the data to reset and adjust the process. Start by checking off the daily resets on a wall calendar. Once you begin to see a track record of consecutive streaks, this will support efforts and give you motivation when you're discouraged.

Eventually, life will happen, and you might fall off the wagon. This is natural, but you need to reset and get back on the wagon. Anything can happen: people get sick, work gets busy, vacations occur, and this list could go on. This is normal. Just spend some time putting the home into an organized state, reset, and maintain the regular schedule.

If your systems don't work effectively, then adjust them. Perhaps the daily tasks are too complex or too intensive. Then simplify them. If the weekly tasks are not done, reassess the schedule. Maybe the monthly tasks are too large. If so, break them down to make them work for your household. You need to find a sustainable rhythm rather than creating more stress.

The Long-Term Reality

Maintenance is a habit that continues forever; it's automatic. It's like brushing your teeth or drinking coffee. If performed consistently, there will be a point where it's like checking to see if the door is locked at night. You will naturally tidy up the home and return items to their locations or even evaluate new items before purchase.

The time invested in the maintenance is small compared to the decluttering efforts outlined in the prior chapters. Provided you continue with the maintenance, you will never again be overwhelmed with clutter in the magnitude described at the onset of this book. Your home will be more functional, calmer, and more organized, without a doubt.

If your home is chaotic, it drains the energy from you. When your home is organized, you have the mental space for work and feel greater support for all areas of your life. These maintenance routines are designed to protect and support your life. You want to have a home that functions smoothly and brings you peace.

CHAPTER 15

Mindful Living - Beyond the Physical Space



By working through this book, you've decluttered every room in your home. You assessed and evaluated your possessions and made difficult decisions to discard and donate items. Later, you adopted some systems or routines to maintain the order of your physical space.

Through this decluttering effort, you've asked questions like, "Is this item useful to me now or something from my past life?" This question was relevant during the decluttering process, but it's also relevant more broadly.

Digital Decluttering

We've touched on this earlier in the book, but digital clutter takes a mental toll just like physical clutter. Think of the number of notifications you receive. Some are useful; others are likely from subscribing to something long past. Perhaps you have emails flooding your inbox that are totally irrelevant to you. Then there

are photos and videos just taking up space on your devices. Digital hoarding is like physical hoarding and requires editing to maintain calmness.

Email Management

For email, start by actively unsubscribing. Try to do this every day for one week. Whether it's promotional emails, retail notifications, or anything else that's irrelevant, unsubscribe from everything except newsletters you read, services you use, and retailers you buy from.

One technique is to implement an **Inbox Zero** or **Inbox Twenty** approach. This approach sets the limit on the number of emails that can exist in your email at one time. The Inbox Zero approach simply means the email inbox count should be zero, whereas the Inbox Twenty is less restrictive, allowing for twenty emails. The goal is to not let your email inbox explode into temporary storage.

You want to treat your digital email like your physical mail by reading, answering, filing, or deleting it. Set aside some time when you can sort through email rather than continually checking it. Adopting this boundary will have the added benefit of keeping you focused on the present and reducing your stress.

Think of your email inbox as a to-do list rather than a large filing system. Those messages that require some type of action stay, whereas the rest should be filed or deleted.

Social Media Audit

Today, many spend countless hours on the phone, glued to social media. It's time to unfollow accounts that make you feel inadequate or anxious. Highlight reels on social media make many people feel insufficient or inadequate when comparing their real life with a

carefully curated video. This is not being unfriendly; it's being focused on your mental health.

Before following an account, be deliberate about it. Is the account adding value, or do you consistently feel worse after watching it? If you have apps you scroll through mindlessly, then it's time to delete them. As a starting point, rather than going cold turkey, consider limiting yourself to thirty minutes daily. If you remove the app and have a change of heart, it can be reinstalled. Generally, thirty minutes a day of social media is reasonable. Two hours is excessive for busy people.

Photo Management

With our mobile phones today, we tend to collect thousands of videos and photos over time and rarely go back to look at them. In the moment, we might take multiple photos hoping to capture a special pose, yet we never return to sort through the videos and photos.

Some people have started to set up monthly photo and video culling sessions. In these sessions, the duplicates, blurry shots, and screenshots are normally deleted. You don't need five of the same shot. Pick the best of the five and move on. The screenshots were probably temporary references, but their usefulness has long since passed.

Try to sort the photos into years and then events for easier reference and sharing in the future. Consider printing and displaying certain photos or events. Some people choose to display a digital photo frame that cycles through a set of photos from an online drive.

Desktop and File Organization

Some desktop computers are littered with files. The goal is to have a desktop computer with zero files, and this is achieved by using folders to organize everything. A computer full of files is visually chaotic. It's too hard to find the desired file with fifty file icons on your home screen. The folder structure should be clear: work, personal, and subcategories within each.

Examine the downloads folder. It's probably full of files you've copied to another folder or just left in this folder after using them. Sort this folder and delete files that haven't been used for over six months. This is similar to when we donated or trashed the physical items we hadn't used in over three months. Review all programs installed on your computer and delete those you haven't used in three months.

Like physically taking out the trash, empty that recycle bin. Your deleted files occupy space until you empty the trash folder. On your phone, examine your storage to see which large apps or video files are consuming most of the storage and purge items you don't need.

App Audit

Look through your phone; there will be apps that haven't been opened in the last six months. If you can't remember when you last accessed the app, then it's time to delete it. Later, if you find you need it, it can be reinstalled.

Digital Boundaries

Many of us are glued to our phones for various reasons—work, kids, or otherwise. For peace of mind, set some boundaries on the use of your phone. When you eat your meals without your phone, it helps to improve human connections and encourages more mindful

eating. Many people no longer sleep with their phones. Their phones are placed elsewhere, and they wake up with an alarm clock. This promotes more restful sleep and sidesteps the tendency to scroll on the phone late at night.

There should be free time during the day without your phone. For example, during the morning routine and evening family time, there's no need to be glued to the phone.

Are you constantly receiving push notifications for items that aren't relevant? Disable those nonessential notifications on social media, news, and promotional apps while keeping the lines open for calls, texts, and other essential communication.

This is a simple shift in mindset that changes your interaction with technology. You're choosing when to engage, when to disengage, and where you direct your attention. The pings and notifications are not constantly drawing you back to your phone.

Time Decluttering

Time is the one truly nonrenewable resource. You can't earn more time or save it for later. Over-commitment is the time equivalent of physical clutter. If you're busy running around with errands, kids, and invitations, that's a choice, but you can choose a different path. "Busy" is not a badge of honor. It's a choice, and you can choose differently.

Learning to Say No

Many of us are programmed to say yes to all requests, invitations, and get-togethers. This may be done out of convenience. Our calendar appears open, so we agree. Other times, it's done out of obligation. The invitation came from a particular person, and others are attending.

You can use scripts before deciding on impulse, allowing you to evaluate. The script might be "I need to check with my family's schedules before responding." This will set some expectations and some boundaries.

There is usually a cost or sacrifice for a commitment. If it's a potluck, then you must prepare a meal for the event, get the kids ready, and juggle other items to meet the invite. Before committing to an event, spend some time evaluating it. Do you want to commit? If you say yes, what are the repercussions, and are there other things being declined? If, for some reason, you might regret going to the event, you should decline it right away.

Common Time Clutter

Over time, you may have become involved in a variety of events and committees for various reasons. It's time to sit down and assess all these commitments and determine their relevance to your life and your family's life today.

You might be involved in some committees out of obligation—for example, being the class helper for your child's class. You might enroll your kids in piano because it's good for them, but they don't really like it. Sometimes you or your kids are somewhere stretching your capacity because you feel guilty about saying no. These obligations and routines tend to roll forward and may be relevant in one chapter of your life but not the next.

Simply list out your current commitments and assign a rough rating to them as essential, valuable, tolerable, or draining. The essential commitments are the basic life tasks, like work or health maintenance. These things you can't do without. Valuable commitments are meaningful or bring joy. For some, that might be attending religious services. Tolerable commitments might be those that are somewhat neutral, maybe being the leader for your child's

class. Draining commitments are those that suck the living energy out of you.

For draining commitments, exit gracefully. Give notice or find a replacement if necessary. In the future, be selective of what you commit to.

The Power of White Space

Downtime or white space represents unscheduled time where there are no plans and no agenda is set. It's a time to relax or to do whatever you feel like doing during that day. We need this time because we aren't built to run around every minute of every day without a pause from the grind. We can run around for some duration but not all day. Parents need unstructured rest, and kids need unstructured play. This time promotes creativity and reflection, allowing you to improve different aspects of your life.

You can create white space by simply blocking your calendar. This is similar to the technique at work of blocking time on your calendar to do something that's not yet known or defined. There's a need to build in a buffer between commitments and avoid running from one event to another back-to-back. If possible, try to have an unscheduled free day each week to do whatever comes up.

During your white space time, take note of how it makes you feel. Some might feel uncomfortable since they're more used to scurrying around and accomplishing something, while others feel like it's not productive. This is not being lazy or unproductive, but practicing maintenance. This practice will allow you to breathe and prevent burnout. Try to plan for white space in your schedule to protect your family's well-being.

Financial Decluttering

The source of physical clutter is often driven by financial clutter. For some, buying material items may make them feel better, and those useless purchases incur a sunk cost. There's a reluctance to discard them due to the sunk cost, leading to physical clutter. Decluttering can reverse this and lead to better financial habits through the discipline you developed in evaluating your possessions and future spending habits.

Subscription Audit

From a monetary standpoint, you should review and get a handle on your subscriptions. Subscriptions by their nature are designed to be forgotten. The automatic payment plan is used by the vendors to maximize their recurring revenue. Once you subscribe, the tendency is to forget you have the service and continue to pay the ongoing fee. The charges might seem small (for one forgotten service, maybe ten dollars per month), which isn't enough to raise red flags. But over the year, these amounts add up. If there are multiple subscriptions, these amounts add up.

Look through your bank records and credit card statements for recurring charges. When you notice subscriptions, examine to see if you are actively using that subscription and cancel those you are not using.

The common subscription culprits are streaming services, gym memberships, software, and even storage units. If you're paying for a storage unit, you should consider if it's worthwhile. Typically, storage units could cost a few hundred dollars per month. Perhaps it's time to declutter that unit and potentially cancel it.

The Shopping Pause

For those larger nonessential items you think you want to purchase, try implementing a shopping delay or pause before their purchase. Perhaps wait thirty days before purchasing. Most often, the need or desire for the item fades.

Each potential purchase should be examined through a series of questions to vet its need. Assess if there's space for the item. Is the item a duplicate? Will the item be used daily or weekly, or is it an aspirational item? Remember, aspirational items rarely get used. You probably trashed or donated many in the decluttering process.

Try to determine your shopping triggers. Was it because of a sale or a deal that you saw, but there was no real need for the product? Is it simply social pressure—your friends had it, so you needed to obtain a similar item?

Some behaviors might stave off the need to shop. Delete those shopping apps from your phone and unsubscribe from those retail emails. Perhaps try to rediscover what you have at home and can make use of rather than buying new things.

Budgeting as Space Making

Give some consideration to where you spend your money. It could be on experiences or on material items. There's evidence to support that experiences bring more lasting happiness than material possessions. When purchasing material possessions, invest in high-quality items rather than lower-quality and cheaper items. The cheaper fast fashion and disposable items cause clutter in the long term.

Take some time to recognize that, for most, money is finite. If you spend more on material possessions, there's less to spend on experience. This realization should drive your spending patterns.

Relationship and Commitment Decluttering

This is an area where you want to tread more lightly. It's about being more intentional about where you want to spend your energy socializing. Your energy is finite. You want to spend your energy on relationships that are nourishing rather than draining.

Energy Vampires Versus Energy Givers

Naturally, there will be people who energize you and those who drain your energy. Those who drain you might leave you feeling fatigued or burnt out after interacting with them. You want to limit your time with those who constantly drain your energy.

Set boundaries with those constantly draining your energy and moderate your interactions. Sometimes you might phase out of draining relationships; they naturally fade away. Other times, you'll need to cut them off abruptly. Investing your energy in relationships should be somewhat reciprocal, both giving and receiving energy.

Audit Your Social Commitments

Take inventory of your social commitments. Perhaps you attend or host some events out of obligation. If these aren't enjoyable, then bow out of them. Are you involved in some group chats that constantly ping notifications and stress you out? Consider muting them or leaving them altogether.

People evolve, and friendships may change over time based on your life chapter. Some friends might have different interests and walk different paths, which can cause relationships to change. Focus your energy on those relationships that matter the most.

Creating Space for What Matters

When you remove irrelevant items from your life, whether physical, digital, financial, or relational, you create space for things that align with your values. This is, in effect, the goal. This book was about creating that space.

Identify Your Core Values

You should have a good understanding of your core values. Some typical core values might be family connection, health, creativity, learning, financial security, and meaningful work. Determine your top three to five values and let these guide your decisions.

For example, let's say acquiring family connections is a core value. If you work late every night and are on your phone during dinner, then there's a conflict. Some possible decluttering solutions would be to stop reading emails after 7 PM, have phone-free dinners, and set aside other time for the family.

As another example, if health is a core value but you don't cook or go to the gym and experience chronic stress, then there's a problem. Some possible solutions are to create home-cooked meals, cancel the gym membership, and work out using an app at home.

Building a Life, Not Just an Organized Home

We started with decluttering, physical decluttering—that was the catalyst. The real transformation is to live with intention. Your choices about what to buy, spend time on, and commit to are anchored on whether these items serve you today.

There's a cascading effect from these actions. A clear home leads to a clear mind, which leads to better decisions, which results in a more peaceful life aligned with your values.

The Practice of Mindful Living

The practice of choosing awareness, intention, and alignment is not about perfection; it's about consistency. You're making small choices aligned with an intention. Sometimes this will be hard, as there will be work, family emergencies, health issues, and the list goes on. The skills you built protect you from the chaos. You can reset, reevaluate, and level set.

Allow yourself to grow and evolve, as this is inevitable. Revisit the space, commitments, and boundaries you set regularly because you're growing and things change. Stay intentional yet flexible.

Remember, your life is a book full of chapters. Now you've completed the decluttering chapter and turned the page. The new chapter is intentional living. As you move forward, you'll turn more pages, and a new chapter will emerge. The skills you've built up ensure you have clarity and can adapt to the transition.

Living Lightly, Living Well

Your journey started with clutter, overwhelming physical clutter. Now, you have a philosophy for living. It's more than the transformation of the organized closets and clear counters. You gained time through the systems you created and the reduced maintenance routines. You have more clarity about the things you value and are willing to protect them. Now, you have reduced anxiety and more mental space.

The solution is not to create a better organizational system; it's to have less to organize. This is the simple truth. It's not about more containers, more unique organizing products, or a bigger house; it is about having less stuff.

Before the decluttering journey, you probably felt guilty about not being organized enough, ashamed of the clutter, and exhausted

with the constant battle with the mess. After this journey, you feel more at peace with your space, guilt-free from unused possessions. It was never about you; it was always about the stuff.

Clutter is a result of the modern consumer culture combined with busy lives. It's not a failure but a product of being too busy with work, kids, life, and stuff. You learned that letting go of things is not wasteful, whereas keeping things wastes space, energy, and peace.

You have permission to release aspirational items. Systems beat willpower, and the decision framework eliminates decision fatigue. The maintenance routines are designed to prevent backsliding. Your success comes from preparation, not from better organization.

This really is a "less is more" situation. If you have fewer clothes, then getting dressed is easier. If there are fewer dishes, then cleanup is faster. If there are fewer toys, then the existing toys get more play time. If there are fewer commitments, then you focus more on those that matter. Your home should reflect your life, not an aspiration. Your home should be a place of rest, not a storage unit.

Living Lightly Going Forward

The concept of mindful living is choosing to live with awareness, intention, and alignment instead of being on autopilot. It's not a destination but a daily practice. Inevitably, there will be mistakes. Since you've reached the end of this book, you've gained the tools to pivot and reset. Now you can stop clutter before it begins to accumulate and overwhelm.

By now, you have some built-in guardrails to prevent clutter. Analytically, you can assess if a particular item is useful to your current life. The one-in, one-out rule actively prevents accumulation. The nightly resets and morning routine help maintain order. We've

established that it's okay to say no to commitments, and this protects your time and energy. These guardrails will propel you forward.

Don't forget that life happens, and you might fall off the wagon. This does not mean you failed. Children get sick, work gets busy, family needs change, and the list goes on. Draw on the reset techniques found in the book, put the place back in order, and reestablish your routines. Remember that it was not about perfection but about creating something functional and peaceful.

You have created a home that is supportive rather than stressing you out. Your possessions serve a purpose rather than creating a burden. This came about not by becoming a different person but by creating different systems, not by working harder but by owning less, and not by organizing more but by releasing more.

Welcome home. Welcome home to a mindful, intentional, clutter-free life!

A NOTE FROM ME TO YOU

If this book helped you breathe a little easier, find your keys a little faster, or finally let go of something that was weighing you down—I would be so grateful if you would take two minutes to leave a review on Amazon.

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Every review helps another overwhelmed person find this book at exactly the moment they need it most. Even a sentence or two makes a world of difference.

Thank you for trusting me with your home and your journey.

Now go enjoy the calm you've created.

You've earned it.

APPENDIX

COMPANION RESOURCES

Download Your Complete Decluttering Toolkit

1. Master Decluttering Tracker
2. Preparation Checklist
3. Three-Question Clutter Killer
4. Complete Room by Room Checklist
5. 30 Day Maintenance Tracker

You can download the Companion Resources here:
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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

ALEX LEE is a home organization advocate dedicated to helping busy people create peaceful, clutter-free spaces. Navigating the beautiful chaos of marriage, three kids, and a demanding career, Alex knows that perfection is a myth, but order is achievable. Through practical strategies and proven systems, Alex guides readers toward homes that support mental clarity and reduce daily stress.